

Demon Copperhead



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF BARBARA KINGSOLVER

Barbara Kingsolver is the author of more than 10 novels, many of which center on themes of social justice, as well as numerous nonfiction and poetry books. She grew up in rural Kentucky, where her father was a physician. She attended DePauw on a music scholarship but decided to study biology after realizing how competitive the job field would be for a classical pianist. While at college, she participated in anti-war protests during the Vietnam War. Kingsolver began as a nonfiction writer at the University of Arizona, and she wrote a book about a 1983 mine strike in the state, which would later be published in 1989 as *Holding the Line: Women in the Great Arizona Mine Strike of 1983*. Initially unable to find a publisher for *Holding the Line*, Kingsolver turned her attention to an unfinished novel, which became her first book, *The Bean Trees* (1988). Throughout her career, Kingsolver has won the Women's Prize for Fiction twice as well as the National Humanities Medal, among many other prizes and awards. Her most recent novel, *Demon Copperhead* (2022), won the 2023 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction. Kingsolver also established the Bellwether Prize for Fiction, which is awarded to first-time writers whose novels address social justice themes. Kingsolver currently lives in Washington County, Virginia, part of the Appalachian region.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Demon Copperhead focuses on how the coal mining industry and the opioid epidemic have impacted the Appalachian region of the United States. Coal mining was once one of the dominant industries in Appalachia, with the mining industry contributing to significant economic growth in the region. However, around 1985, surface mining began to replace underground mining as the industry's preferred method of coal extraction, and this caused the number of coal jobs dropped roughly 50% in the region. With fewer opportunities for employment, Appalachia became one of the most impoverished places in the country. Mining also left many workers ill or physically debilitated, and studies have linked attempts to treat the physical impairments people suffered as a result of mining to an increase in opioid use in the region. The opioid epidemic—an ongoing crisis dating back to 1990 that has led to an increase in overdose deaths in the U.S. as well as an increase in the abuse and misuse of drugs classified as opioids—has especially impacted Appalachia. In 2021, the rate of overdose deaths in Appalachia was 72% higher in Appalachia than in other parts of the country. Purdue Pharma introduced OxyContin—the drug that Dr. Watts prescribes Demon in the novel—in the U.S. in the late 1990s,

marking the drug as safe and effective despite evidence that it could be addictive. OxyContin and other opioid painkillers were subsequently overprescribed throughout the U.S., leaving people to develop a dependency on the drug. From 1999 to 2016, an estimated 450,000 Americans died from opioid use.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Kingsolver's works often address themes of social justice, including her first novel, *The Bean Trees*, which touches on the topics of motherhood, Native American parental rights, and the struggles of undocumented immigrants in the U.S. *The Poisonwood Bible*, perhaps Kingsolver's most well-known novel, tells the story of a Christian missionary family that travels from the U.S. to what is now the Democratic Republic of the Congo to address themes of sexism, misogyny, racism, and U.S. imperialism. *Demon Copperhead* is a retelling of Charles Dickens's *David Copperfield*. In addition to borrowing plot structures, characters, and character dynamics from *David Copperfield*, *Demon Copperhead* is also indebted to Dickens's understanding of literature as a tool for social good. *Suttree* by Cormac McCarthy touches on similar themes as *Demon Copperhead*, including addiction and criminal activity. In addition, the novel is set in Knoxville, a city often visited and referenced in *Demon Copperhead*. *Demon Copperhead* also seems to be in conversation with several contemporary works. In some ways, the novel can be seen as a rejoinder to the portrait of Appalachia presented in J. D. Vance's 2016 book *Hillbilly Elegy*. *Demon Copperhead* draws a comparison between the caste system of India and social hierarchies in the U.S., similar to Isabel Wilkerson's book *Caste: The Origins of Our Discontents*, which portrays racism in the U.S. as being part of a caste system.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Demon Copperhead
- **When Published:** 2022
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Appalachia from the 1990s into the early 2000s
- **Climax:** Demon, Maggot, and Hammer go to Devil's Bathtub so that Hammer can confront Fast Forward about stealing Emmy from him and then treating her badly. The altercation leads to Hammer's and Fast Forward's deaths.
- **Antagonist:** Opioid manufacturers; Coal companies; Stoner; Fast Forward
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Prize Winner. *Demon Copperhead* won the Women's Prize for Fiction, making Kingsolver the first (and as of now only) person to win the award twice—her book *The Lacuna* previously won the award in 2010. *Demon Copperhead* also won the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction, sharing the 2023 honors with Hernan Diaz's *Trust*.

Inspiration. *Demon Copperhead* is based on Charles Dickens's book [David Copperfield](#) with many plot points and characters borrowed from Dickens. Kingsolver says that she was inspired to write *Demon Copperhead* after an ethereal visit from Charles Dickens; Kingsolver was staying in Dickens's home when, Kingsolver claims, he came to her and told her, "Look, nobody in my time wanted to hear about these orphans either, and I made them listen." After that, she began to write *Demon Copperhead*.



PLOT SUMMARY

Damon Fields tells the story of his life from birth to adulthood. Damon was born in Lee County, which is located in the Appalachian region of Virginia. His nickname, **Demon Copperhead**, is a play on "Damon." Copperhead comes from his father's nickname, and it's also a reference to Demon's red hair.

Demon and his mom live in a trailer owned by the Peggots, who live next door. Matthew Peggot, whom everyone calls Maggot, is around Demon's age and is Demon's best friend. Demon is often in and out of the Peggot house, and the Peggots serve as a kind of surrogate family for Demon.

When Demon is a boy, Demon's mother becomes involved with a man named Stoner. Stoner is vituperative, strict, and abusive to both Mom and Demon. He tells Demon he can't spend time with Maggot because he suspects Maggot is gay. Whenever Stoner is around, Mom seems to shrink into the background. One day Mom overdoses on **painkillers**, and Demon is assigned a caseworker from the Department of Social Services (DSS), Miss Barks. Unable to live with Mom while she's in recovery, Miss Barks finds Demon a temporary foster care placement at a farm belonging to a man named Mr. Crickson. At Crickson's farm, Demon lives with Mr. Crickson's other foster children, Tommy and Fast Forward. Tommy is kind and caring, while Fast Forward is the larger-than-life quarterback of the high school football team. Crickson takes the boys out of school to do manual labor on the farm.

On Demon's eleventh birthday, Miss Barks calls him and tells him that his mom has died of an overdose. Demon doesn't know whether her death was a suicide or an accident. He also doesn't know where he's going to live now that Mom has died. That Christmas, he accompanies the Peggots to nearby Knoxville. In Knoxville, Demon sees Aunt June who has adopted her niece, Emmy, after Emmy's dad died. Emmy and Demon spend many

nights staying up late and commiserating.

When Demon returns to Lee County, Miss Barks finds him a new foster family, the McCobbs. Mr. McCobb insists that Demon pay rent, even though the state pays the McCobbs for fostering him, and even though Demon is just a child. He finds Demon a job in a makeshift dump behind a convenience store and orders Damon to pick through the trash pile to find things they might be able to sell. Damon is also tasked with draining the acid from batteries. After a while, he begins to suspect that he might be working for a meth lab. At school, Demon the other kids make fun of Damon for being poor. Damon's time with the McCobbs ends when the McCobbs, facing financial difficulties, decide to move to Ohio to be with Mrs. McCobb's family.

Facing more uncertainty about his future, Demon decides to track down the remaining family that he's aware of. He hitchhikes to Murder Valley, Tennessee, to find his paternal grandmother, Betsy Woodall, whom he only knows through the stories Mom would tell. When he arrives, he discovers that Betsy has taken in and raised 11 girls—only girls—through the years, and that she lives with her brother, Mr. Dick. Betsy decides to try and help Demon find a better foster placement. She remembers that one of the girls she raised married someone in Lee County before she died. Betsy makes the necessary calls and then Demon goes back to Lee County to live with Coach Winfield and Coach Winfield's daughter, Angus.

In Lee County, Demon's life takes a turn for the better. Demon gets along with Coach Winfield and Angus. He excels at school and is eventually enrolled in the gifted and talented program. He also starts taking lessons from the art teacher at the local high school, who encourages him to pursue his passion for drawing.

Coach Winfield also takes an interest in Demon's football ability, thinking that he'll make a good tight end. The summer after eighth grade, Demon goes to summer football training camp, and when he enters high school, he quickly becomes a star on the team. Coach Winfield's assistant, U-Haul, seems strangely jealous of Demon and corners him one night to tell him that he's not really family to Coach Winfield or Angus and that he shouldn't get too comfortable in their home.

Around this time, Demon reconnects with Fast Forward, and the two begin to spend more time together. However, Demon starts to suspect that there might be something a little sinister about Fast Forward that he didn't notice when he first met him.

In October of his sophomore year, Demon injures his knee during a football game. A doctor named Dr. Watts comes to see him and writes him a prescription for Lortab, an opioid. Demon starts playing football again four weeks later, but he's on a heavy regiment of painkillers by then. When he tries to wean himself off the painkillers, he experiences symptoms of withdrawal that seem even worse than the pain itself. Around this time, Demon meets Dori and falls in love with her almost

instantly. He's surprised when, on their first date, she gets high on fentanyl—and shares some with Demon.

When football season ends, Coach tells Demon that it's time to get off the painkillers. Demon tries, but he keeps experiencing withdrawal symptoms. He and Dori continue to do drugs together, including pills, and Demon also begins smoking heroin. Around this time, Demon reconnects with Tommy, who is working at a local newspaper. Tommy remembers the comics Demon used to draw, and the two begin working on a weekly comic strip together for the local paper. Emmy, meanwhile, leaves her long-time love interest, Hammer, to run away with Fast Forward.

Dori's dad, who has been battling cancer, dies that winter, and Demon isn't sure if Dori will ever recover from her grief. Demon feels like he's overstayed his welcome at the Winfield's house, so when Dori asks him to live with her, he accepts. Dori begins doing fentanyl and heroin more often, and Demon comes home to find her overdosing at least five times. When Dori becomes pregnant, Demon hopes that it might provide Dori with the motivation she needs to stay sober, but Dori continues to struggle with addiction and later loses the baby.

Sometime later, U-Haul tries to blackmail Angus into having sex with him. He accuses Coach Winfield of embezzling funds meant for the football team and threatens to expose the supposed illegal activity. When Demon goes to help Angus, she tells him that U-Haul has overseen bookkeeping for years and has been putting some of the football team's money into his mother's bank account each month.

One afternoon in April, Demon returns home and discovers that Dori has died of an overdose. With nowhere else to go, Demon lives out of Dori's old car. When he's with Maggot one day, they see Hammer with a flat tire on the side of the road. They pick him up, and Hammer grabs his rifle from his car. When Hammer hears that Fast Forward is at Devil's Bathtub, a waterfall outside of town, Hammer orders Demon and Maggot to drive him there so he can confront Fast Forward about stealing Emmy from him and then treating her poorly. They agree. At the waterfall, Hammer and Fast Forward get into a violent altercation. When Hammer threatens Fast Forward with his rifle, Fast Forward dives from the cliff but slips and lands on the rocks. He dies on impact. Hammer dives into the water to try to save Fast Forward, but the current sweeps him away, and he drowns.

Because he gave Hammer drugs, Maggot ends up being charged as an accessory to his death and goes to juvenile detention. Aunt June tells Demon that she'll help put him through rehab, and Demon moves to Knoxville to enter rehab and get sober. After three years away, Demon returns to Lee County. He reconnects with Angus, who he realizes might have feelings for him. As they drive together to see [the ocean](#), which Demon has always wanted to see, he thinks that he might have feelings for Angus, too.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Demon Copperhead – Demon, born Damon Fields, is the novel's protagonist. He is based on David Copperfield from Dickens's novel, [David Copperfield](#). Demon is born in a trailer to a young mother (Mom) who is addicted to drugs. After she dies from an overdose, the Department of Social Services (DSS) shuffles Demon from one foster care placement to another, and he ultimately becomes addicted to painkillers himself. Throughout the novel, Demon struggles to overcome the circumstances of his birth—poverty, generational trauma, and his mother's addiction, which he ultimately inherits. He serves as an example of the hardships that people in Appalachia face as a result of external forces like inadequate social services, poverty, and a lack of employment opportunities. Demon's character, in particular, helps illustrate the harm caused by pharmaceutical companies that targeted the Appalachian region and overprescribed [opioids](#) they knew to be addictive. Demon is orphaned by the predatory practices of those pharmaceutical companies when his mom dies, and then his girlfriend, Dori, also dies from an overdose. It seems like Demon might follow suit, but ultimately, through hard work and the help of his community, he manages to get sober and embark on a new chapter of his life—a chapter he'll be able to write on his own terms, without the inherited traumas of his past limiting his opportunities.

Demon's Mom – Demon's mom is young when she has Demon. During Demon's childhood, Mom works at Walmart and tries, at various times, to enter recovery from addiction. After she becomes involved in an abusive relationship, one overdose sends her to the hospital, and she later dies after overdosing a second time. Mom is an example of the human cost of pharmaceutical companies' predatory practices. While those companies advocated for the overprescription of addictive medication in the name of profits, Mom's character shows that those companies lost sight of the human cost of their profit-seeking behavior. Ultimately, such predatory practices leave children like Demon orphaned and vulnerable to future abuses. Mom is also an example of the harms of abusive relationships and intimate partner violence. While Stoner's violence doesn't kill Mom directly, the novel suggests that the abuse she suffered at Stoner's hands contributed to her early death.

Maggot – Maggot, born Matt Peggot, is Demon's closest friend growing up. They spend days together playing in the nearby creek, and Demon seems to spend as much time at Maggot's house as his own. When Mom becomes involved with Stoner, Stoner forbids Demon from spending time with Maggot because he suspects that Maggot is gay. In some respects, Maggot serves as an example of the discrimination and prejudice that people from the LGBTQ+ community can face in

Appalachia. However, as Maggot becomes unhappier and struggles with drugs and addiction, his grandparents who raised him, Mr. and Mrs. Peggot, say they just want him to be happy and don't care about his sexual orientation. Notably, while people like Stoner discriminate against Maggot, Maggot doesn't seem to face significant prejudice or discrimination at school. By the end of the novel, after spending time in juvenile detention, Maggot has a boyfriend and is sober, presenting another example of how, despite setbacks and hardships, a person's community can help them overcome their personal struggles.

Stoner – Murrell Stone, nicknamed Stoner, is Mom's boyfriend who is physically and verbally abusive to Mom and Demon. After Mom dies from an overdose, Demon becomes convinced that she had returned to drugs in part to cope with the pain that came along with her relationship with Stoner. The novel depicts Stoner as a textbook example of toxic masculinity. He is quick to anger, unreflective, prone to violence, and discriminates against Maggot because he suspects Maggot is gay. There are moments during Demon's relationship with Dori when the novel seems to intimate that Demon might be at risk of inheriting some of Stoner's harmful behaviors, as when Demon breaks the TV when he is angry at Dori for always watching it. After Dori dies, though, instead of continuing down a path toward more and more toxic masculinity, Demon pursues sobriety and opens himself up to his emotions in a way that Stoner never would.

Mrs. Peggot – Nance Peggot, more often referred to as Mrs. Peggot, is Maggot's grandmother who, along with Mr. Peggot, helps raise Maggot after his mother is sent to prison. The novel portrays Mrs. Peggot as kind and caring, and she and her husband become a surrogate family to Demon. When he is a young child, Demon even calls her mammaw, thinking that she is, in some ways, his own grandmother. The Peggots decline to take Demon in after Mom dies, though, because they are already exhausted from raising Maggot. Even though Mrs. Peggot doesn't take Demon in, she and her family are some of the most devoted members of the community who look after Demon after his immediate family is no longer around to do so.

Mr. Peggot – Mr. Peggot, Mrs. Peggot's husband, is a kind and patient man. He becomes Maggot's adoptive father after Maggot's mother is sent to prison. He helps raise Demon, too, and Demon has fond memories of the times when Mr. Peggot would take him and Maggot fishing when they were children. He sustained a leg injury while working in the mines and has not walked easily since, showing the impact that working in the mines could have on people in the Appalachian region.

Emmy – Emmy is the daughter of Humvee, who passed away before the novel takes place. After Humvee died, the Peggots took in Emmy. When Maggot's mom was sent to prison, though, the Peggots couldn't raise two children, so Emmy went to live with her aunt June in Knoxville. June eventually formally

adopts Emmy. Emmy is depicted as smart and wise beyond her years, but she runs into trouble when she meets Fast Forward, who eventually enlists her in his drug dealing and smuggling schemes. Emmy, who seemed to be going down a "straight and narrow" both in Knoxville, becomes a stark example, then, of how the pressures and difficulties of one's environment—in this case, the Appalachian region of Virginia—can completely alter one's path in life.

Aunt June – June is Maggot and Emmy's aunt who becomes Emmy's adoptive mother. June is a nurse in Knoxville who then moves back to Lee County to be closer to her family. She dates a pharmaceutical representative, Kent, who pushes for more widespread use of **opioid** painkillers. June soon comes to see the harm that opioids are doing to people in Lee County and blames Kent, along with the pharmaceutical companies, for all the harm the opioid epidemic has done to her hometown. As a nurse in a local clinic, she sees firsthand the impacts of opioid addiction, and she becomes a vocal critic of pharmaceutical companies. She also steps in to help both Demon and Emmy when they are at their lowest and then financially supports their journeys to sobriety. She is portrayed, then, as one of the most community-minded people in the novel: as someone who is always ready to help others when they are in need.

Angus – Angus, born Agnes Winfield, is Coach Winfield's daughter. She does well in school and initially plans to leave Lee County to go to a four-year college as soon as possible. She is portrayed as steadfastly unique and self-assured and as someone who cares deeply about Demon. Angus supports Demon in whatever he wants in life and is also honest with him when she feels that he is making mistakes and derailing his life. At the end of the novel, after Demon has become sober, he realizes that he and Angus have feelings for each other.

Fast Forward – Fast Forward is the larger-than-life football star who Demon first meets at Crickson's farm. At first, Fast Forward seems charming to everyone who meets him, and Demon thinks of him as a kind of real-life superhero. As the novel progresses, though, this charming façade peels away to reveal a darker, more sinister personality. One character who grew up with Fast Forward, Rose Dartell, says that as children, Fast Forward would try to hurt or kill her and her siblings and seemed to feel no empathy or remorse about it. When Demon reconnects with Fast Forward later, Demon gradually learns that Fast Forward deals heroin and other drugs. Emmy leaves her long-time love interest, Hammer, for Fast Forward, which ultimately results in the confrontation between Hammer and Fast Forward that leaves both dead.

Coach Winfield – Coach Winfield is the widower of one of the girls Betsy. After Demon finds Betsy, she identifies Coach as someone who might help raise Demon and arranges for Demon to live with Coach and Coach's daughter, Angus. Coach is a hands-off parent to both Demon and Angus, but he also cares deeply about them both. He lives, eats, and breathes football

and (correctly) identifies Demon as a potential star tight-end, which Demon loves. Coach struggles with alcoholism, though, and his own difficulties with addiction might account for his failure to provide adequate care to Demon when he is injured during a game. Dr. Watts later prescribes Demon a regiment of **opioids** that ultimately causes Demon to have his own issues with addiction.

Dori – Dori is Demon's girlfriend. They meet when Dori comes into the feed store where Demon works during his sophomore year of high school. Demon is almost instantly in love. The two begin dating, and Demon is surprised to learn that Dori is a heavy user of **opioids**, which are prescribed to her father Vester, who is dying of cancer. While the novel depicts the love between Demon and Dori as genuine, they are ultimately destructive influences on each other, and they experience some of the darkest moments of addiction together. Ultimately, Dori dies of an overdose, becoming another casualty of the opioid epidemic and another shattering loss that Demon must learn to cope with.

Tommy Waddell – Tommy is one of the foster boys whom Demon meets at Mr. Crickson's farm. The novel portrays Tommy as a sweet, kind, caring, and gentle person. Demon loses contact with Tommy for a while, but when the two reconnect, Tommy is working at the local newspaper. Tommy remembers the comics Demon would draw on the farm, and the two of them begin to work on a weekly comic for the newspaper.

Betsy Woodall – Betsy is Demon's paternal grandmother. Betsy is suspicious and distrustful of men, and the novel intimates that she survived an abusive relationship when she was younger. She is deeply invested in her community and has helped raise more than 11 girls who didn't have homes. She lives with her brother, Dick, and one of the girls she is raising, Jane Ellen. Another one of those girls grew up to marry Coach Winfield before dying of cancer, and Betsy helps facilitate Demon's foster placement in Coach's house. Betsy never takes money from DSS or any other social service agency, believing that those agencies are corrupt and serve themselves more than the people they claim to help.

Dr. Watts – Dr. Watts is the doctor for the football team. After Demon injures his leg during a game, Dr. Watts prescribes him a regiment of painkillers that leads to Demon becoming addicted to **opioids**. Later in the novel, Demon learns that Dr. Watts is the doctor at a pill mill, a kind of pain management clinic that will write prescriptions for anyone who pays for one. When Dori goes to Dr. Watts to get him to write an opioid prescription after her father Vester has died, he tells her that he'll write one if she has sex with him. Dori refuses, and Demon is furious at the doctor for trying to exploit her.

Kent – Kent is Aunt June's boyfriend who is a pharmaceutical representative. Kent's job consists of trying to get doctors to prescribe **opioid** painkillers more often. As Aunt June sees

more and more of the damage that opioids have done to Appalachia, she comes to think of Kent and the pharmaceutical companies he represents as murderers.

Hammerhead Kelly – Hammerhead Kelly (called Hammer) is a cousin in the Peggot family, related through marriage. He harbors a long-time infatuation with Emmy, and the two ultimately begin dating. Not long after, though, Emmy leaves Hammer for Fast Forward. Hammer takes the breakup hard, and it seems like he might never recover. He decides to confront Fast Forward about how he has hurt Emmy, and that confrontation results in both Hammer and Fast Forward's deaths.

Miss Barks – Miss Barks is one of Demon's case managers through the Department of Social Services (DSS). She finds Demon various foster placements and secures the social security payment for Demon that he's entitled to receive once he turns 18. She ultimately leaves DSS, though, to pursue her dream of becoming a teacher.

Mr. Crickson – Mr. Crickson is the foster parent whom Demon first goes to live with after Mom overdoses. The novel portrays him as strict, mean, and exploitative, as he forces his foster children to work long hours on his farm, even taking them out of school to do so. When Demon first goes to live on the farm, there are three other foster boys there: Swap-Out, Tommy, and Fast Forward, and Demon forms relationships with them that last past their time on Crickson's farm.

Mr. McCobb – Mr. McCobb is one of Demon's foster parents. Even though the McCobbs receive money each month for fostering Demon, Mr. McCobb insists that Demon work to pay rent in their house, and he finds Demon a job at the trash pile behind the convenience store. The novel portrays Mr. McCobb and his family as opportunists who try to exploit the foster care system to earn extra money, and it cynically implies that the McCobbs' behavior is not unique and that such exploitation is common in the foster system.

Mrs. McCobb – Mrs. McCobb is one of Demon's foster parents. The McCobbs make Demon stay in a back area of the house—the space is filthy, and Demon suspects that the McCobb family dog used to sleep there before Demon arrived. Mrs. McCobb makes Demon go into pawn shops with her things to try and sell them because she thinks that might give him a better deal than they would give her.

Dick – Dick is Betsy's brother and Demon's great-uncle. He uses a wheelchair to get around and is doted on by Betsy and Jane Ellen. Dick is a thoughtful, caring person who is obsessed with books. He makes kites and fills the fabric with handwritten quotes from the books he's reading. Demon and Dick develop a close bond while Demon is living at Betsy's house.

U-Haul – U-Haul, born Ryan Pyles, is Coach Winfield's assistant who will later become an assistant football coach. U-Haul is jealous of the attention Demon gets from Coach and is

sexually interested in Angus, who is a teenager. He's a lascivious, exploitative person who ultimately tries to blackmail Angus into having sex with him by claiming that Coach has been embezzling funds meant for the football team and threatening to expose him. Demon helps subdue U-Haul before he can harm Angus, and he learns that U-Haul the one who has been embezzling money.

Mr. Armstrong – Mr. Armstrong is an English teacher at Demon's middle school. He recognizes that Demon is a strong student and recommends him to the gifted and talented program. He is known as a truth-teller at the school and as someone who is almost impossible to dislike. Mr. Armstrong also arranges for Demon to study art at the high school with his wife, Ms. Annie. Ms. Annie and Mr. Armstrong face racism and prejudice as people spread rumors about them because Ms. Annie is white and Mr. Armstrong is Black.

Ms. Annie – Ms. Annie is the art teacher at the high school. In middle school, Demon studies with her twice a week. She encourages Demon to pursue his talent for drawing. Demon describes Ms. Annie as a hippie, and he also develops a childish crush on her. Ms. Annie is married to Mr. Armstrong, one of Demon's middle school English teachers. Ms. Annie and Mr. Armstrong face racism and discrimination in town when people spread rumors about them and their marriage because Ms. Annie is white and Mr. Armstrong is Black.

Mr. Ghali – Mr. Ghali is the owner of Golly's Market. When Demon lives with the McCobbs, he works at the trash heap behind Golly's Market. The trash heap is run separately from the market, and Demon fears he may be working for a meth lab. When he works at the trash pile, Demon often goes into the market and talks with Mr. Ghali, who seems to make extra food for him and the other people who work on the trash pile. Mr. Ghali tells Demon about his own experiences working on a trash pile while growing up in India. He describes growing up as a Dalit, the lowest rank of the caste system in India, and considered an "untouchable." Demon uses Mr. Ghali's description of discrimination and prejudice within a caste-based system to understand the ostracization and prejudice he faces in his own life, as well as class discrimination in the U.S. more broadly.

Rose Dartell – Rose Dartell is one of Fast Forward's friends, though Fast Forward seems to treat her only with contempt. Rose seems jealous of Demon for the attention that Fast Forward gives him. Rose tells Demon that her family adopted Fast Forward when they were both children, but Fast Forward would frequently hurt the other children and never show empathy or remorse.

Vester – Vester is Dori's father. When he is undergoing treatment for cancer, Dori takes his leftover prescription painkillers and sells them so she can buy herself more **opioids** and other drugs she prefers. Vester dies while Demon and Dori

are dating, and Demon is not sure that Dori will ever recover from his death. Demon's prediction proves heartbreakingly accurate, as Dori dies of an overdose not long after Vester's death.

Martha – Martha is Maggot's friend, but Emmy also spends time for her. All three are involved in heavy drug use, and Martha ends up staying at a "crack house" for a time. After Emmy disappears, June tasks Demon with tracking down Martha, who she believes might know where Emmy has gone. Although Demon does find Martha, she tries to throw herself from the car on the way to June's house, seemingly afraid to face June about whatever trouble Emmy is in.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Mariah Peggot – Mariah Peggot is Maggot's mother. She was sent to prison after assaulting Maggot's father, Romeo Blevins, with an X-Acto knife after enduring months of his physical abuse. Romeo lies during Mariah's trial and doesn't have to serve time, meanwhile Mariah is sent to prison.

Romeo Blevins – Romeo Blevins is Maggot's father. After suffering months of abuse at Romeo's hands, Maggot's mother assaults him with an X-Acto knife. Though her attack could be seen as a form of self-defense, Romeo lies during the trial, and the court sends Mariah to prison.

Humvee – Humvee is Emmy's dad and Mr. Peggot and Mrs. Peggot's son. He died under mysterious circumstances, and the Peggots try to avoid talking about him.

Swap-Out – Swap-Out is one of the foster boys whom Demon meets on Mr. Crickson's farm. Swap-Out later reappears as one of Demon's fellow workers at the trash pile behind the convenience store. Swap-Out is an expert climber, and the novel also intimates that he suffers from fetal alcohol syndrome.

Baggy Eyes – "Baggy Eyes" is the name that Demon gives to one of his other caseworkers at DSS. She is depicted throughout the novel as negligent and uncaring, content to accept the lies Demon's foster parents tell her.

Mattie Kate – Mattie Kate is the housekeeper at Coach Winfield's house. She cooks meals, does the laundry, and helps take care of the kids.

Big Bear Howe – Big Bear Howe is one of Fast Forward's closest friends. Big Bear played on the offensive line when Fast Forward was the quarterback on the high school team.

Mouse – Mouse is a makeup artist and one of Fast Forward's friends. She helps Fast Forward smuggle and deal drugs.

Haillie McCobb – Haillie is one of the children in the McCobb family. She is the only one who develops a sort of friendship with Demon and keeps Demon informed things that her parents won't tell him.

Pinkie – Pinkie is Tommy’s boss at the newspaper.

Jane Ellen – Jane Ellen is the eleventh of the 11 girls Betsy raised. She drives Demon to meet Coach Winfield for the first time. She, Betsy, and Mr. Dick visit Demon at Coach Winfield’s house every few months to see how he’s adjusting to living there.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



EXPLOITATION

Demon Copperhead shows how large institutions in the Appalachian region, including the coal industry, the pharmaceutical industry, and even the foster care system, exploit and overpower individual people like Demon, taking away their agency and their ability to control the trajectory of their own lives. Mr. Armstrong, one of Demon’s teachers, explains to Demon that coal companies structured their industry so that they owned the churches people attended, the schools their children went to, and the stores selling household goods. Those companies also made sure to shut down any other industry that tried to encroach on their territory. When coal mining in the region decreased, the companies left the people of Appalachia in poverty with nowhere to turn because they had pushed competing industries out of the region. The novel examines how pharmaceutical companies similarly exploited the region. While those companies knew that **opioid** painkillers were addictive, they advocated for increased use of those painkillers region without caring about the cost to human lives. When those pills were overprescribed, the resulting addiction wrecked people’s lives. In Demon’s case, both his mom and his girlfriend Dori die as a result of opioid addiction.

Kingsolver is careful to show, though, that many different kinds of institutions, not just corporations, exploit the people of Appalachia. When Demon is put in foster care, the people in charge of ensuring his wellbeing just as often do the opposite, including Mr. Crickson, who forces a ten-year-old Demon and other foster children to work excruciating hours on his farm, and Mr. McCobb, who makes Demon work in a trash pile so that Demon can pay rent. Just as pharmaceutical and coal companies exploit the people of Appalachia, then, so too does the inadequate foster system fail to provide kids like Demon with the support they need to flourish and take control of their own destinies. The novel shows, then, how institutional powers—in the Appalachian region and in general—exploit

individual people, rendering them powerless by limiting their opportunities to improve their lives and severely compromising their ability to dictate their own futures.



CLASS, SOCIAL HIERARCHY, AND STEREOTYPES

In the novel, Demon often describes himself as one of the “no-toucher” kinds of people. He takes the term from Mr. Ghali’s description of growing up in India as a Dalit, once known as an “untouchable,” a member of the lowest caste in India. In India, the caste system divides Hindu people into a hierarchy of five groups, or castes, with privileges reserved for those in the highest caste, while people in the lowest caste face social ostracization. While growing up in India, people of other castes refused to touch Mr. Ghali, and he is amazed to find that his caste status does not follow him to the United States. The novel contends, though, that a similar hierarchy operates in the U.S. In the U.S., the novel shows, society discriminates against people based on socioeconomic status. In particular, *Demon Copperhead* shows how after Demon’s mom dies and he goes into foster care, he feels socially ostracized in a way that reminds him of Mr. Ghali’s description of India’s caste system. When one of Demon’s foster families refuses to buy him new clothes, for instance, people at school move away from him and pretend to smell the air when he walks by.

The novel compares the social ostracization that Demon experiences throughout his life to the Hindu caste system to show how the stereotypes mainstream American culture attaches to people of a lower economic status, or who come from certain geographic regions, like Appalachia, perpetuate discrimination and limit people’s opportunities for upward social and economic mobility. In popular culture, people from Appalachia are stereotyped as being ignorant and lazy, with outsiders using insults like “redneck” or “hillbilly” to dehumanize and belittle them. The novel argues that these stereotypes preserve and perpetuate existing social and economic hierarchies and disregard the real problems that Appalachian communities face as a result of poverty, addiction, and other social ills. In using negative stereotypes to belittle and dehumanize Appalachian people, mainstream culture attempts to render Appalachian people “untouchable,” or inherently defective, and claim that the social ills that destroy Appalachian communities are the result of Appalachia’s inherent inferiority rather than the consequence of discriminatory and exploitative social and economic systems.



PAIN AND ADDICTION

Almost every character in *Demon Copperhead* struggles with addiction of one kind or another. Demon’s mom becomes addicted to pills and dies

from an overdose. Later, Dori, Demon's girlfriend, also dies of an overdose. Demon and his friends Emmy and Maggot also struggle with addiction throughout the novel. The novel argues that none of these characters choose to be addicted to various substances. Instead, the novel presents addiction as a very human—if unhealthy and ultimately catastrophic—approach to pain management.

That pain can be both physical and emotional. Demon, for example, first takes pills when Fast Forward gives them to him when he is 10 years old. But, according to Demon, Fast Forward isn't trying to make him addicted to anything or even to get him high. Instead, Fast Forward is acting out of kindness. He is trying to make the other foster boys—who have never felt meaningfully safe in their lives—feel safe and give them a place where they can feel like they belong. The pills, then, are offered as a kind of emotional balm. Demon then becomes addicted to painkillers when he is prescribed them to treat his pain after he suffers a knee injury in football. Dori and Mom both overdose and die while they are dealing with devastatingly painful circumstances in their lives. Before Dori overdoses, her father has just died, and she doesn't know how to continue without him. To try and find emotional relief, she turns more and more towards drugs. Demon's mom has found herself in an abusive relationship, and she cannot find a way out of that relationship or a way to protect Demon from Stoner's violence. She searches for escape from that hopelessness, then, in drugs and, possibly, suicide. While *Demon Copperhead* doesn't shy away from depicting the destructive realities of drug addiction, it also portrays characters who struggle with substance abuse in a sympathetic light, showing that they are often acting on the very human desire to alleviate pain and suffering and turn to drugs when there are no other readily available options.



TOXIC MASCULINITY

Demon Copperhead is, at its core, a coming-of-age story. In particular, it focuses on how Demon's exposure to toxic masculinity influences him over

the course of his formative years. Stoner, Mom's boyfriend when Demon was growing up, forbids Demon from spending time with Demon's friend Maggot because he thinks Maggot is gay. He also feels entitled to abuse Mom because he is a man and she is a woman. While Demon hates Stoner and everything he stands for, when Demon lives with his girlfriend Dori, he replicates, perhaps unconsciously, some of Stoner's most toxic behavior, including breaking a TV when he is angry that his girlfriend Dori won't stop watching it. Demon's behavior in this scene shows how deeply growing up in a culture of toxic masculinity has impacted him. The culture of toxic masculinity in which Demon grows up also teaches him to suppress his emotions. When Demon is in high school, he is severely injured during a football game, and he turns to painkillers to get back on the football field as soon as possible. He thinks, in part due

to the influence of people like Coach and Dr. Watts, that he must suppress his pain instead of listening to it and hearing what his body is trying to tell him. The mindset that men and boys must "push through pain" and suppress their emotions and vulnerabilities is one of the hallmarks of toxic masculinity, and it ultimately contributes to many of the issues that threaten to derail Demon's life.

To overcome his addiction, get back on track, and make the difficult transition from a harrowing childhood to stable adulthood, Demon must reckon with the trauma of his past—not ignore it, as the men in his life have repeatedly taught him to do. When Demon eventually enters a recovery program, he begins to acknowledge his pain, talk about his feelings, and embrace vulnerability. Doing so allows Demon to maintain his sobriety. At the end of the novel, Demon is over three years sober, and it's implied that he's about to embark on a stable, healthy, and lasting relationship with Angus. The novel shows, then, that toxic masculinity can inhibit men from healthily processing their emotions. When men and boys are exposed to environments where they're encouraged to acknowledge and process their emotions, however, they can counteract the harm that toxic masculinity causes and become healthy and well-adjusted friends, partners, and members of their communities.



COMMUNITY AND BELONGING

Throughout the novel, Demon struggles to find a sense of community and belonging. After Demon's mom dies, he feels isolated and abandoned. As he is

shuffled from foster home to foster home, he tries to find belonging with Fast Forward, Tommy, and Swap-Out, other boys who live in one of his foster homes. Later, when Demon goes to live with Coach and Angus, he searches for belonging on the football field. When the Peggots ask Demon to sit in the family section during Mr. Peggot's funeral, Demon feels "like somebody of worth," and this speaks to the strength and power that comes with having a community one can turn to in times of struggle. Demon thrives when he has a loving and supportive community, but his efforts to find belonging are repeatedly complicated by the fact that he often looks for community with people who might not have his best interests at heart or may not be able to adequately care for him. Fast Forward, for example, makes Demon feel special and cared for, but his involvement with drugs ultimately harms Demon and the people Demon cares about. And while Demon and Dori seem to be genuinely in love, their relationship fuels both of their addictions, and Demon goes through some of the darkest moments in his life when they are together.

Each time Demon sees a glimmer of hope in the novel, that hope comes in the form of community and belonging. With that in mind, it is not surprising that when Demon reaches his lowest point—after Dori, Hammer, and Fast Forward have all died—salvation comes from his extended community. June, a

member of Demon's surrogate family, the Peggots, steps in to offer him a way out of addiction by helping to pay for his rehab. Through her influence (and financial support), Demon goes to rehab, gets sober, and finally has all the tools he needs to work toward a brighter future. The novel argues, then, that while Demon repeatedly attempts to escape the trauma and suffering of his past to find a better future, he can't accomplish this alone. Instead, he experiences the most happiness and has the best chance at success when he is surrounded by strong communities of people who give him the love and support he needs to reach his personal goals.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



COPPERHEAD SNAKE

Copperhead snakes symbolize the stereotypes, caricatures, and inaccurate and harmful judgments that outsiders can attribute to given region and its inhabitants. Demon says that a bite from a copperhead, a venomous snake, can cause a person serious pain and can even lead them to lose a hand or foot. People who aren't from Demon's holler (a small mountain valley where people live) say that the place is rife with copperheads. In all Demon's time spent outdoors, though, he has never seen a single copperhead. "People love to believe in danger," Demon says, "as long as it's you in harm's way, and them saying bless your heart." According to Demon, people want to believe that his holler is dangerous because it makes them feel safer. The novel, through Demon, then, argues that people from outside Appalachia do a similar thing to the people of Appalachia when they rely on stereotypes instead of engaging with the people who live there and trying to understand the problems they face.

After Demon receives the nickname Demon Copperhead, he becomes like the myth of the copperheads in his holler. People who don't know him want to believe that Demon—and, by extension, people from Appalachia in general—are "copperheads" in the sense that they are, according to those stereotypes, dangerous: dangerously ignorant, dangerously addicted to drugs, or dangerously poor. The novel argues that these stereotypes are wholly inaccurate and even harmful. Through its depiction of Demon Copperhead as a complex character who doesn't fit the stereotypes that people from outside the region might try and pin on him, the novel dismantles those stereotypes and shows that while Demon may be named after a venomous snake, he is actually a vulnerable, caring, and complex person trying to find love and belonging.



OPIOID PAINKILLERS

Opioid painkillers symbolize strategies that people use to exploit others, showing how self-interest and greed are often hidden beneath a mask of benevolence to enable people in more powerful positions to take advantage of others. Aunt June's boyfriend, Kent, is a pharmaceutical rep in charge of marketing opioid painkillers. Kent claims that his company's mission is to eliminate suffering in patients who are in pain—and that painkillers are the way to do that. Notably, Kent does not say his company's mission is to make money. In reality, though, as June later points out, Kent's company knows its product is addictive and pushes doctors to prescribe it without caring about where that addiction might lead. June describes Kent as a "hired killer for his company," and the novel shows that June's assessment is true, as both Demon's mom and his girlfriend, Dori, die as a result of their addiction to opioid painkillers. The novel argues, then, that Kent's company—a stand-in for pharmaceutical giants like Purdue Pharma—markets painkillers with a message of compassion while preying on people, exploiting them, and often indirectly killing them, all in order to make a profit.

But opioids are only the latest in a long string of corporate marketing that uses benevolence as a mask for corporate greed. Coal and tobacco companies did the same thing to the people of Appalachia before the pharmaceutical companies. And in the novel, corporations aren't the only guilty parties. People like Mr. Crickson and the McCobbs exploit Demon and other foster children while claiming to be concerned with the wellbeing of those children to hide their true economic motivations. Even someone like Stoner hides his abuse of Demon behind a mask of good intentions, claiming that he is trying to teach Demon to be respectful and righteous. In this way, then, Demon Copperhead's portrayal of opioids symbolically illustrates a broader phenomenon of people (and corporations) using polished, crafty rhetoric and claims of good intentions to conceal their greed and their nefarious aims.



THE OCEAN

The ocean symbolizes the peace and tranquility that Demon hopes to cultivate in his own mind. Perhaps paradoxically, Demon finds that tranquility when he stops envisioning it as a specific destination and starts embracing his own journey. Demon describes the ocean as a place that is free from the chaos that characterizes his day-to-day life, and this is why he's so drawn to it. Throughout the novel, he makes various attempts to reach the ocean and, by extension, to find peace. However, he repeatedly encounters obstacles along the way.

In particular, his childhood trauma and ongoing struggles with addiction continue to plague him, standing in the way of his goal to make his mind resemble the tranquility of the ocean.

The ocean can also be understood, then, as a symbol of the tranquility and peace that *eludes* Demon when he turns to destructive outlets to find instant relief. At various points, Demon uses drugs to find respite from the disorder of his life. While those drugs give Demon a temporary feeling of the peace he's looking for, they ultimately lead to addiction and more "hectic nonsense." At this point in his life, Demon's suffering is so great that he is more concerned with dulling his pain than working through it. In other words, he wants to reach the peace and tranquility of this ocean but cannot yet undertake (or even acknowledge) the long and arduous journey it will take to get there.

After he becomes sober, Demon begins to find ways to make his own mind take on the tranquility of the ocean. At the end of the novel, Demon and Angus make one last trip to try and reach the sea. Demon says, "The trip itself, just getting there, possibly the best part of my life so far." Instead of thinking of the ocean as the ultimate destination, Demon chooses to embrace the journey it takes to get to the ocean rather than that destination itself, a change in mentality that has allowed Demon to find the peace and tranquility he has searched for all along.

birth. They "are marked," Demon explains, as people who will "win or lose." According to that idea, individuals' choices don't really matter because their lives are predetermined by fate.

Notably, Demon's philosophy challenges the myth of the American Dream, which claims that a person only needs to work hard in order to be successful and improve their circumstance's. But Demon argues against this idea. According to him, a person's circumstances of her birth play a larger role in how their life turns out. The novel, in some ways, sets out to answer that question: are people's lives governed by fate or by free will? The novel answers the question by showing that although a person's circumstances do significantly shape a person's life, they can also make choices to change those circumstances. But those changes, the novel argues, can be much more difficult for some people to implement than others because of circumstances they inherited at birth.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ A kid is a terrible thing to be, in charge of nothing. If you get past that and grown, it's easiest to forget about the misery and pretend you knew all along what you were doing. Assuming you've ended up someplace you're proud to be. And if not, easier to forget the whole thing, period. So this is going to be option three, not proud, not forgetting. Not easy.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker)

Related Themes:     

Page Number: 7

Explanation and Analysis

At the start of the book's second chapter, Demon explains some of the things he is trying to accomplish in telling his story. He is trying, he says, to be honest when telling his story, including both the parts that he isn't proud of and the painful memories. At the end of the novel, Demon intimates that he started writing his story down because a therapist suggested it might be helpful for him. With that in mind, Demon is telling his own story in the hope that it will be therapeutic for him, helping him to heal from painful experiences in his past over which he had no control. To heal, though, Demon has to face those painful experiences directly. Throughout the novel, Demon consistently turns away from his pain or tries to silence it through drugs, hoping the pain might disappear if he doesn't acknowledge it. This passage, though, shows the lessons that Demon has learned by the end of the novel: that if he runs from his pain,



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Harper edition of *Demon Copperhead* published in 2022.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ If a mother is lying in her own piss and pill bottles while they're slapping the kid she's shunted out, telling him to look alive: likely the bastard is doomed. Kid born to the junkie is a junkie [...]. Anybody will tell you the born of this world are marked from the get-out, win or lose.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 2

Explanation and Analysis

At the start of the novel, Demon's mom is passed out on drugs when she gives birth to Demon. To Demon, that is a sign that he is doomed from the beginning. That sense of doom introduces a major theme of the novel: the tension between fate and free will. In this passage, Demon espouses a fatalistic view of the world: because his mother was addicted to drugs, he will also be addicted to drugs. He doesn't have a choice in the matter. Demon expands his view to say that each person's fate is sealed at the time of

he will never stop running, and he will never stop hurting.
The only thing he can do is turn and face it directly.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☛ Mom had walked down the road and Stoner was bent over kissing her like he was trying to suck something out of her guts with a straw. And her a willing party to the crime.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Stoner

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

Demon watches his mom and Stoner kiss soon after they have begun a relationship. To Demon, the romantic act of kissing between Stoner and Mom seems more like an act of violence. When Stoner kisses Mom, Demon interprets an act that ought to be a show of affection as Stoner's attempt to "suck something out of her guts." Demon's interpretation isn't far from the truth: Stoner turns out to be a violent, exploitative, and manipulative person. And as a result, Mom grows more and more depressed during her relationship with Stoner, eventually dying from an overdose. It's as if being with Stoner literally sucked the life out of her.

The novel draws a comparison, too, between exploitative and manipulative characters and the exploitative and manipulative industries that prey on the people of Appalachia. Here, Stoner functions as a stand-in for pharmaceutical industries that claim to offer something good (pain-relieving medications), but really they're only hurting the vulnerable communities they serve in the long run, leaving them dependent on highly addictive, potentially dangerous drugs. That is, the pharmaceutical companies slowly poison people, just like Stoner seems to have done to Mom. And, like Mom with Stoner, people gladly take what the pharmaceutical companies offer, desperate for relief from pain, not realizing that their initial relief from suffering will leave them with far more misery and hardship down the line.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☛ For whatever reason Emmy said okay, let's do it. I had to hold her hand. She kept her eyes closed.

It was true about Aunt June keeping track. Which was not true of my mom in any way, shape, or form. So that was me promising Emmy that life is to be trusted. I knew better. I should have let her go with her gut: Never get back on the horse, because it's going to throw you every damn chance it gets. Then maybe she'd have been wise to the shit that came for her later on, and maybe it would have turned out better.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Maggot, Emmy, Aunt June

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 28

Explanation and Analysis

When Emmy and Demon are both young, they go with Aunt June and Maggot to the aquarium in Gatlinburg, Tennessee. At one point, Emmy stops walking because she is afraid of going down the shark tunnel, so Demon goes back to help her, reassuring her that Aunt June knew Emmy had fallen behind because Aunt June "keeps track."

Throughout the novel, Demon is let down over and over again by the adults who are supposed to care for him. As a result, he comes to believe that trusting others will only make him more vulnerable to exploitation and abuse, and that does happen to Emmy later in the novel. The novel contrasts Demon's reasoning, though, with his actions. Throughout the novel, he routinely treats others with care and kindness. When coupled with the philosophy he articulates in this passage, Demon's actions indicate that while trusting others can lead to ruin, a person should always strive to be a person whom others can trust. And, in turn, a person should try and surround themselves with the people they can trust (something that Demon often struggles to do). While there are many parts of life a person can't control, they can control how they treat others. As such, they have an imperative, Demon's actions in this passage show, to treat others with dignity, care, and compassion.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☛ Nobody believed a word out of this girl's mouth at the time of her need. And today, her side of the story stands as gospel. The world turns [...]. How all this fits with the story of me, hard to say.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Maggot, Mariah Peggot, Romeo Blevins

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 42

Explanation and Analysis

After Maggot's father, Romeo Blevins, violently abuses Maggot's mother, Mariah Peggot, she defends herself, attacking Romeo with an X-Acto knife. She goes on trial, and Romeo manipulates the judge and jury into siding with him. As a result, Mariah is sentenced to 12 years in prison. In the present, everyone believes Mariah. But when Romeo was abusing her, nobody knew she needed help. This quotation shows how society often silences or ignores its most vulnerable populations, such as victims of abuse. Meanwhile, society tends to believe and side with people (or corporations) in positions of power. In Mariah's case, her unjust sentencing seems to be the result of toxic masculinity and gender inequality; people believe Romeo Blevins because he is a man and silence Mariah because she is a woman.

The novel argues that a similar phenomenon happens to Demon and, by extension, the people of Appalachia, albeit for different reasons. Demon is a child for most of the novel and doesn't have power in most situations. As a result, he is abused and mistreated by people who should care for him, and no one listens to him when he tries to talk about that mistreatment. Similarly, when pharmaceutical or coal companies came to Appalachia, society privileged their "voices" over the concerns of individual people in Appalachia who tried to raise awareness about the danger those companies posed to Appalachia's most vulnerable residents.

Chapter 9 Quotes

💡💡 Other people made up *hillbilly* to use on us, for the purpose of being assholes. But they gave us a superpower on accident [...]. Saying that word back at people proves they can't ever be us, or get us, and we are untouchable by their shit.

The world is not at all short on this type of thing, it turns out. All down the years, words have been flung like pieces of shit, only to get stuck on a truck bumper with up-yours pride. Rednecks, moonshiners, ridge runners, hicks. Deplorables.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 69

Explanation and Analysis

Demon explains the power that comes when people reclaim derogatory words used against them. Notably, Demon identifies that kind of reclamation, and the resultant pride, as a superpower. Throughout the novel, Demon is obsessed with comics, superheroes, and superpowers; he eventually develops a comic with a superhero named Red Neck who helps the people of Appalachia, pointing to his own pride in what was originally used as an offensive term.

Significantly, Demon repeatedly uses the word "us" when discussing his idea of that superpower that comes from the reclamation of derogatory words and stereotypes. With that in mind, that superpower comes from banding together, uniting as a group under a word designed to put people down. When people who are stereotyped and denigrated come together, Demon says, they can achieve extraordinary power.

Notably, the novel sets the word "deplorables" in a sentence of its own, perhaps gesturing toward its pejorative use by Hillary Clinton to describe supporters of her political opponent, Donald Trump, during her campaign for the 2016 election. Trump would go on to win the election, with electoral support from Appalachian regions securing that win. Given this, Demon's use of the term "deplorables" seems to criticize broader society's contempt for and underestimation of people from Appalachia. In fact, so-called "deplorable" are not as socially irrelevant as the broader culture might tend to think they are.

Chapter 10 Quotes

💡💡 A ten-year-old getting high on pills. Foolish children. This is what we're meant to say: Look at their choices, leading to a life of ruin. But lives are getting lived right now, this hour, down in the dirty cracks between the toothbrushed nighty-nights and the full grocery carts, where those words don't pertain. Children, choices. Ruin, that was the labor and materials we were given to work with. An older boy that never knew safety himself, trying to make us feel safe. We had the moon in the window to smile on us for a minute and tell us the world was ours. Because all the adults had gone off somewhere and left everything in our hands.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Fast Forward, Dori, Tommy Waddell, Mr. Crickson, Swap-Out

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 77**Explanation and Analysis**

After Demon's mom dies, he goes into foster care and is sent to Crickson's farm, where he and the other boys are forced to do manual labor. One night, Fast Forward, the oldest of the boys, throws a "party," where he gives pills to all the boys in attendance—including Demon, who is only 10 years old at the time. In this passage, Demon criticizes people who would argue that people with substance abuse issues have only themselves to blame for their problems. Instead, he suggests that people in his circumstances don't really have choices. His mom has died, and his foster guardian, Crickson, is abusive to children. Demon hasn't chosen any of those things. Instead, he has been given "ruin," as he says, and out of that ruin, he has had to try and make a life for himself, seeking support anywhere he can get it. Taking drugs from Fast Forward might not be what's best for Demon, but it's understandable that he would trust one of the few people who has shown him love and compassion.

In this way, Demon challenges the stereotype that people who become addicted to drugs do so because they are "foolish" or self-centered. Instead, Demon argues, love can be the motivation that leads to addiction. Fast Forward, in his own confused way, seems to care deeply for the other foster boys, and he wants to provide for their safety in the only way that, to him, seems possible. With that in mind, Demon's first experience comes from Fast Forward's impulse toward love, just like later in the novel when Dori offers Demon drugs because she loves him. With that in mind, the novel argues that addiction is a much more complicated phenomenon than a stereotype of individuals acting foolishly or destructively.

Tommy Waddell, Miss Barks, Mr. Crickson, Swap-Out

Related Themes:   **Related Symbols:** **Page Number:** 78**Explanation and Analysis**

Demon explains the situation on Crickson's farm to his case manager, Miss Barks. Even though there is child abuse happening and Miss Barks is a case manager at a social services agency, she explains that she can't do anything to help Demon since Tommy and Swap-Out aren't under her management. While one might hope that a system that deals with children might be run with more care and compassion than the pharmaceutical or coal industries, through Miss Barks, Demon learns that all large institutions seem to function according to the same principles.

Miss Barks is a case manager because she needs money while she is studying to become a teacher. Crickson fosters children because he wants to get a monthly check for each boy and force them to work on his farm. Even in foster care, then, the underlying motivations of everyone involved are, according to Demon, economic. The only difference is that the "product" in foster care is children. Demon explains here that children are ushered from placement to placement depending on circumstances outside of their control, and the people in charge of them are only interested in exploiting them, the foster care system, or both. With that in mind, while the foster care system purports to care about children, the novel argues that it functions similarly to any other exploitative industry.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☛☛ She asked me about Creaky Farm, and I told her. The old man was brutal to Tommy, and Swap-Out should be in some other kind of situation [...]. Had Crickson ever hit me, she asked. Answer: no. I myself had not been struck. And that was that. Miss Barks was sorry, but Tommy and Swap-Out weren't on her. Usually all kids in a home are from one foster company, but Crickson was an emergency-type place, and Tommy and Swap-Out belonged to a different foster company that Miss Bark didn't work with. So fostering was done by companies, and we, as Stoner would say, were Product. Rotating and merchandising foster boys at more than fifty customer accounts. Live and learn.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker),**Chapter 14 Quotes**

☛☛ If Philip Morris and them knew the devil had real teeth, they sat harder on that secret than you'd believe. Grow it with pride and smoke it with pride, they said, giving out bumper stickers to that effect. I recall big stacks of them at school, free for the taking [...]. We drove around with "Proud Tobacco Farmer" stickers on our trucks till they peeled and faded along with our good health and dreams of greatness. If you're standing on a small pile of shit, fighting for your one place to stand, God almighty how you fight.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Mr. Crickson**Related Themes:**  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 103

Explanation and Analysis

On Crickson's farm, Demon and the other boys harvest tobacco, and Demon reflects on people's attitudes toward smoking and tobacco at the time. This passage establishes the relationship tobacco companies like Philip Morris had with people who farmed and smoked tobacco. According to Demon (and as has been well-established in court cases and historical records), tobacco companies knew that tobacco products were addictive and caused serious health issues but kept that information hidden from the public for as long as possible in order to profit off tobacco farmers and users.

The novel argues—and court cases and historical records show—that pharmaceutical companies are similarly predatory. Pharmaceutical companies knew that opioid painkillers were highly addictive but pushed for their increased use without caring how it would impact the people who took those drugs. The novel implicitly compares the tobacco and pharmaceutical industries to show how powerful companies and institutions in general prey on society's most vulnerable populations.

Chapter 16 Quotes

☞ Maybe life, or destiny, or Jesus if you really need to put somebody in charge of things had finally flung down one too many rocks in Mom's road and she called it a day. That's option one. Or two, maybe she didn't aim to die but miscalculated to cap off her twenty-nine-year pileup of miscalculations, one of those of course being me. I could spend the rest of my life asking which it was, suicide or accident. No answer on that line.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Stoner

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 107

Explanation and Analysis

After Mom dies from an overdose of OxyContin, Demon tries to determine whether she died by suicide or if the overdose was an accident. The answer to that question is especially important for Demon because Mom had told him that he was her reason for getting clean. Now, her death suggests to Demon that he wasn't a good enough reason for

Mom to stay alive, a line of thinking that severely damages Demon's self-esteem.

In some ways, the novel sets out to answer a related question about Mom's death: who killed her? Whether Mom's death was accidental or intentional on her part, the novel argues that forces beyond her control are also responsible for her death, if only indirectly. Those forces include her painful upbringing in foster care, her abusive relationship with Stoner, and, finally, the predatory practices of drug companies that gave her easy access to the highly addictive, dangerous drugs that directly caused her death.

☞ In the long run, that's how I've come to picture Mom at the end: reaching as hard as her little body would stretch, trying to touch the blue sky, reaching for some peace. And getting it.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 109

Explanation and Analysis

When Demon is at Mom's funeral, he tries to understand her death. Demon frames her overdose as an attempt to find peace. Whether she meant to die from the overdose or not, Demon reasons that she started using pills initially, and then continued to go back to them, because that was the most accessible means to find peace. Notably, Demon says that through her death, Mom found the peace she was looking for. It's a dark idea, but it points to the reality of Mom's situation while she was alive and to Demon's situation now that she is dead.

When she was alive, Mom did not feel like she was in control of her life. She suffered from memories of childhood trauma and was in an abusive relationship that she didn't see a way out of. To find relief from the suffering of her daily life, she turned to pills. Those pills had been marketed as physical pain relievers, but, without a plethora of better options, Mom used them to try and treat her emotional pain. Demon's idea that Mom's death brought her the peace she could not find in life signals just how hopeless the life seemed to Demon and Mom. Without hope, Mom looked instead for relief, and it ended up killing her.

☛ Mom was the unknown soldier. Walmart would have a new stock girl in time for the Christmas shoppers [...]. Our trailer home would be thoroughly Cloroxed and every carpet torn out, so the Peggots could rent it to one of Aunt June's high school friends that got left flat by both her kids' daddies [...]. Wanting a fresh start for this girl and her little family, I'm sure they scrubbed the place clean of old stains, including the two pencil lines on the kitchen wall that proved I once stood taller by a hair than my mom. Her life left no marks on a thing.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom , Aunt June

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 109

Explanation and Analysis

After Mom dies, the Peggots clean the trailer where Mom and Demon lived to make room for another family. Demon reflects and concludes that no trace of his mom will remain after her death. It will be as if she never existed. Notably, Demon refers to Mom as an “unknown soldier,” a term that evokes soldiers who die in war and are never identified. The passage implies that Mom's battle—her personal war—was simply making it through each day. Like an unknown soldier, nobody will know how Mom contributed to others' lives will never be fully recognized or acknowledged. Just after Demon says that Mom is an unknown soldier, he references her job at Walmart, drawing the comparison between capitalism and war. That comparison might seem hyperbolic, but the capitalistic profiteering of large drug companies is what led, indirectly or directly, to Mom's overdose. And just as young soldiers' lives may be seen as expendable to the governments who wage wars, Mom's life was expendable to the major corporation who profited off her labor.

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

After Demon leaves Mr. Crickson's farm, he is sent to live with the McCobbs. Mr. McCobb treats the foster care system like another scam that might give him a little extra money. Demon feigns jadedness, but underneath his world-weary exterior, the exploitation at the hands of people who are supposed to care for him clearly takes a toll on him.

Mr. McCobb's manipulation of the foster care system is similar to Dr. Watts's pattern of seeking loopholes to overprescribe drugs in order to make a larger profit. Neither man seems to care about the wellbeing of the people they are supposed to protect. Instead, they are intent on exploiting those people for their own profits. Although the novel criticizes the role that individual people play in the exploitation of more vulnerable populations, it is also careful not to blame individuals entirely. According to the novel, their exploitation of others isn't outside of the norm or the result of “a few bad apples.” Instead, it is part of broader systems of institutional exploitation, whether the institution in question is the foster care system or the pharmaceutical industry.

☛ Miss Barks [...] stuck with a different theory. I needed to be more pushy with them. Did she give up on *her* dreams? No, she worked hard for what she wanted. Did I expect anybody to look out for Damon if he wouldn't look out for himself? Life is what you make it! Here's where Miss Barks didn't grow up: foster care. She had no clue how people can be living right on the edge of what's doable. If you push too hard, you can barrel yourself over a damn cliff.

Chapter 20 Quotes

☛ Mr. McCobb was big on idea for making that little bit extra to turn things around, and had tried most of them: selling Amway, breeding AKC pups with fake papers, human advertisement, sperm donor, etc. Plus buying lotto tickets, obviously. His newest idea was taking in a foster. If I went okay, they might take in two, for twice the cash. It didn't hurt my feelings. Creaky made no bones about wanting that five hundred a month per head. I knew the score.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Dr. Watts, Mr. Crickson, Mr. McCobb

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom , Maggot, Emmy, Dori, Hammerhead Kelly, Miss Barks, Mr. McCobb, Mrs. McCobb

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 144-145

Explanation and Analysis

After Demon complains to Miss Barks that Mr. and Mrs. McCobb aren't feeding him enough, she asks the McCobbs about it, and they say they give Demon more than enough food. Miss Barks believes them and tells Demon that if he wants more food, he has to stick up for himself more with

the McCobbs. Miss Barks's speech reflects the core idea of the American Dream: if a person works hard, they'll achieve success. After all, Miss Barks argues, that's what she did, and she has been successful. According to Miss Barks, there are two options: a person can be passive and struggle, or they actively work hard and succeed. Miss Barks thinks Demon is being too passive and that he needs to be more proactive if he wants to have a better life.

Demon thinks that Miss Barks's worldview is painfully naïve and doesn't account for the barriers that may stand in the way of success for many people. According to Demon, if some people are more "pushy," they might not find success but will instead land in untenable situations. That seems to be what happens to various characters in the novel, including Mom, Emmy, Hammer, Maggot, Dori, and Demon himself. They try to shape their lives according to their own will, but they find barriers that they cannot readily overcome. Each character gets stuck behind those barriers, and some, like Mom and Dori, end up dying because they have gone "over" the edge of what's doable.

Chapter 25 Quotes

☝☝ He said his parents, sisters, and all their dump friends were so-called no-toucher people. Meaning if they touched food or anything at all, it was like, doomed. Regular people would have none of it. Same for bodies, no shaking hands. If he let his *shadow* touch a high-class person, they'd call the cops to come beat the hell out of him. He said a name for this kind of people that sounded like "dolly" [...]. He said he never would get used to how nice Americans are to each other [...]. But if we had a word for that kind of person in America, it would get used.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Betsy Woodall, Mr. Ghali

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 187

Explanation and Analysis

When Demon is hitchhiking his way to try and find his grandmother, Betsy, he eats his last piece of food, a Slim Jim he stole from Mr. Ghali's store. Demon then remembers what Mr. Ghali told him about growing up in the caste system in India. Mr. Ghali describes being a Dalit (which Demon hears as "dolly") as a boy in India. Dalit people were previously known as "untouchables" (which Demon remembers as "no-toucher"). Dalits are considered the lowest rung in India's caste system and face discrimination and prejudice as a result. India's caste system is a rigid social

hierarchy passed down through one's family.

While the U.S. is not generally thought of as a caste-based society in the strict definition of the term, Demon finds many similarities between the prejudice and discrimination he experiences due to his class and Ghali's descriptions of the caste system in India. In particular, Demon seems to be thinking of the social ostracization he faced at school when he lived with the McCobbs. The McCobbs refused to buy him new clothes, his poverty became apparent to his classmates. As a result, they shunned him. Demon argues that this kind of ostracization is common in the U.S., even if people refuse to acknowledge it.

Chapter 32 Quotes

☝☝ I told Angus my mom being dead wasn't something I pinned exactly on my birthday. "It's more like this bag of gravel I'm hauling around every day of the year. If somebody else brings it up, honestly, I'm glad of it. Like just for a minute they can help me drag the gravel."

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Angus

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 246

Explanation and Analysis

During their first Christmas together, Demon and Angus talk about their mothers, who have both died. Demon's mom died on his birthday, and Angus mentions how difficult that must be for him. Demon's response aptly illustrates the emotional weight of his mother's death, describing his grief as a "bag of gravel" he carries around every day of his life. He feels his grief like a heavy burden he drags behind him. For Demon, there's usually no relief from the pain and grief of his mother's death. The only relief comes when he can talk to someone about his mom, and then that person can help him "drag the gravel."

The importance of talking about his mom's death points to two different aspects of Demon's life. First, it seems likely that part of the reason he doesn't talk about Mom is that, as a boy surrounded by toxic masculinity, he was taught to keep his emotions inside. Demon's comment also highlights the importance of community and belonging. He is carrying too much weight for one person to carry alone, and needs other people to help him. In this conversation alone, Angus shows she can be one of those people. Unfortunately, for every Angus in the novel, there is someone like Fast

Forward, and Demon has to learn how to discern between helpful, supportive people and destructive people before he can form the right kind of community full of people who will help him recover and thrive.

Chapter 36 Quotes

☝ I was born to wish for more than I can have. No little fishing hole for Demon, he wants the whole ocean. And on from there, as regards man-overboard. I came late to getting my brain around to the problem of me, and still yet might not have. The telling of this tale is supposed to make it come clear. It's a disease, a lot of people will tell you that now, be they crushed souls under repair at NA meetings or the doctors in buttoned-up sweaters. Fair enough. But where did it come from, this wanting disease? From how I was born, or the ones that made me, or the crowd I ran with later? Everybody warns about bad influences, but it's these things already inside you that are going to take you down.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 281

Explanation and Analysis

Demon reflects on his fall from being a rising football star and popular in school to dropping out of school and becoming addicted to opioids. Demon explains that he is telling his story to try and grapple with the choices he has made and to try and understand himself better in hopes that he can maintain his sobriety and avoid the pitfalls of his past.

Demon reflects on the idea that addiction is a disease, which doesn't entirely satisfy him because he wants to know where that disease comes from. In particular, he wonders whether the factors that contribute to increased susceptibility to addiction are more genetic or environmental. Interestingly, Demon's idea that the "things already inside you" will "take you down" seems to bolster his fatalistic outlook on life. He often comments that no matter what he does or chooses, life has a way of bringing him down. He says that not from a place of self-pity, though: instead, he seems to want acknowledge the complexity of his life and to understand the trauma he has experienced and the predisposition to addiction that he seems to have inherited.

Notably, Demon's exercise of writing down his story challenges that fatalistic outlook in the sense that he is telling his story to gain more control over what his future will look like. With that in mind, it's clear that, in Demon's view, the fate determined by the "things already inside you" isn't unchangeable, but it takes a lot of work to alter it.

Chapter 41 Quotes

☝ Where does the road to ruin start? That's the point of getting all this down, I'm told. To get a handle on some choice you made. Or was made for you. By the bullies that curdled your heart's milk and honey, or the ones before that curdled theirs. Hell, let's blame the coal guys, or whoever wrote the book of Lee County commandments. Thou shalt forsake all things you might love or study on, books, numbers, a boy's life made livable in pictures he drew. Leave these ye redneck faithful, to chase the one star left shining on this place: manly bloodthirst. The smell of mauled sod and sweat and pent-up lust and popcorn. The Friday-night lights.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead, Stoner, Fast Forward, Hammerhead Kelly (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 332

Explanation and Analysis

After Demon is injured, he reflects on his life and also describes that he's telling his story to try and understand the choices he made or were made for him. Later in the book, Demon will more fully explain that he is writing the story following the suggestion of a therapist. With that in mind, the novel itself is a therapeutic tool for Demon and is part of the painstaking, day-in, day-out work to maintain his sobriety.

In this passage, Demon also puts his choices that led to addiction into context. Those choices come about, Demon explains, because of widespread trauma, and he traces that trauma back to the economic devastation caused by coal companies in Appalachia. Notably, Demon describes that kind of trauma as a state of mind where people's "heart's milk and honey" is "curdled." There is nothing tender or sweet left in those people, Demon argues, and they take out their trauma on others (who then take out their own pain on others, perpetuating the cycle of pain). When that tenderness is "curdled" within people, the only thing left is "manly bloodthirst," the toxic masculinity of people like Stoner, Fast Forward, and even Demon himself, which

eventually leads to Hammer and Fast Forward's deaths.

☛ She said it was hydrocodone and something. Not oxy then, I said, and she said it was really no better than that. I was struggling for words and possibly catching the asshole bug from Coach because I asked her whatever happened to Kent's "pain is a vital sign" and all that.

She hissed at me: "Kent Holt is a fucking hired killer for his company."

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Aunt June, Coach Winfield, Kent

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 340

Explanation and Analysis

After Demon injures his knee during a football game, Aunt June comes to visit and says that he is tempting fate by taking the pills he's taking. After June moves back to Lee County, she sees firsthand how much opioids have impacted the community. Those opioids are causing people to lose their jobs and houses and to lose control of their lives. In many cases, those pills take people's lives.

June places the blame squarely on pharmaceutical companies and their employees, including her former boyfriend, Kent. Kent would contend that by getting doctors to prescribe opioids, he is only trying to help alleviate people's suffering. According to Kent, he and the pharmaceutical companies are acting benevolently and in the best interest of the people of Lee County. Aunt June has seen the wreckage opioids have left in their wake, though, and she argues that Kent's rhetoric of compassion is just marketing. Instead, June argues, the companies are so determined to make money that they will indirectly murder other people as long as they are paid to do so. The novel supports that argument, portraying the pharmaceutical companies' exploitation of the people of Lee County within the broader context of the long history of powerful institutions exploiting the people of Appalachia.

Chapter 42 Quotes

☛ The next surprise won't leave my brain. The kit she took out of her purse. The spoon she used first, to scrape the patch. The lighter she held underneath. The cotton ball, the syringe, pulling the cap off the needle and holding it in her mouth like a nurse giving booster shots. I don't know what I said but she could tell I was scared, and she was sweet with me, the same voice she used with Jip. She'd been saving this, because the first time you do it with somebody, they say it's the best you'll ever feel in your life. Like having Jesus in your blood.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Dori

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 351

Explanation and Analysis

After Dori and Demon go to homecoming together, they find time to be alone in Dori's car, where Dori and Demon do fentanyl together. Notably, Demon describes himself as "scared," and he seems to be afraid not just of the needle but of the experience itself. Dori reacts with kindness and tenderness, highlighting the novel's recurring theme that drugs and addiction often come out of impulses toward kindness and care instead of the negative impulses of selfishness or self-destruction often ascribed to drug use. That impulse toward care—along with a desire for connection, community, and belonging—is underlined by Dori's desire to wait until she was with Demon to do fentanyl because she wanted to feel something with him (instead of alone).

Notably, Dori describes that feeling as "like having Jesus in your blood." Throughout the novel, Demon often likens Jesus to a superhero, someone who can step in and change fate in one fell swoop. While superheroes might give people hope, Demon is adamant that they are not real because, in real life, no one can step in and save the day. By comparing fentanyl to Jesus, the novel makes a case about how people hope drugs (and religion) might function in their lives. The novel argues that people think drug use in general might miraculously cure their other issues. But, the novel contends, there is no such miracle cure: addiction, while a human response to sometimes insurmountable obstacles, ultimately leads to destruction and pain, no matter what impulse led someone to begin down that path.

Chapter 48 Quotes

☞☞ If you've not known the dragon we're chasing, words may not help. People talk of getting high, this blast you get, not so much what you feel as what you don't: the sadness and dread in your gut, all the people that have judged you useless. The pain of an exploded leg. This tether that's meant to attach you to something all your life, be it home or parents or safety, has been flailing around unfastened all this time, tearing at your brain's roots, whipping around so hard it might take out an eye. All at once, that tether goes still on the floor and you're at rest.

You start trying to get back there, and pretty soon, you're just trying to get out of bed.

It becomes your job, staving off the dopesickness for another day. Then it becomes your God. No one ever wanted to join that church.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Dori

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 408

Explanation and Analysis

Demon is living with Dori, and he explains the process of addiction in general terms. Demon explains that getting high begins as a way to quell both physical and emotional pain. For Demon, opioids first treated the physical pain of his knee injury, but he soon learned that they helped silence his emotional pain, too.

Notably, Demon describes his emotional pain in terms of feeling an absence of belonging. Demon has consistently had the potential people or places he could become attached to ripped away and has felt like something inside him is flailing. Opioids, then, (including the heroin that he smokes when he "chases the dragon" and the fentanyl Dori gives him) help quiet that emotional chaos and give him the kind of mental calm and peace he has been searching for. In a way, opioids are a shortcut to the sense of belonging that Demon hopes to find: they give him the feeling that he can't sustain in his day-to-day life.

Ultimately, though, the soothing qualities of opioids shift to dopesickness, and Demon starts getting high not to feel emotional tranquility but to get out of bed each day. The problems only get worse from there. While Demon tries to quit multiple times, Dori tries less frequently and eventually has a fatal overdose.

Chapter 49 Quotes

☞☞ I tried to explain the whole human-being aspect of everybody needing to dump on somebody. Stepdad smacks mom, mom yells at the kid, kid finds the dog and kicks it. (Not that we had one. I wrecked some havoc on my Transformers though.) We're the dog of America. Every make of person now has their proper nouns, except for some reason, us. Hicks, rednecks, not capitalized.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Tommy Waddell

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 417

Explanation and Analysis

Demon visits Tommy at his job at the newspaper and explains his understanding of why national coverage of people from Appalachia seems to dehumanize those people and rely on stereotypes for that coverage. Demon's first line of reasoning is that people have to externalize their pain. They can't keep it in, and, as a result, they hurt other people. Those people, in turn, hurt other people, animals, or objects. Notably, in Demon's telling, pain is always transferred from a more powerful person to a less powerful person until it reaches animals or toys. Demon's logic mirrors the book's understanding of generational trauma. According to the novel, Demon becomes addicted to drugs in part because his mom experienced trauma at the hands of more powerful people, which led her to become addicted to drugs.

From that argument, Demon makes the leap to say that the country functions in the same way as an abusive and dysfunctional family. People are in pain, and they need to externalize that pain by forcing it onto others. According to Demon, people wanting relief or distraction from their own issues project them onto the people of Appalachia. Following Demon's logic, the people of Appalachia are some of the most disempowered people in the country.

Chapter 53 Quotes

☞☞ *Stupid* is all the word I've had to cover much of my time on God's grass. But it's not stupid that makes a bird fly, or a grasshopper rub its knees together and sing. It's nature. A junkie catches his flight. That sugar on your brain cells sucks away any other purpose. You can think you're in charge. Walk around thinking this for hours at a time, or a day, till the clock winds down and the human person you were gets yanked out through whatever hole the devil can find. Learn your lesson, get your feet up under you. You will be knocked down again.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Demon's Mom, Dori

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 445

Explanation and Analysis

After Dori becomes pregnant, Demon hopes the pregnancy will be a good enough reason for Dori to get clean. Demon makes the case that it isn't just environmental factors that lead someone into addiction, though: neurological wiring also plays a part.

In some ways, that idea makes the novel's indictment of the exploitation of the pharmaceutical companies even more damning. Demon argues that there are people who are biologically more susceptible to addiction and that pharmaceutical companies knew how their drugs would impact those people. Instead of that knowledge functioning as a deterrent, the drug companies went ahead and marketed those pills without any regard for how they would impact human lives.

Demon's reasoning also hints that he is processing and coming to terms with not just Dori's death, but his mother's, as well. While he first felt responsible, at least in part, for his mother's inability to stay clean, he now seems to be embracing an understanding of the situation in which he is not responsible for his mom's addiction (and neither is she).

Page Number: 499

Explanation and Analysis

After Hammer and Fast Forward die, Aunt June offers to help Demon go to rehab. Demon demurs, and June stresses the importance that Demon goes. According to June, Hammer, Fast Forward, Demon, and Maggot all became ensnared by the plots of pharmaceutical companies and coal companies before that, along with the negligence of the federal and state governments, which failed to provide adequate educational opportunities. June argues that the absence of opportunities coupled with addiction led boys like Fast Forward and Hammer to lose their minds.

June's understanding of life seems to differ in some important respects from Demon's, and this passage highlights those differences. While Demon has often espoused a fatalistic worldview in which life will knock a person down time after time and any attempt to alter one's life will lead to failure, June stresses the importance of choice and free will. She presents Demon with an opportunity to change his life. Notably, she doesn't claim that change will be easy. Instead, she says it will be the hardest thing he'll ever do. In that way, June's path to success is markedly different from the drugs or superheroes that Demon fixated on. Instead, June presents success as a slow, steady, and painstaking process—but one that allows for the possibility of free will even in a world that seems stacked against people like Demon.

Chapter 59 Quotes

☞ “It's not natural for boys to lose their minds,” she said. “It happens because they've had too many things taken away from them.”

I asked her like what. She got up and walked around the room, upset. No decent schooling, she said. No chance to get good at anything that uses our talents. No future. They took all that away and supplied us with the tools for cooking our brains, hoping we'd kill each other before realizing the real assholes are a thousand miles from here [...].

She sat down on the bed again. “The question you have to answer now is, What are you willing to do for yourself? And I won't lie, it's going to be harder than anything you've done before.”

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead, Aunt June (speaker), Maggot, Fast Forward, Hammerhead Kelly

Related Themes:    

Chapter 64 Quotes

☞ The trip itself, just getting there, possibly the best part of my life so far.

That's where we are. Well past the Christiansburg exit. Past Richmond, and still pointed east. Headed for the one big thing I know is not going to swallow me alive.

Related Characters: Demon Copperhead (speaker), Angus

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 546

Explanation and Analysis

After Demon has been sober in Knoxville for three years, he returns for a weekend to Lee County. He sees Angus while he's there, and the two decide to take a trip to the ocean. Throughout the novel, the ocean symbolizes the peace and

tranquility that Demon hopes to find in his life. The ocean (both literally and figuratively) has been a destination that he has been trying to reach. At the end of the novel, though, he realizes that the trip to the ocean is the “best part of his life so far.” By writing his story and devoting himself to maintaining sobriety, Demon seems to have realized that he is not necessarily trying to arrive at a specific destination but to be fully present during his continuous journey. Notably, Demon’s realization comes after he learns that

Angus has feelings for him and that he reciprocates those feelings. This realization reaffirms how Demon’s finally finding the sense of belonging he has been searching for corresponds with his ability to live with himself. Although Demon and Angus may have had feelings for each other all along, Demon needed to accept himself and make peace with his past before he could acknowledge and act on his romantic feelings toward Angus.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Damon Fields, the book's narrator, describes the day he was born. That day, Nance Peggot barges into Damon's mom's house and finds her in the middle of labor, passed out with drugs scattered on the bathroom floor. Damon punches and kicks, "still inside the sack that babies float in, pre-real-life." Nance comes out of the house and yells to her husband, Mr. Peggot, who is waiting outside, to call 911. When Nance describes the event later on, she says that Damon punched out of the sack like "a little blue prizefighter."

Damon grows up in a single-wide set between the Ruelynn coal camp and a settlement called "Right Poor" in the heart of Lee County in southwest Virginia. He spends hours playing in the creek, looking under rocks, and "being mighty" with his neighbor, a boy named Maggot. "Maggot" is short for Matt Peggot, and he's the grandson of Nance. The place where they live is famous for its **copperheads**, but Damon never sees one. He adds, though, that one of his mother's "bad choices," a phrase she learned to use in rehab, was a guy named Copperhead. Copperhead had "the dark skin and light-green eyes of a Melungeon." As Damon grows up, he becomes the spitting image of that man.

Damon's mom has a different story about Damon's birth than Nance Peggot's. But, Damon says, anyone who had met both his mom and Nance would know who was more trustworthy. Either way, according to Damon's mom, the day Damon was born, her "baby daddy's mother" showed up out of the blue with a plan to take her grandchild away from the "den of vice" and raise "her up decent." The fear that she might lose custody of Damon scared his mom into going to rehab. Damon doubts his mom's story and also doesn't understand why she was so insistent that the woman came to take away a girl. Damon wonders if that was what his Mom wanted all along—someone delicate who would make her clean up her act. Damon thinks that he's fragile, too.

The book's opening passage introduces the climate of addiction that Demon is born into. Addiction is the first thing he knows, as he is born to a mother who has passed out from drug use. The novel establishes Mom's pattern of drug use and addiction not just to highlight her own struggles, but also to provide context that will help explain how and why Demon later becomes addicted to drugs himself. That Mrs. Peggot, Demon's neighbor, steps in to help Demon when he is most in need, introduces the novel's other central theme of community.



This passage introduces some of the ideas and stereotypes that people who aren't from Appalachia—and, in this case, even people from outside of the specific area of town where Demon lives—have about the region and its people. Specifically, people have an idea that Demon's home is infested with copperheads, dangerous snakes. In truth, though, there are virtually none of those snakes in the region. Those misconceptions about the region become a running theme throughout the novel, especially as outsiders use stereotypes about the region to justify disregarding its people and ignoring their struggles.



Demon intimates that his mom may feel some shame regarding the circumstances of his birth, namely that she was unconscious after taking drugs when Demon was born, and that is why she may have made up a story to obscure the actual events of that day, as told by Mrs. Peggot. Demon also wonders about how gender plays into his mom's story, suggesting that if he had been born as a girl, his gender would have provided an impetus for his mother to go to rehab because she would have needed to protect her child. But Demon questions those tropes and assumptions of gender when he says that he, too, was fragile and needed protection, hinting at the way that Demon will ultimately have to question and dismantle the harmful gender stereotypes he's exposed to growing up.



CHAPTER 2

The Peggots keep a collection of gourds hanging from trees in their front lawn: a collection of would-be birdhouses, except the birds prefer to build their own nests in the surrounding trees. The Peggots have seven children altogether, some living as far as Florida, some just a mile away. Over the course of each day, every member of the family gets talked about in one way or another, except for Maggot's mom, who's in jail, and his uncle Humvee, who's dead. The Peggots also have a dog pen with no dog. Damon's family's trailer lies on the other side of that pen. The Peggots have chickens too, and a rooster with the "mind of a serial killer" that haunts Damon's dreams.

The Peggot family takes Damon to church, and he doesn't mind it until he finds out about Lazarus and thinks his dad might come back. Maggot helps calm him down by explaining that Bible stories are a kind of superhero comic. The trailer where Mom and Damon live used to belong to the Peggots before Maggot's aunt June got her nursing degree and moved to Knoxville. Damon used to call Mrs. Peggot Mammaw, which embarrasses him now. Mrs. Peggot is the only one who keeps using his given name, Damon, after everyone else starts calling him Demon. Once he gets red hair, he gets the nickname "Copperhead" along with Demon, so he becomes, "Demon Copperhead."

The Peggots belong to a large community, which includes their extended family and Maggot, a grandchild the Peggots have taken in to raise. They are so invested in community, the passage suggests, that they even provide homes for animals that can't be of any use to them. Similarly, the Peggots welcome Demon into their home, their family, and their extended community, caring for him and expecting nothing of him in return.



Demon is so close to the Peggot family and feels so at home with them that he once believed that Mrs. Peggot was his grandmother. While the sentiment shows Demon's acceptance within the Peggot family, it also highlights the fact that Demon and Mom do not have much of an extended family. This will become a problem for Demon when he lacks the support to help him through difficult situations later in life.



CHAPTER 3

Murrell Stone, whom people call Stoner, shows up, and Mom immediately likes him. He drives a Harley, is bald as a cue ball, has bulging biceps, and has gauges in his ears. In other words, to Mom, he's the ideal of masculinity. Mom tells Demon this over shared menthol cigarettes, even though Demon is still a little kid. Over pizza one night, when Mom is gone but Demon is there, Stoner asks his friends what they would do if they found a cherry Camaro they wanted, but it had a trailer attached to it. Stoner and his friends keep making jokes, and Demon is confused by what they mean. After school is out for summer after fourth grade, the Peggots offer to take Demon with them to visit Maggot's aunt June in Knoxville. Demon is sure Mom will say no, but, surprisingly, she agrees.

To Mom, Stoner is the ideal of masculinity, but the novel portrays him in a negative light, highlighting the traits of toxic masculinity he embodies. He also jokes that he would get rid of Demon if he could, showing his callousness and hinting at how badly he will treat Demon throughout the course of his relationship with Mom. The passage also shows that Mom and Demon are close, but not in particularly healthy or helpful ways: for instance, they share cigarettes. This detail illustrates how a person can inherit their family's hardships.



CHAPTER 4

In Knoxville, Demon is surprised to find Emmy Peggot, the daughter of Maggot's dead uncle Humvee, living with Aunt June. Emmy's a sixth grader with long brown hair, a Hello Kitty backpack she carries everywhere, and a "cold-blooded" look to her. It's the first time Demon has been to a city, and every time he sees something like a police car with a dog in it or a tow truck with a wrecked car on the back, he exclaims, "Oh man, look at that!" Emmy glares at him like she can't believe he's so naïve. Demon had expected he'd be able to get outside of the city more easily. By the end of their two-week visit, though, Demon determines that a city is, in essence, "a hot mess not easily escaped."

Demon and Maggot spend their time in Knoxville with Emmy, who tells them stories of the suitors Aunt June rejected and shows them her stash of gum and cigarettes, which she hides under the carpet in June's closet. Aunt June, Demon thinks, is completely different from Emmy. She's very nice but "[takes] no shit." June takes them to the aquarium in Gatlinburg, and Demon is amazed by the sharks, rays, and sea turtles. Emmy, though, is scared of the sharks when they visit the shark tunnel. Seeing the fear in Emmy's eyes, Demon comforts her, assuring her that they won't leave her behind. Afterward, Demon buys her a bracelet in the gift shop and says it's her bravery badge. On the ride home, Emmy says she's in love with him, and they should get married when they're older.

Demon's connection to the Peggot family grows during this trip to Knoxville when he spends time with Aunt June and Emmy. Demon's response to Knoxville also continues to establish the divide between people of rural areas and the city, a divide that influences some of the stereotypes that outsiders apply to the people of rural Appalachia. While Demon does not use stereotypes or prejudices to understand the city or the people in it, and while he even enjoys parts of it, he also does not feel at home there. His description of the city as "a hot mess not easily escaped" underscores the novel's main theme of fate vs. free will, suggesting that a person can struggle to move beyond the circumstances into which they were born, regardless of where, geographically, they're from.



When Demon sees that Emmy is afraid at the aquarium, he goes back to help her. This gesture shows Demon's attentiveness to the people around him, making it clear that he is empathetic, emotionally aware, and caring. While Demon doesn't think he did anything extraordinary in helping Emmy, Emmy keeps the bracelet he gives her into adulthood, showing how meaningful Demon's action is to her. The bracelet, then, also comes to symbolize not just the bond that Emmy and Demon share, but also the bond of community and family that Demon feels with the Peggot family.



CHAPTER 5

When Demon returns from the two-week trip to Knoxville, he finds out Mom and Stoner have gotten married. Stoner and Mom take over Demon's bedroom because that's the bigger one, but Mom promises they'll get a better house soon because Stoner makes good money. Stoner's dog, Satan, moves into a fort that Demon and Maggot built together. Demon plans to spend all his time at Maggot's during the summer, but his mom isn't on board. She thinks the Peggots are turning Demon against Stoner, and she forbids Demon from visiting them. Demon says she can try and stop him. Mom replies that while she might not be able to stop Demon, Stoner sure can.

Stoner's opposition to the Peggot family underscores the novel's view of community and family. Though as Demon's stepfather Stoner is technically a closer relative to Demon than the Peggots, Demon does not feel like he's a family member, and Stoner does not show Demon any care or attention. Instead, his dog, aptly named Satan, moves into a fort that Demon and Maggot built, showing that Stoner does not care about Demon or his friends. Stoner seems to only care about himself, underscoring the novel's point that family is less about hereditary or legal ties and more about establishing mutual care, trust, and understanding with others.



Stoner's money comes from his job driving a semi-truck with a special license that allows him to transport beer. His job also gives him medical and dental insurance, which Demon hasn't had before and is now eligible to receive as Stoner's dependent. Stoner tells Demon that Mom has been treating him too leniently. Now, Demon will have to start learning how righteous people live: with discipline and respect for others. One morning, he hits Demon in the jaw. When Demon asks what he did to deserve it, Stoner says it's not what did, it's what he was thinking. When Demon tells Mrs. Peggot about Stoner, she says she'll have to talk to Mom or call social services.

Mrs. Peggot ends up talking to Mom, who then tries to talk to Stoner about his treatment of Demon during a commercial break in the middle of an episode of *Law & Order*. Stoner dismisses Mom, implying that her drug use doesn't exactly make her a model parent, either. He says Demon spends more time at the Peggots than at home and refers to Maggot using the f-slur. Stoner tells Demon that he'll never let Demon go over to the Peggots house again to play with Maggot. Mom agrees with Stoner, and Demon doesn't think he'll ever forgive her for it. For the next week, Demon stays inside watching reruns of *X-Men*, *Iron Man*, and *Hulk*, or reading and drawing comics with Stoner as the villain. That night, Demon decides he will "burn the man down."

CHAPTER 6

The story of how Mariah Peggot, Maggot's mom, ends up in prison starts with her falling for the wrong man, Romeo Blevins. Because Romeo is practically attractive enough to be a model, Mariah thinks he's out of her league and feels like she's won the lottery when he becomes interested in her. Mrs. Peggot warns Mariah about him and forbids her from seeing him. Mariah sees no other choice but to sneak around. When she becomes pregnant, she moves in with Romeo in his A-frame house outside Duffield. Romeo starts going out with other women and says Mariah should feel lucky she's carrying his baby. When she has the baby, she tries to get Romeo to stay home more, but the two constantly argue.

One night, Mariah says she's going to call her sister June so she and the baby can leave. Romeo knocks her down and ties her hands together with the phone cord, drags her outside, and ties her to the deck. He finds his Ruger and puts it in her mouth. Eventually he gets bored and drives away before coming back two hours later, asking if Mariah is sorry. When she says yes, he unties her, and that passes as making up in their relationship. Things only get worse from there. Romeo gets into a habit of tying up Mariah, and he once leaves her tied up all night while the baby, Matty, cries.

Soon after lecturing Demon about the need to live with discipline and respect for others, he hits Demon, committing an act of child abuse and revealing how hypocritical he is. Notably, Stoner does not seem to realize his hypocrisy or feel bad about his actions. Instead, he seems to believe that he is acting righteously and with respect for others. Stoner's lack of self-awareness becomes a hallmark of the novel's portrayal of his toxic masculinity. And when Demon is in need, the Peggots are again the people who step in to help him.



When Stoner dismisses Mom and then calls Maggot a homophobic slur, he further displays his bigoted, hateful personality. Both characteristics are aspects of his toxic masculinity and represent his attempts to view himself as superior to other people. Demon takes refuge in comics and superheroes, hinting at how comics and art in general will offer him an escape from the problems of his everyday life. Notably, the idea that superheroes can defeat the evil they face also gives Demon glimpses of hope for a better future.



The story of how Maggot's mom ends up in prison puts the difficulties of Demon's life in context. Through Mariah's story, the novel argues that Demon's circumstances are not exceptional. Instead, many people, including Maggot and the Peggot family, have similarly difficult family histories. This indicates how generally widespread many of the problems Demon faces are, in his community and perhaps throughout the region.



Romeo's violent treatment of Mariah shows the depths of his misogyny and toxic masculinity. Notably, Mariah first thought of Romeo as charming and handsome, qualities that hid his propensity toward violence. After Romeo abuses Mariah, he tells her to apologize, and they make up after she does, a dynamic that further illustrates the emotional manipulation to which Romeo subjects Mariah.



After that night, Mariah keeps a knife taped to her body to use if the situation with Romeo turns violent. After Romeo passes out one night, she slices his mouth on each side until she feels his jawbone with the blade then carves a heart into his chest. She grabs Matty and leaves. She doesn't think Romeo will press charges because he only got what was coming for him. But when the case goes to trial, he "gaslight[s] the jury like [he's] gaslighted Mariah." He says Matty isn't his child—he was only taking pity on a single mother when he let her live with him, but then she turned out to be clingy and unstable. The more Mariah tells the truth on the stand—about being tied to the deck all night, for example—the "crazier" she seems. The jury sides with Romeo, and Mariah is sentenced to 12 years in prison.

The end of the story of how Mariah ends up in prison underlines the novel's themes about institutional exploitation. In this case, the novel shows that Mariah's story isn't just the story of one person facing misogyny and gender-based violence. Instead, the story shows the institutionalized misogyny of a justice system that punishes the victim and survivor of horrific crimes instead of the perpetrator of those crimes.



CHAPTER 7

When fifth grade starts, Demon and Maggot are excited to see each other again and to spend the first day of classes together. They hang out for a couple hours after school lets out, too. When Stoner gets home, he yells at Demon for tracking mud inside. Demon mops up the mess, but Stoner says that's not good enough, so Demon washes the floor with Clorox. Stoner says it's still not good enough and that Demon has to clean it again. Mom is there, but she stays quiet. Stoner then tells Demon to clean the carpet in the living room. The chemicals go to Demon's brain, and he ends up shouting the *X-Men* theme song at Stoner, who puts him in a headlock, covering Demon's mouth until Demon bites him. Demon ends up back in his room with a busted lip.

Stoner's abuse of Demon continues, and the conflict between the two grows increasingly serious. The novel also subtly comments on how chemicals can impact people's behavior. In this case, chemicals from bleach lead Demon to act in a way that he doesn't quite understand, foreshadowing similar behaviors that he'll engage in later when he begins regularly using drugs.



Demon is "on lockdown" for the next few days and over the weekend. The days blur together. Stoner and Mom go on shouting outside his door, and he imagines the Peggots can hear everything they're saying. Demon draws comics in his notebook, coming up with ways to take down the Stone Villain. Stoner flings open his door one night and says Mom wants to show Demon how much she loves him. The statement's strangeness makes Demon nervous. He runs through the house and finds Mom lying faceup in her clothes on her bed, still breathing, but surrounded by **pill bottles**. They're not empty, though, so Demon thinks she had just been trying to get high, not the "total checkout."

When Demon faces what he views as the insurmountable evil of Stoner, he draws comics in which Stoner is the villain, showing again how the idea of superheroes and superpowers offers Demon an escape from his daily life. That hope, though, meets reality quickly when Mom overdoses. While there is no actual hero who can step in and immediately change that reality, Stoner becomes even more of a villain, as his abuse and misogyny have led to Mom's overdose. In response to Stoner's abuse, Mom resorts to drugs to try and manage living in an abusive relationship with no clear way to escape. While Demon's comics might offer him an escape, the reality of his circumstances is increasingly dire and hopeless.



CHAPTER 8

After Demon finds Mom passed out on her bed, he grabs the phone to call 911. Stoner punches him to try and stop him. Mrs. Peggot pounds on the door. Demon rides up front with the driver after the ambulance arrives. Stoner rides in the back with Mom, pretending to be shocked and polite. The Peggots follow in their truck. At the hospital, a woman from DSS speaks to Demon. At first, she wants to know if Maggot, Mr. Peggot, or Mrs. Peggot have molested him. Demon says certainly not and thinks that Stoner must have already talked to her. He then tells the woman from DSS about Stoner and says that, if he could, he would shoot Stoner in the kneecaps and elbows before killing him so he could watch him beg for mercy. The woman writes down everything Demon says.

The woman from DSS asks about other fights Demon and Stoner have had. She asks Demon to take off his shirt and takes pictures of his injuries. She then shuffles Demon to a doctor who will examine Demon's "mental aspects," to see if he is okay to be released. The doctor says Demon can go, but Mom will be recovering for the next few weeks, and he can't go with Stoner, either. Meanwhile, Stoner has made a complaint against the Peggots, so the authorities will have to investigate them before Demon can live with them.

The next morning, Demon's new caseworker, Miss Barks, tells him they've found him a temporary placement with Mr. Crickson on a farm with other boys Mr. Crickson has taken in for short-term stays. Demon wonders if Miss Barks might be his "guarding angel." She says Mom will be released from the hospital and start treatment, which will last for a few weeks. At the house, Miss Barks doesn't want to take him to the door. Demon can tell that she's afraid of something in there and thinks this might be her first day on the job. So much for being a "guarding angel," Demon thinks.

When the ambulance comes to take Mom to the hospital, Stoner acts shocked and polite. The narration implicitly compares him to Romeo Blevins: like Blevins, he is abusive behind closed doors but able to put on an act around others. Thus, those in positions of power initially take Stoner at face value, inclined to believe him on account of his age and his authority over Demon.



While DSS seems to take Demon's true allegations against Stoner seriously, they also take Stoner's untrue allegations against the Peggots seriously. The ensuing investigations leave Demon with nowhere to go. Now, Demon is at the mercy of the foster care system when trying to find the kind of family, community, and belonging he needs to thrive. Although DSS is theoretically supposed to help someone in Demon's positions, that doesn't happen in practice.



Since Demon cannot stay with Mom or the Peggots, the community he had come to rely on for support is no longer available to him. As a result, DSS seems to put Demon's future in the hands of chance. While in theory, DSS would evaluate potential foster placements before sending children to live there, Miss Barks's reaction to Mr. Crickson's farm shows that she knows something is wrong with the farm but is still willing to send Demon there, intimating that the foster system, designed to ensure the wellbeing of children, is hopelessly broken.



CHAPTER 9

Crickson is a “meaty guy with a red face and greasy combover.” He talks in a whisper like Freddy Krueger. Miss Barks runs through her list of preliminary questions with him, clearly frightened, before handing him a yellow envelope. Crickson asks if his check is in there. She says they’ll send it in the mail like they always do. When Miss Barks leaves, Crickson tells Demon that the other boys won’t like a biter and that he’s told them about what Demon did to Stoner. “A wonder no one’s filed off your teeth,” he says.

Demon thinks he might as well have a sign around his neck: “Druggie Mom, Queer Best Friend, Hand Biter.” Whatever Crickson told the other boys will surely spread all over school. Crickson takes him out for a day’s work, starting with feeding the cattle. After school lets out, two boys, Tommy Waddell and Swap-Out, come to the house. Tommy says they knew another boy would be coming because Crickson has to pay a big tax bill every April and September. When the bill is due, he needs the farm to bring in more money, so he gets another boy to come and work. Tommy is nice to Demon, despite Demon’s fear that the boys would label him a biter. Tommy is sweet to the cows, too, which are destined to become hamburgers. Demon thinks it’s like Tommy is trying to “make up for all the bad things in our lives.”

After school, Fast Forward comes back to the Crickson house. His real name is Sterling Ford, and he’s a star on the high school football team. When he pulls up in an F-100 Lariat, everyone acts like he’s Captain America. Fast Forward has been at the farm “forever.” Before Mrs. Crickson died, he was treated kind of like their “real son,” even though he hates Mr. Crickson. Crickson and Fast Forward have a deal to split the \$500 a month check Crickson gets for fostering Fast Forward. At night, Fast Forward comes into the room Tommy, Swap-Out, and Demon share and asks them to hand over whatever money they have. Demon says he doesn’t have any at first but then finds the \$10 Mrs. Peggot gave him at the hospital the night before. He reluctantly gives it to Fast Forward. Fast Forward promises it will go toward a party.

The novel portrays Crickson as a terrifying man right off the bat. Additionally, it becomes clear that he is primarily interested in taking in foster children for economic gain, not because he cares about his foster children. While it may be tempting to identify Crickson as the villain in this scenario, or as the only villain, Miss Barks clearly knows something is wrong and doesn’t do anything about it, implicating not just herself in Crickson’s wrongdoing but also DSS and the foster care system in general. This suggests the power that institutions have over all people, even those with good intentions.



When he arrives at the farm, Demon feels like he is already saddled with harmful stereotypes that will impede his goal of finding community and belonging. Tommy, though, doesn’t seem to care about those stereotypes and treats Demon with kindness and respect. In that sense, Tommy represents the kind of humanity that the novel argues is so often missing from interactions between people, especially interactions between people of different backgrounds, regions, and cultures. Notably, Demon identifies Tommy’s kindness as an attempt to “make up for all the bad things in [their] lives,” showing that Tommy’s care and compassion are rooted in empathy and a deep understanding of the pain that has impacted each person. With that in mind, the novel presents Tommy as the opposite of people like Romeo Blevins or Stoner. Instead of mistreating people as a reaction to his own, unacknowledged pain, Tommy uses his personal experiences with pain as reason to treat other people with more kindness and compassion.



When Demon first meets Fast Forward, he compares him to Captain America, a superhero who serves as a patriotic symbol of the best aspects of the United States. However, Fast Forward is also engaged in economic chicanery in cahoots with Crickson, and, gradually, the novel will reveal the more unsavory aspects of Fast Forward that lurk beneath his charming exterior. Comparing Fast Forward to Captain America, then, subtly critiques the American dream: while it’s an appealing idea that anyone can find success in life, that optimistic view conceals a harsher, less savory reality.



CHAPTER 10

Since they live together on Crickson's farm, Demon starts spending a lot of time with Tommy and rides with him every day on the bus. Tommy likes to draw like Demon, often filling entire notebook pages with skeletons when he's had a bad day. He also tells Demon his life story. Tommy's parents both passed away when he was too young to remember, so he's been in some kind of care for most of his life. He tells Demon that foster care gets worse the older you get. At school, Demon gets to see Maggot. Demon describes Maggot as the only thing he has left to live for. At Crickson's house, Demon keeps helping with the farming while Tommy and Swap-Out struggle with the work. Fast Forward also throws the party he promised.

At the party, which is held in Fast Forward's room, Fast Forward, Tommy, Swap-Out, and Demon eat candy and cookies and smoke cigarettes. The three younger boys listen to Fast Forward's stories about girls he's had sex with. Before he knows it, Demon feels high. Fast Forward tells him that the cookies he ate are "special." He digs a hat out from under his bed and shows Demon the **pills** inside. The boys pass the hat around, each taking a pill at random. Demon thinks other people might have opinions about a ten-year-old boy getting high on pills. But really, Demon thinks, it's an older boy who has never known safety trying to make the other boys feel safe. They have to look out for one another because the adults have left them to fend for themselves.

Through Tommy's story, the novel intends to show again that the struggles that Demon faces are not entirely novel. Instead, the novel contends, many people in the Appalachian region face similar hardships. The novel does this not just to show the difficulties of various individuals but to hint at the ways that injustices engrained in the institutions that have shaped the socioeconomic landscape of Appalachia impact the lives of individual people there.



With Fast Forward, Tommy, and Swap-Out, Demon tries pills for the first time. He thinks people might judge him, or the Appalachian region, because he begins taking pills when he is only 10 years old, but he is careful to note that Fast Forward's impetus for offering drugs doesn't come from a desire to make him addicted or even to get him high: instead, Fast Forward shares the drugs to give vulnerable kids a sense of the comfort and escape that they desperately need.



CHAPTER 11

Demon thinks he's at least halfway in love with Miss Barks. She tells him that he won't be able to go back and live with Mom after three weeks. First, Mom will have to go back to her old life and take regular drug tests. Once she's on more solid footing, they can talk about Demon going back to live with her. When Demon asks about Stoner, Miss Barks says he and Demon will have to "learn to get along better." In the meantime, Demon and Mom will have supervised visits.

The novel presents Mom's path of recovery after the overdose as long and arduous. Notably, when Demon asks about Stoner, Miss Barks says that the two of them will need to "learn to get along better." Miss Barks's phrase places at least half of the responsibility on Demon instead of identifying Stoner as an abusive person who shouldn't be allowed near children, underscoring the pattern of negligence and indifference of Miss Barks and the social services industry.



Fast Forward plays favorites with Demon. He looks at Demon's drawings like they're real comic books and asks Demon to draw him as a superhero. Demon draws him as "Force Fastward, a.k.a. Fast Man." His superpower is his force of will, which can "make anybody do anything and feel glad of it" because they all want to be on the same side as Fast Man. When Fast Forward looks at the drawing, he says Demon has real talent that can't be taught. To Demon, that makes his whole "dogshit" life up to that point worth it. Demon draws Creaky—what the boys call Crickson—as the villain Creak Evil. He also draws the boys as superheroes using the nicknames Fast Forward has given each of them. Swap-Out is WildMan, who can climb anything, and Tommy is SuperBones, who can instantly mend people's bones.

When Demon faces difficulty, he again turns to comics and art to try and find hope. The novel portrays the relationship that Demon's comics and his superheroes bear to his real, lived experiences. He identifies and arguably exaggerates the best qualities of the people to whom he is closest in order to transform them into heroes while focusing on the negative qualities of his antagonists in order to make them into villains. The novel itself is involved in a similar interplay; Kingsolver identifies heroes and villains in the story she wants to tell, and while the novel adds depth and nuance to each character, it is also not shy about identifying its heroes and villains. In that way, the novel presents a commentary on good and evil and heroes and villains, portraying underdogs like Demon as the true heroes and powerful industries and institutions as villains.



Demon thinks the supervised visits with Mom are weird. Usually they'll meet at McDonald's with Miss Barks pretending to read while she discreetly keeps tabs on them. Mom says Stoner is paying for her rehab, and that Demon is her motivation for getting sober. That makes Demon nervous because, if she fails, he thinks it will mean he's not a good enough motivation for sobriety—and he thinks this is a lot of pressure. Mom tells Demon that Stoner has visited her in rehab three times already, the maximum number of visitations allowed. He also brought her a new dress and a card. She says they're going to be a better family from now on. When Demon tells her about Mr. Crickson and the mice, cockroaches, and forced labor on the farm, Mom starts to cry. Demon thinks it's a trap to feel sorry for her, though.

Mom says that Demon is the reason she wants to be sober. While the statement may be well-intentioned and certainly seems to be true, it also puts an enormous burden on Demon and raises the specter of a terrifying possibility: if Mom fails to get sober, it would be Demon's fault. Notably, Mom tells Demon that Stoner is paying for rehab. While that economic arrangement could show Stoner in a positive light, it seems more likely that paying for Mom's rehab is another way that he exercises power over her and, by extension, over Demon.



The Saturday after Demon's visit with Mom, the Peggots visit him on the farm. They'd found out where he lived from the school bus driver, bypassing DSS entirely. Demon shows Mrs. Peggot and Maggot the house while Mr. Peggot talks to Crickson. The house's condition upsets Mrs. Peggot. She asks Demon where Crickson keeps the Lysol. When Fast Forward pulls up, he charms the Peggots like he charms everyone else. Demon feels bad because he catches himself seeing the Peggots through Fast Forward's eyes and wondering if he'll see Mr. and Mrs. Peggot as a "couple of old bumpkins," and Maggot as a boy who is "a little bit odd."

Through Fast Forward's eyes, Demon sees the Peggots in an unflattering light. That change of perspective shows just how mutable Demon's own thinking and behavior is at this point in his life. While the Peggots show him as much, if not more, care and kindness than any other people in his life, he slips into viewing them in a stereotyped, prejudicial way when they meet Fast Forward, whom he wants to impress.



CHAPTER 12

Mom gets out of rehab and comes home. Supervised visits with Demon now happen in their kitchen instead of a McDonald's. Miss Barks is still there, though, to tell them when their time is up. Eventually, Demon gets to spend a whole Saturday with Mom. On that day, she tells Demon she's pregnant. "Holy Jesus," Demon thinks. For the rest of the day, they rake piles of leaves to jump in them and then play music and dance. Mom says Stoner isn't happy about her being pregnant. When Stoner comes home, Mom tells him Demon's happy about the new baby. She says if it's a boy, they'll be inseparable. Stoner uses a racial slur and says that the baby won't be biracial, like Demon. "My dad was Melungeon," Demon says. Stoner tells Demon again that he can't see Maggot, even though Miss Barks has said it's okay for him to see the Peggots.

Stoner shows that he is not only misogynistic and homophobic but also profoundly racist. "Melungeon" refers to a group of people, usually, from Virginia, Tennessee, and North Carolina, who have European, African, and Native American ancestry. The term Melungeon, which comes from the French "to mix," first appeared in the early nineteenth century and was used in a derogatory way. Over time, as the novel points out, people have begun to reclaim the word, using it with a sense of pride, as Demon does here.



CHAPTER 13

One day on the farm, the boys wake up and discover that the water's not running: the well has been drained. Crickson blames Tommy, but really, it's Fast Forward's fault—he left the hose running after washing his truck. But Fast Forward just watches on and then leaves the house when Crickson punishes Tommy, striking him 20 times with a broken hose. Demon is amazed that Tommy doesn't rat out Fast Forward to try and save himself. Demon thinks that's maybe what he would have done.

Here, Demon gets his first hint that Fast Forward might not be the hero that Demon first imagined him to be. Instead of taking responsibility for leaving the hose on, Fast Forward lets Tommy take the blame, even when Crickson violently beats Tommy in response. Many of the villains throughout the novel commit similarly selfish acts, harming other community members for their own benefit.



While Mom recovers from the overdose, Demon gets weekly visits with her. Stoner isn't around for the visits, and Mom complains that he's not supportive of her having the baby. On the farm, Crickson keeps working Demon and the boys hard and never feeds them quite enough. Demon lives for Friday nights when they'll all drive in Crickson's truck to the stadium to watch Fast Forward, who plays quarterback. In September and October, they tend to tobacco on the farm, which is the hardest work they do. One day, Demon sees Tommy gathering the pink flowers that they're supposed to leave behind while topping tobacco. Tommy then sets the flowers on two mounds at the edge of the field. He's made graves for his parents. He never got to bury them, so he makes set of graves for them in every new foster home he's sent to.

Topping tobacco entails removing the small pink flowers or buds from the top of tobacco plants to stimulate growth in the plant's remaining leaves. The tobacco industry is one of the most historically predatory industries in the United States, a fact that Crickson's use of child labor emphasizes. Still, Tommy uses the tobacco flowers to memorialize his parents, showing the novel's contention that one can find or create beauty and care in even the worst circumstances.



CHAPTER 14

About a month after topping the tobacco, they cut it. Demon thinks cutting tobacco is the “bastard of all bastards.” Creaky keeps them out of school for most of October. One week in, Demon gets nicotine poisoning because he isn’t wearing gloves to handle the tobacco. He pukes on his shoes, and the other boys drag him inside. Around that same time, tobacco ads stop playing on TV, but Demon doesn’t know why. At school, teachers smoke during their breaks, and kids smoke at recess.

This passage highlights the exploitative and abusive nature of Crickson’s farm. He forces the boys, who are as young as 10, to do difficult, physically demanding labor that can lead to serious illness. The novel directly links Crickson’s exploitative practices to the predatory practices of the tobacco industry, showing that there is a pattern to the abuse the industry (and the individuals who profit from it) commits.



CHAPTER 15

On November 19, Demon’s eleventh birthday, he gets called to the office at school. He thinks finally everyone has remembered it’s his birthday. He finds Miss Barks waiting for him in the office, and she says she has bad news: Mom is dead. Demon doesn’t want to hear any of it and yells at Miss Barks. He asks her how Mom died. Miss Barks says “oxy.” Demon hasn’t heard of oxy before and asks what it is.

Mom dies from an overdose of OxyContin just after Demon finishes harvesting tobacco for an abusive person who works in an exploitative industry. The novel draws a connection, then, between the tobacco industry and the pharmaceutical industry, which has, during the time the novel takes place, just begun its campaign to overly prescribe dangerously and often fatally addictive opioid painkillers.



CHAPTER 16

Demon could spend the rest of his life wondering if Mom’s death was a suicide or accident. Everyone else seems convinced that she planned it. Demon thinks nothing is right about the funeral. First of all, it’s in a church, something Mom never liked. When he goes up to see Mom in the casket, he realizes that his brother is in there with her. He rides in a limo to the burial, and the whole time, the limo driver, a high schooler, flirts with the girl riding up front with him. “There’s no kind of sad in the world that will stop it turning,” Demon thinks. He spends the weekend with the Peggots. Soon, they’ll clean the trailer they rented to Mom, erasing even the lines that show Demon a hair taller than Mom. “Her life left no marks on a thing,” Demon thinks.

Two things strike Demon about his mother’s death. First, he wants to know whether her overdose was intentional or accidental. Though everyone else thinks she died by suicide, Demon doesn’t want to believe that his mother intentionally abandoned him. Second, Demon notes how little his mother’s death has affected others. Community members, like the limo driver, go on with their lives as if nothing has happened. Demon’s newfound understanding of Mom’s isolation from any kind of community is arguably part of what spurs Demon’s drive to find belonging from that point forth.



CHAPTER 17

Demon has one last supervised visit with Stoner. It's unclear what role, if any, Stoner will play in Demon's life going forward. They meet for lunch with Miss Barks present, and the conversation quickly loses steam. Demon keeps trying to get Stoner to respond in any way he can, but Stoner is silent and completely disinterested in Demon or anything Demon has to say. Demon says he's going out for JV football and has been doing well in school. But Stoner continues to ignore Demon. Demon feels caught between wanting Stoner to care about him and wanting Stoner to disappear from the Earth. In a last-ditch effort to get a response, Demon says he'll be going to Knoxville with Maggot and the Peggots for Christmas. Stoner just says, "You all have a nice time."

Demon's efforts to make Stoner care about him or what he says can be seen as a last-ditch attempt to prove, if only to himself, that his Mom's life impacted someone besides himself. If Stoner showed care or concern for Demon after Mom's death, that would be evidence that Mom left a mark on Stoner. Instead, though, Stoner ignores Demon while waiting for the meeting to end.



CHAPTER 18

Maggot is on board with Demon joining the Peggots in Knoxville for Christmas, but Mrs. Peggot thinks about it all night before deciding to let Demon come. In Knoxville, Aunt June tells them all that she's going to move back home. She's gotten sick of the city and being so far from everyone. She has adopted Emmy too. Knowing that someone can be in seventh grade and then all of a sudden start calling a new person "mom" gives Demon "the strangest feeling." At night, Emmy and Demon talk with their faces moving closer and closer together. Emmy says she's sorry for what happened to his mom, and Demon tells her about the struggles and horrors of foster care. "Poor Demon," Emmy says. "Can't they find anybody to adopt you?" Demon can't decide whether he wants to kiss Emmy or throw up. He thinks that maybe he wants to do both.

This passage shows that the Peggots' generosity toward Demon—inviting him into their home and making him feel like part of their family—is a family trait. Aunt June has done something similar for her niece, Emmy, and has gone even further by formally adopting Emmy. That adoption gives Demon a feeling of hope that he's not entirely comfortable with because that kind of hope could also lead to profound disappointment. At the same time, Demon realizes that the Peggots are not superheroes put on Earth to save him. As Mrs. Peggot hesitates about bringing Demon to Knoxville, it becomes clear that their generosity might be reaching its limits.



CHAPTER 19

Demon feels like the uninvited person in Aunt June's home. But she does a good job of anticipating his needs, slipping him extra food and taking him to places he wants to visit, like the skatepark. Emmy starts visiting him every night, and they talk about "everything under the sun." Emmy tells him she's scared about leaving Knoxville. She also tells him about how she ended up with Aunt June, explaining that the Peggots took her in after her dad died. Then, when Maggot's mom was sent to prison, they took Maggot in, too. They couldn't care for both Emmy and Maggot, so June stepped in to take Emmy, even though she was still in nursing school. At first, June raised Emmy in the trailer that would later become Mom and Demon's. For his part, Demon tells Emmy about his baby brother who died with Mom.

Having noticed Mrs. Peggot's reluctance to bring him on the trip to Knoxville, Demon feels unwelcome in Aunt June's house. Still, Aunt June tries to make him feel welcome, and he grows closer to Emmy. Notably, Demon and Emmy forge their closeness by sharing some of their more difficult memories with each other. They bond over their similar hardships, but those late-night talks ultimately remind Demon that Emmy has a new mother and a family in the Peggots, he is alone in the world by comparison.



Demon feels like he's falling in love with Emmy. She asks him if he wants to "go to second base" with her. When he says yes, she puts his hand under her shirt. He tells her he loves her and pictures them both as adults together. On Christmas, Demon gets various presents from "Santa," and Aunt June gets him a set of markers for drawing comics. The night before Demon is going to leave, Emmy starts crying. She asks him to not get a girlfriend and wait for her until she and Aunt June move to Lee County in May.

Back at the Peggots' house, Demon works up his nerve and asks Mrs. Peggot if they might think of adopting him or fostering him. Mrs. Peggot says Miss Barks asked her the same thing after Mom's funeral. But, Mrs. Peggot says, she and Mr. Peggot are getting older, and they're both having health issues. And Maggot will move out in two years when his mom is released from prison. Mrs. Peggot tries to explain that they don't have it in them to raise another kid. Demon starts crying, and Mrs. Peggot tries to console him. Demon thinks he shouldn't have been surprised. He remembers what Maggot said about Sunday school stories being just like superhero comics. Thinking that Jesus would save the day, Demon realizes, is the same as sending up the Batman signal.

Because they have experienced similar traumas and are comfortable opening up to each other, Emmy and Demon develop a deep bond, even though they're both young. This underscores the importance of forming communities with supportive, empathic people.



This passage hints at why Mrs. Peggot hesitated to let Demon come with the family to Knoxville. She knew Demon would need a home and suspected that bringing him to Knoxville might raise his hopes that the Peggots would adopt him. Mrs. Peggot's refusal to adopt him confirms his worst fears: now, he feels that he has nowhere to go, no home, no family. When Demon mentions superhero comics and Sunday school stories when discussing Mrs. Peggot's decision not to adopt him, he underlines one of the novel's main themes: while there may be heroes and villains in this story, there are no easy solutions, and no one can change the course of history (or the course of a person's life) with a single act.



CHAPTER 20

Miss Barks finds Demon a new home with the McCobb family. They have a boy, Brayley, who is in first grade, and a girl, Haillie, who is in second grade. They also have two baby twins who Demon can't tell apart. The McCobbs never seem to have enough money to make it through the month, and Demon sleeps on an air mattress in a "dog room" at the back of the house, which also houses the washer and dryer and has a rotted floor. They never feed him enough, and even though the McCobbs get money from DSS to foster Demon, Mr. McCobb tells Demon he'll have to get a job to pay his own way. He explains that Mrs. McCobb will take Demon with her to go to pawn shops, making Demon go in with the things she's trying to sell because the pawn shop owners already know her. Eventually, Demon befriends Haillie, who sneaks him snacks.

The novel shows again that the foster care system is as ripe for exploitation as the mining or pharmaceutical industries. The novel suggests that while DSS in theory is supposed to provide for the wellbeing of children in its care, in practice the agency shuffles children from one harmful home to another without caring about how it impacts those children. At the same time, the individuals who foster those children, while they may claim that they are doing good for kids, are motivated by economic incentives.



CHAPTER 21

Mr. McCobb finds Demon a job at Golly's Market, a gas station mini mart on Route 58. Demon's job entails picking through the trash pile—a place where people pay a small fee to dump their trash—for valuables. On his first day, he finds Swap-Out working the trash pile too. Their boss is a guy named Ghost, who has white hair and tattoos and is one of Stoner's friends. Demon gets paid \$16 per day and can eat food at Golly's Market. Following Ghost's instructions, Demon drains battery acid into glass containers. He begins to suspect he's working for a meth lab.

By the fifth grade, Demon is taller than almost everyone, including teachers. Boys want him on their teams when they play games, and girls flirt with him. Everything changes, though, when Demon finds “shit eater loser trash jerkoff” and “asshole” written by his name in an anonymous book that lists students' names and other kids' opinions of them. Afterward, Demon notices people avoiding him in gym or pretending to smell the air when he's close by. Demon tells Mrs. McCobb he's being tormented at school and that people know he's living with the McCobbs. Hearing that people are insulting the McCobb name makes Mrs. McCobb sit up. She takes Demon to Walmart to buy new clothes. But the new clothes don't make Demon feel any better at school. He thinks they make him look even more pitiful because now it seems like he's trying to fit in and still failing.

CHAPTER 22

One afternoon, Miss Barks picks Demon up and says she has good news. On the drive, Demon has so much fun that he doesn't even worry what Ghost will say about him missing work. Miss Barks tells Demon he will start receiving social security checks and will get a percentage of what Mom made at Walmart every month until he's 18. The money will go into an account he'll be able to access after he ages out of foster care. Miss Barks then takes him to dinner at a restaurant where she tells him some bad news: she's leaving DSS. She's saved up enough to pursue her teaching degree full time. Back at the McCobbs', Demon punches the washing machine until his hands bleed.

Demon cannot legally work because he is too young, so Mr. McCobb finds him a job at a trash heap that Demon suspects might also be a meth lab. The job shows just how little concern the McCobb family has for Demon. Like Crickson, the McCobbs are only interested in what Demon can do for them, and they don't care about him or his wellbeing.



This passage shows the novel's views on social stratification, hierarchies, and stereotypes. At the start of the year, Demon is popular in school. As his poverty becomes more evident, though, students start to bully him. Though nothing about Demon's personality has changed, students treat him entirely differently based on their perception of his socioeconomic status. The novel shows that the social ostracization of Demon is based, then, on stereotypes and prejudice against people living in poverty. That exclusion also, of course, pushes Demon further from finding the kind of community and belonging he is searching for.



One by one, the people who care about Demon seem to disappear from his life. While Miss Barks hasn't secured Demon good home placements, she has ensured that he will receive the social security money allotted to him. Once she helps him secure his money, though, she tells Demon that she's leaving DSS and will no longer be Demon's case manager, repeating a pattern of abandonment that has characterized Demon's life. Notably, Demon's responds to the devastating news with anger. In a way, he seems to feel anger instead of other emotions, a signal that Demon has begun to internalize lessons of toxic masculinity, including the idea that emotions other than anger indicate weakness.



CHAPTER 23

Demon is becoming more and more ostracized at school and is close to flunking out. He can't wait for summer vacation, even though it will just mean more time working at the trash pile at Golly's. The McCobbs are also dealing with some serious trouble of their own: their car gets repossessed, and they're debating moving in with Mrs. McCobb's parents in Ohio. When Demon starts working full-time at the trash pile, Swap-Out generously shares weed with him, which makes the work a little more enjoyable. Demon also spends time with Mr. Ghali, the owner of Golly's market, who tells him stories of growing up in a dump in India.

The McCobbs fight almost constantly. Their landlord threatens to evict them unless they pay back rent. They end up paying it with money Demon earns at Golly's. They don't even tell him—Haillie does. Demon storms upstairs to tell them if they want his help, they can ask. He takes his money and puts it in a jar. Eventually, the McCobbs decide they'll have to live with Mrs. McCobb's parents, which means DSS will have to find Demon a new foster family.

Demon hatches a plan. He tells his new caseworker, whom he calls Baggy Eyes, that he'll stay with the Peggots until she finds him a new placement. Then, after work on the day the McCobbs leave for Ohio, he hitchhikes on Route 23. When the person who picks him up asks where he's going, he says Murder Valley, Tennessee, where his dad is supposed to be buried.

Notably, Demon seems to prefer the exploitation he experiences at the hands of the McCobbs to the social ostracization at school. With that in mind, the novel argues that, for Demon at least, social exclusion may be worse than economic exploitation. The ostracization he faces at school has also led him to almost entirely give up. The novel underlines the point that social exclusion based on socioeconomic status has material in addition to the emotional impacts in the sense that if Demon were to drop out of school, his economic prospects would suffer.



The novel shows that while the McCobbs are exploitative and treat Demon poorly, they have reasons for doing so. Those reasons may not excuse their behavior, but they do contextualize it. With that in mind, the novel shows that the McCobbs exploit Demon not because they enjoy seeing him suffer but because they are facing their own difficulties. They are simultaneously victims and perpetrators of a larger system of oppression.



Since Mom died, Demon has had two horrible foster placements and has felt increasingly isolated as a result. Facing the possibility of another placement that could be as bad as the past two, Demon decides to try and find the last remaining family that he is aware of, hoping that he might overcome those feelings of isolation if he finds familial support.



CHAPTER 24

The man who picks up Demon while hitchhiking drives an El Camino. Two dogs ride in the back. They're covered in mud, and the man is too. It turns out he's a preacher who's been camping in Kentucky. Demon tells him he's going to Murder Valley to look for Betsy Woodall, his father's mother. The preacher goes out of his way to drop Demon off at a truck stop where he might be able to get another ride. At the truck stop, a woman asks Demon if he has any ice and if he wants oral sex. "Honey, I'm wanting an oxy real bad," she says. Demon goes into the bathroom, and the woman follows him. He hides in the stall, counting his money while he tries to wait her out.

The threat of danger pervades Demon's trip to Murder Valley. He finds a ride with a stranger who seems menacing at first but turns out to be kind. But Demon's later encounter with the sex worker, whom the novel portrays as being addicted to OxyContin, is more jarring. When the woman brings up oxy, it inevitably reminds Demon of Mom's death. In addition, it underlines how widespread opioid addiction has become in the Appalachian region.



The woman stands on the toilet to see into Demon's stall. She asks him if he wants to share some of his money with her. He bolts from the bathroom, and the woman follows him out, yelling, "Give me back my money help police help me I've been robbed!" The cashier grabs Demon. The woman keeps yelling, saying that Demon has her jar of money. Eventually, the cashier punches Demon and takes his backpack. He finds Demon's jar of money and hands it to the woman. Demon yells at the cashier and tells the woman to "go buy herself a fucking overdose" before he walks through the truck stop's sliding electric doors.

The novel implies that the woman's addiction to opioids drives her to lie and create a scene so that she can steal Demon's money. After he loses his money, Demon feels so devastated and angry that he lashes out against the woman and says he hopes she overdoses, just like his Mom did. That statement again shows that Demon may be more comfortable feeling anger than emotions like sadness, loneliness, or despair, a trait often associated with toxic masculinity. Notably, Demon's anger hasn't seemed to help with work through his grief.



CHAPTER 25

Demon gets a ride from a long-haul trucker and tells him he's on his way to Tennessee, then he falls asleep. Five hours later, he wakes up, and he's in Nashville, which is even farther from Murder Valley than Lee County. Demon gets dropped off at a gas station and then makes a sign with UNICOI, the name of the county where Murder Valley is, written on it. A chatty woman picks him up. She says she likes unicorns, too, and that she's on her way to see her boyfriend in Knoxville. She drops him off at an exit named Love Creek.

Demon's journey to Murder Valley is anything but easy. To get there, he has to rely on strangers and ends up taking wrong turns. That journey, then, provides a glimpse into Demon's psyche by showing the lengths he's willing to go to find a family he isn't sure exists. While Demon tries to maintain a positive attitude during the trip, at this point in his life he has no home, almost no food, and no money, and so he's more desperate than he might let on.



In Love Creek, Demon eats his last food, a Slim Jim he stole from Mr. Ghali. Demon remembers Mr. Ghali telling him that in India, he and his family were "so-called no-toucher" people, people whom others in India refused to touch. Or, if Mr. Ghali touched food, they would refuse to eat that, too. Mr. Ghali said the name for those people was, as Demon remembers, something that sounded like "dolly." Mr. Ghali was amazed that in the U.S., he can touch food and serve it to anyone, and they'll eat it without thinking twice about it. Demon, though, thinks that while there may not be a word for "no-toucher" people in the U.S., there are certainly people who are never touched. If there were a word like that in the U.S., Demon thinks, "it would get used."

Mr. Ghali explained to Demon that in India, he was considered a Dalit person, a member of a caste of people who were once called "untouchables." Mr. Ghali is referring to the caste system in India, which determines a person's socioeconomic standing. Dalit people are considered the lowest members of the caste system. Historically, people of other castes refused to touch them or objects they had touched. Mr. Ghali was pleasantly surprised that his caste status did not follow him to the U.S. Demon believes, though, that there is a different kind of caste system in the U.S., which also includes a bottom rung for people whom others refuse to touch (figuratively). He seems to reference the social ostracization he experienced at school, and he suggests that the poor treatment people receive in the U.S. is often the result of shared prejudices and stereotypes within a community that function similarly to the caste system in India that Mr. Ghali described.



It takes three more rides for Demon to get to Unicoi County. When he gets to Murder Valley, Demon asks everyone he comes across if they know Betsy Woodall. No one does, until Demon finds a group of men outside a feed store. When he asks about Betsy, one says she was last seen riding a broom. They keep making jokes about Betsy being a witch until Demon lashes out at them. Then, they give him directions to find her in a yellow, two-story house. He doesn't notice the woman pulling weeds out front right away. When she sees Demon, she angrily tells him to leave. But when Demon tells her he's her grandson, her attitude changes "Oh, lord," she replies.

Before Demon meets his grandmother, Betsy, he gets a sense of her reputation within Murder Valley. That reputation seems to be based on sexist and misogynistic tropes derived from toxic masculinity, as the men refer to Betsy as a witch. The novel underlines, then, how stereotypes and prejudices determine one's socioeconomic standing within different communities.



CHAPTER 26

Demon's grandmother doesn't want anything to do with men or boys. Betsy says she raised 11 girls total, and many of the girls she took in were the babies of teenage mothers. But Betsy says she never took money, unlike the foster parents Demon knows. Demon thinks that his mom's story was true then—that Betsy showed up before he was born, ready to take him in if he was a girl. Demon tells her how and why he ended up looking for her. They sit listening to the clocks until Betsy says he should meet her little brother Dick.

Betsy is quick to clarify that she raises the girls she takes in outside of the DSS or foster-care systems. In Betsy's mind—and as Demon's experiences show—the social service institutions are hopelessly corrupt and ineffective. Betsy's ethos makes it clear that she believes you shouldn't try and help people for the money but because it's the right thing to do, establishing her as the antithesis to the various institutions and industries that aim to exploit people throughout the novel.



Brother Dick, Demon soon discovers, is in a wheelchair. Demon thinks that he is "little and crooked and pigeon-boned." Betsy asks Dick what they should do about Demon, and Dick says he needs a bath and new shoes. Jane Ellen, the eleventh of Betsy's 11 girls, brings clothes and shoes over for Demon. The four of them share dinner before Betsy shows Demon to his room.

While Betsy, Dick, and Jane Ellen don't know Demon—and Betsy has a policy against taking in boys—they welcome Demon warmly, providing him the shelter, food, and community that he has so desperately needed.



CHAPTER 27

It takes Betsy a while to make up her mind about Demon. She doesn't want any relative of hers to be turned over to DSS, but she'd also rather "shoot herself in the head than raise a boy." At first, Demon is afraid to talk to Dick. Betsy then tells Demon that Dick was born with "a spinal type of thing," and his father put him in a home in Knoxville, where he remained out of sight until the rest of the family died and Betsy could get him out. After that, Demon feels a kinship with Dick. "One no-toucher kid knows another," Demon thinks. Demon starts talking to him and asking questions about their family. One day, Demon sees Dick writing on a kite. He writes quotations from the books he reads in careful, neat handwriting onto a homemade kite. Once he's filled the kite with quotes, he'll fly it.

When Demon learns more about Dick's story, especially about how Dick's family repeatedly tried to abandon him, Demon feels a kinship with him. In Demon's telling, he, as a "no-toucher kid," recognizes Dick as a similar kind of person. Demon's statement furthers his argument that while the U.S. does not have a formal caste system, the way that society discriminates against people living in poverty is similar to the discrimination people face in caste systems, and Demon senses a deep injustice in how people have treated him and Dick.



Betsy insists that Demon go to school. She's proud that most of the girls she raised have gone to college and wants Demon to get an education, too. She asks Demon about the social security money Demon is supposed to get since Mom died. When Demon tells her about it, she says he'll have to stay in Virginia then, "legalwise." Demon says if he's going to be in Virginia, he wants to be in Lee County. Betsy says she has girls who live over there. One of them died of breast cancer, but her husband, a schoolteacher, is still in the area. Demon recognizes the name, Winfield: he's the coach of the Lee High Generals football team. Before he leaves, Demon flies the homemade kite with Dick.

In this passage, the novel stresses the importance of family and community for Demon. Now that Demon has found his grandmother, Betsy seems to genuinely care about him despite only knowing him for a few days: now, she seems willing to act on his behalf. Demon has been missing a person like that in his life: someone who cares about him and is willing to take care of him without expecting anything in return. The novel highlights, then, how important family and community are in general, and specifically for Demon. Betsy's support seems to offer him a second chance to thrive.



CHAPTER 28

Jane Ellen drives Demon to meet Coach Winfield. But it's not Coach Winfield who greets Demon. Instead, the "weirdest human" Demon has ever seen shows up. He has stick legs, long arms, red hair, and long fingers. He says Coach Winfield is caught up with Saturday practice. He introduces himself as Ryan Pyles and says people call him U-Haul. Demon doesn't want to go with the man, but neither he nor Jane Ellen sees any other choice. Demon goes to his new home with U-Haul then. The home turns out to be a mansion overlooking downtown Jonesville. Demon looks around and sees athletic gear strewn all over the place. Without Demon realizing it, a kid sneaks up behind him, wearing a flat detective's cap, a leather jacket, and Doc Martens.

Demon gets a bad feeling from U-Haul immediately, perhaps foreshadowing that U-Haul will create trouble for him in the future. Note that U-Haul comes to pick up Demon, whom Coach Winfield will be fostering, showing how intimately U-Haul is involved in Coach's daily life. Finally, the detail of the athletic gear strewn throughout Coach's house seems to suggest that sports take precedence over everything else in his life.



It's Coach Winfield's kid, Angus, who is the child of the girl Betsy raised who died of breast cancer. Demon assumes Angus is a boy. Coach Winfield comes down the stairs. "You look like a linebacker," he tells Demon. Demon can hardly contain his excitement. In his excitement, he makes a crass remark about linebackers being popular with cheerleaders. Angus seems mortified by what Demon says. A woman named Mattie Kate puts their dinner on the table. Coach Winfield says she'll wash the dishes in the morning. Angus shows Demon to his room, which he'll have all to himself. When Angus comes back wearing pajamas, Demon realizes that she is a girl, not a boy, and thinks back over all of the stupid things he said to her.

After Demon realizes that Angus is a girl, he's embarrassed by his previous comments about cheerleaders. That embarrassment points to a couple of significant aspects of Demon's personality. First, Demon seems to code-switch based on whether he is around men or women. For the entire time he's meeting Angus, he gauges the situation to determine what he should say to make Angus like him, a learned behavior, potentially, from the past times he has been abandoned: fearing that he will be abandoned once more, he does everything he can to ensure that others accept him. Notably, when Demon thinks Angus is a boy, he tries to build comradery with her by sexualizing women—something Angus finds repellant—pointing to ways that Demon may have adopted behaviors of toxic masculinity in order to gain social acceptance.



CHAPTER 29

Demon starts attending Jonesville Middle School, and the kids seem different from the ones he went to elementary school with. Demon thinks the kids in his new school might know more than him academically, but they don't know anything about how the world works. They especially don't know about money. Angus takes Demon shopping at Walmart and buys him new shoes with Coach Winfield's credit card, which Demon is reluctant to use. After their rocky start, Demon and Angus start getting along okay. Angus is two grades ahead of him in school and tells him what to expect, and Demon tells her about his history.

Demon's life with Angus and Coach Winfield is much different from any life he's lived before. Living with Coach also catapults Demon into a higher socioeconomic status. With access to money, Demon finds that he can avoid the pitfalls of poverty that led to his ostracization in his previous school, underlining Demon's idea that poverty, especially extreme poverty, can lead to social exclusion in the U.S.



CHAPTER 30

At school, other kids treat Demon like a different person. They don't know who he is to Coach, but they know Coach is the one in charge, and they respect him because of that. Coach also lets Demon help out with the football team on Saturdays. One day, Coach plays catch with Demon, and Demon sees him beaming. Demon is placed in remedial classes because he's behind in school, and he's also sent to meet with the guidance counselor, Mr. Armstrong. When Mr. Armstrong first meets with Demon, he tells Demon that he's read Demon's DSS file and that he is resilient. Mr. Armstrong then gives Demon a test with different diagrams. Demon completes this test easily, and Mr. Armstrong says it's a gifted and talented test and that Demon should make up the work he missed so he can go into the gifted and talented program.

In this passage, and through Demon's interaction with Mr. Armstrong, the novel argues that Demon has been pigeonholed as a certain type of person—namely, as a poor student—because of his background and his lower socioeconomic status. Various teachers, the novel contends, have assumed that he is not good at school because of the family he came from. As soon as he is part of a different socioeconomic status—and meets someone like Mr. Armstrong, who can see beyond stereotypes—Demon is identified as the gifted student he always has been, underlining how stereotypes and prejudice harm people.



When other boys in Demon's math class discover he can draw, they ask him to do nude drawings for them. Demon and Angus start spending time together regularly. Demon hasn't had a friend since Maggot, whom he hasn't seen in a long time. He thinks it's a little strange to spend all his time with a girl, but he also doesn't think that Angus is like other girls he's met. She tells Demon that her real name is Agnes. She started going by Angus when kids used the name to tease her in first grade. To make them stop talking, she started using the name herself. As the season continues and the Lee High Generals remain undefeated, Coach becomes more and more scarce around the house.

The novel portrays Angus as defiantly unique: she trusts in her instincts and moral compass. Demon, on the other hand, seems easily swayed by others. He draws nude pictures for other boys in his math class because they want him to and worries that it might be strange to spend all of his time with a girl (meaning Angus). In a sense, Demon's journey throughout the novel charts his path as he goes from someone who insecurely seeks the approval of others to someone who is comfortable in his own skin: in other words, he becomes someone more like Angus.



CHAPTER 31

One day, Mrs. Peggot calls Demon at Coach's house, and they arrange for Demon to go to the Peggots to see Mr. Peggot, Mrs. Peggot, and Maggot. When Demon arrives on a Saturday after football practice, the Peggots gather around him like he had "come back from the moon." Maggot looks different: he wears makeup around his eyes and has two rings in his bottom lip. They talk about Jonesville and Coach, and they ask why Betsy only started taking an interest in him now. Demon says she hadn't been interested in him before because she didn't know he existed. But Mrs. Peg reveals that this isn't true: Betsy has known about him all along.

After that, Demon finally gets the true story of Betsy coming to visit his mother. Mrs. Peggot says Betsy didn't visit on the day of Demon's birth, like Mom said, but a few weeks before. She came and wanted to "take away the baby." Mom refused. Demon thinks his mom had good reason, then, for not wanting Demon to be connected to his dad's side of the family, because she was afraid Betsy might still try to take him away. Maggot tells Demon that his mom will be in prison for longer because her parole was denied. He also says that Emmy has a boyfriend. June and Emmy have moved closer to home now that June is working at the Pennington Gap clinic as a nurse practitioner. Demon goes to see their home, which Mr. Peggot describes as a "geometric dome."

At June and Emmy's house, Emmy takes Maggot and Demon to her room and tells them "her secrets, just like old times." After Maggot prods her, Emmy says she and Hammer aren't dating. They're just friends. She doesn't seem to remember kissing Demon, but she's still wearing the bracelet he gave her around her ankle. Emmy says she hates June's boyfriend, Kent, a pharmaceutical rep who never seems to stop talking. Maggot puts on some of Emmy's clothing. When Mrs. Peggot calls up that it's time to leave, Emmy and Demon stall for long enough for Maggot to change back into his own clothes.

Demon continues his quest to find family, community, and belonging. At this point, he has found partial belonging with Betsy and Dick, with Coach and Angus, and with the Peggots. In a way, the novel hints that Demon might already have everything he's looking for. But, the novel argues, he will not be able to recognize that or truly feel the sense of belonging he's looking for until he directly addresses his past trauma and the resulting pain. Until he does that, the novel suggests, Demon will always be running from something, even if he feels mostly at peace with his life. In other words, he will be surviving, not thriving.



When Mom told Demon about his grandmother, Betsy, coming and trying to take him away, she said that Betsy came the day he was born. Demon had thought Mom invented the story to obscure the fact that she was passed out from drugs while she gave birth to Demon. Demon could have been right in the sense that Mom may have changed the timeline of the story out of shame. But the revelation Mrs. Peggot shares with Demon complicates that theory. Knowing the truth of the story makes Demon understand why Mom never wanted him to know anything about his dad's side of the family. Mom was concerned, Demon thinks, that if Demon tried to make a connection with Betsy, Betsy might try and take him away again. Though Demon isn't entirely sure what to make of the story, it does seem to show how fiercely Mom loved him, making it clear that, unlike what Mrs. Peggot's story may have implied, he wasn't an accident or someone his mother didn't care about. Instead, she cared about him deeply, if also imperfectly.



This passage shows again that while Demon is flawed, he also deeply cares about his friends and consistently shows up for them and protects them. For example, Emmy still wears the bracelet he gave her when they were just children, and when Maggot dresses in Emmy's clothes, he and Emmy work together to ensure that Mrs. Peggot won't find out, protecting Maggot from the kind of judgment and prejudice they fear would come from Mr. and Mrs. Peggot.



CHAPTER 32

With Christmas approaching, Demon asks Angus what their family does for the holidays. She says they don't really do anything. She says Christmas is hard for her dad because her mom died around Christmastime. But Demon insists that they celebrate Christmas. They steal a tree from Crickson's farm. When they bring it home, they decorate it with whatever they can find, including old CDs, Angus's earrings, and spoons. The night of December 23, they can't wait any longer. They run downstairs while Coach is asleep and open the presents they've gotten for each other. Angus gets Demon a silver Members Only jacket and a ship in a bottle. Demon gets Angus a velvet hat with a veil that hangs down from a pawn shop. He also gives her a framed drawing he made of her as a superhero named Black Leather Angel.

Demon and Angus both love their gifts. Demon thinks stealing the tree from Crickson was the best part of Christmas—it felt righteous. Demon gets one more surprise a few days after Christmas. Coach calls him into his office. Demon is convinced he's about to be sent away to live somewhere else. Instead, Coach tells Demon that he has talent, and he seems like he could be a tight end. Coach says he'll talk to Coach Briggs about putting him in JV practices next fall and that football camp runs for most of the summer. Demon is ecstatic, not just about football, but also because he'll be staying at Coach's house at least through the summer and next fall.

Over and over, the novel shows that Demon—while he has experienced significant trauma—can still form deep and close friendships. In this case, he and Angus not only plan a Christmas celebration together, but they also exchange thoughtful gifts. As a result, both Angus and Demon feel seen by the other, hinting at the closeness that will continue to grow between them over time. The novel frames this kind of mutual care and consideration as the opposite of the exploitation that organizations and corporations exercise throughout the novel.



As soon as Coach talks to Demon about football, the novel establishes Demon's thought process around playing. Demon is excited about being part of the team, but he directly connects playing football to being able to stay at Coach's house and to continue having a stable and supportive living environment. With that in mind, though, if something were to happen and Demon couldn't play football, it's possible that Demon may feel less welcome in the Winfield house. In that sense, while it seems like Coach genuinely cares about Demon, he still views their relationship in somewhat transactional terms—Demon can only stay, he thinks, because he has something to offer Coach. Demon's present insecurities hint at the damage Demon has sustained from exploitative foster care situations of the past.



CHAPTER 33

Demon rises through the social ranks at Jonesville Middle and becomes popular with all kinds of different friends, but things seem too good to be true, and he keeps waiting for his luck to change. He feels like he's still a "jack-shit homeless orphan, just faking it in nice clothes." He also knows what people are like—sooner or later, they'll either turn against you or die. One night, U-Haul corners Demon and accuses him of being self-important. He tells Demon that he better not get too comfortable and that he'll never really be part of Coach's family.

When Demon becomes popular at Jonesville Middle, he suffers from imposter syndrome, suggesting he has internalized the bullying and poor treatment he received at his last school and believes those people saw his "true" self. While Demon may feel imposter syndrome, the novel suggests a more trenchant critique of how socioeconomic status functions in the U.S. by showing that the same person is treated completely differently depending on little more than what clothes they wear.



Mr. Armstrong is a seventh and eighth grade English teacher, but he substitute teaches for Demon's sixth grade class a lot because their teacher is out with shingles. He first came to Lee County from Chicago as a Vista, then met his wife, who was another Vista. Demon first heard about his wife, Ms. Annie, because some people in town don't approve of their marriage because she's white and he's Black. Ms. Annie is an art teacher at Lee High, and, after Mr. Armstrong shows her some of Demon's drawings, she comes to talk to him. She says he has a natural talent and offers to work with him at the high school art studio when he wants.

Betsy comes to visit that winter to transfer paperwork. If she approves of how Demon is doing with Coach, then they'll go to the DSS office together to make Coach Demon's legal guardian. She's satisfied with her visit and says that if Demon keeps at it, everything will be okay. She comes with Jane Ellen and Mr. Dick every few months after that, which means they clean the house more often. With the house tidier, Demon and Angus start inviting friends over more. Demon also starts going to football camp during the summer. By fall, he's wearing his jersey to school. In a year, he'll be playing for Coach.

CHAPTER 34

Demon experiences a lot of firsts that school year: his first JV game, first tackle, first dance, first date, and his first time at the dentist. He also sometimes has to carry Coach up the stairs when he finds him passed out in his office. Coach drinks more in the off season. Demon also has Mr. Armstrong as a teacher this year. He's strict about grammar and teaches the class about stereotypes people use to make people who come from places like Lee County seem "like animals." Mr. Armstrong says outsiders use these stereotypes so they don't have to feel bad about stealing coal and timber from Appalachian communities and leaving them with nothing.

One day, a lifted truck with a confederate flag and a United States flag flying from the back drives by the school when Mr. Armstrong is outside. Later, he tells his class, "The Confederacy and the United States were opposite sides in a war." He says it doesn't make sense for the two flags to be flown side by side. He also says that while Virginia voted to join the Confederacy, the "mountain people of Virginia" formed militias to fight for the Union. Mr. Armstrong gives his class an assignment to delve into their families' backgrounds. Demon finds that "Melungeon" is another word that was invented to put people down before it was taken back and reclaimed by those people. He also talks to Mr. Dick about the project, and Mr. Dick becomes excited about it.

Vista is an anti-poverty program conceived as a domestic version of the Peace Corps. It now operates under the larger organization of AmeriCorps. In contrast to others who aim to exploit the people of Appalachia under the guise of supposed good intentions, both Mr. Armstrong and Ms. Annie seem to genuinely want to help other people, including Demon. In this passage, the novel also addresses the racism that is present in the region but seems to attribute that racism only to a few people with ignorant views rather than a symptom of widespread, systemic racism.



The novel shows just how much Demon's life is changing due to the positive environment at the Winfields' house. His home situation has become much more stable, and as a result he's become popular at school, invites friends home, and begins playing football.



This chapter begins to show the cracks in Demon's stable home life while also showing, through Coach's own struggles with addiction, how widespread addiction is. Coach's turn to alcohol to try and cope with difficult emotions also hints at how toxic masculinity negatively impacts Coach, who attempts to push through his pain without talking about it with anyone else or really acknowledging that it's there. Through Mr. Armstrong, the novel also directly states some of its main ideas about the exploitation and dehumanization of people from Appalachia at the hands of outsiders.



Through Mr. Armstrong, Demon starts to gain a more thorough understanding of Appalachian history, particularly of racism in the region and how it relates to his own ancestry. When Demon discovers the history of the word "Melungeon," the novel addresses one of its themes of people subverting the stereotypes that others try to foist on them. By highlighting that history, the novel suggests that while people who are persecuted may face increased obstacles and uphill battles, they still have agency and can shape their paths forward.



Angus tells Demon that he's going to have to keep notes in a notebook about his girlfriends to "keep them all straight." Demon thinks that after years of being a "no-toucher," he's become hungry for any kind of human contact. Angus, who's in high school now, decides to try and start an academic team. When the school board rejects her plan, she only grows more determined. She enlists Mr. Armstrong to help, but even with him in her corner, she still struggles to get the plan off the ground. Demon is supportive, but from a distance. His main gifted and talented activity is meeting with Ms. Annie twice a week to work in the art studio. Time has never flown so fast for Demon as it does on those afternoons.

The novel shows that while Angus and Demon are very different—Angus wants to start an academic team while Demon wants to play football and be popular—they care about each other in a way that honors those differences instead of trying to ignore or change each other. This reinforces the importance of forming mutually caring, supportive relationships with others. Their willingness to see each other for who they are instead of resorting to stereotypes helps them to better understand each other and strengthens their overall bond.



CHAPTER 35

In the family history project for Mr. Armstrong, Demon learns that almost everyone in his family has some connection to the coal industry. Mr. Armstrong also tells the class about the Battle of Blair Mountain, where the army was called in to break a strike of coal workers. Demon understands the battle as the "biggest war in America, other than the civil one," Mr. Armstrong says the coal workers wore red bandannas around their necks to show they were on the same side and that people calling the people of Appalachia "rednecks, that goes back to the red bandannas."

Notably, Mr. Armstrong's description of the origins of the word "redneck" is only partly true. The word was used before the 1921 coal strikes and seems to have been used as a derogatory way to refer to white people of lower economic classes. Even so, the history Mr. Armstrong describes also hints at ways to counter the effects of exploitation at the hands of powerful corporations and institutions. The novel suggests that the answers may lie in a history of individuals uniting to achieve collective power against those corporations and institutions.



But all of that is in the past, Demon thinks. No one has parents working in the mines now that coal companies traded humans for machines and laid off workers. After Mr. Armstrong points out that there's no work in the area because the coal companies ensured that other industries wouldn't encroach on their business, everything starts to click for Demon. The unemployed dads, moms with SNAP coupons, and army recruiters looking for hopeless kids—Demon sees how it can all be traced back to how coal companies devastated Lee County.

With Demon's realization about how the coal companies have impacted Appalachia, he begins to see that the economic impoverishment of the region isn't accidental or the result of choices of individual people but instead comes from years of exploitation targeted at the people of the region. Now, people in Appalachia continue to feel the impacts of that greed through no fault of their own.



CHAPTER 36

As a freshman, Demon feels like he has it all. He's a rising star on the football team, and Coach feels like a father to him. His name is sometimes featured in the local paper. Once, the paper runs an article about him titled, "From Foster Homes to Football Fame." The September 11 terrorist attacks happen that fall. To Demon, the tragedy doesn't seem quite real, but the army recruiters step up their efforts. All the middle schools feed into the same high school, so Demon and Maggot are reunited, and they go to school with Emmy and Angus, too. Demon starts spending time at the Peggots' house again. Maggot skips school a lot, uses MDMA, and robs more than just makeup from drug stores. The Peggots don't know what's going on with him or what to do about his behavior.

Demon is on top of the world. He has everything he's been searching for: a family, friends, a stable life, and popularity. Altogether, he feels a sense of belonging. He's a rising star on the football team and goes to school with his closest friends. It seems like he is no longer at risk of dying like he fears his mom did, without leaving a mark. But that sense of belonging also carries with it a tinge of threat. The novel seems to argue again that the belonging he has achieved at this point is fleeting at best—and illusory at worst—because he has not come to terms with his painful past, including his mom's death and the exploitation he suffered at the hands of various foster parents.



CHAPTER 37

The football team makes it to the state semifinals. At the game, the cheerleaders make up "Trailer Trash" cheers about them, and spectators throw manure on the field. On a Saturday the following February, Emmy tells Demon and Maggot that June and Kent are breaking up. Emmy explains that June told Kent that she would no longer prescribe his painkillers, and if he wanted to know why, he could go to her clinic and see people with hepatitis from needles, and whose family farms went bankrupt in six months.

Kent is a pharmaceutical drug representative. His goal is for doctors to prescribe opioid painkillers, and throughout the novel, he serves as a stand-in for the pharmaceutical industry. Earlier, Kent explained that his company aims to help suffering patients, but June now sees the addiction that prescription painkillers have left in their wake. The novel argues, then, that the pharmaceutical companies' benevolent rhetoric was nothing but callow marketing, disguising the corporate greed of an industry that never cared about the human repercussions of its business strategies.



After Angus gets her license, she and Demon take a road trip to Murder Valley. When they get there, Betsy asks them about their plans for the future. Angus, who's a junior in high school, says she wants to go to college to study sociology or psychology. Demon feels hurt, knowing that no matter what happens, Angus plans to leave Jonesville (and him) behind after she graduates. Demon tells Betsy that he might try to go to college on a football scholarship.

In this chapter, more cracks appear in the superficial stability of Demon's present life. While he and Angus are close now, Demon takes her decision to leave for college personally. To him, that decision isn't just a sign that she'll have opportunities in the future: instead, it's another instance of someone abandoning him. The novel shows, then, that Demon's unhealed past trauma may inhibit his ability to form healthy, lasting relationships because his fear of abandonment prevents him from being a supportive and caring friend.



CHAPTER 38

The next summer, Demon gets a job at the Farm Supply store in Pennington. Demon thinks it's the best job he's ever had. The customers are good, there are no rats, and no one's cooking meth. One day, Fast Forward comes into the store. The two talk about their time together on Crickson's farm, and Fast Forward says he has his own 50-acre farm now. He also tells Demon that he's seen him play football. Demon couldn't be more pleased when he hears that.

After their unexpected reunion, Fast Forward makes a point of talking to Demon whenever he comes into the store. One day, he asks Demon if he wants to hang out with him after work. They go to Pennington Gap to cruise down the main street in Fast Forward's Lariat with his friends Big Bear Howe and Rose Dartell. Rose and Fast Forward have a small argument that lasts most of the night. Rose has a large scar on the left side of her mouth. When Fast Forward runs out of cigarettes, she rushes to get more. Demon thinks Fast Forward still has the same charm, and he wants to do anything he can to be around him. Demon can't believe his luck that there he is, "Dragging main" with Fast Forward.

Demon has already sensed that Fast Forward's charming exterior is hiding something more sinister. Demon still reveres Fast Forward, though, hinting that Demon—perhaps due to unhealed trauma—may not be the best judge of character, as he chooses to place his trust in people who have shown that they may be untrustworthy.



Fast Forward still seems like a charming, larger-than-life figure to Demon. His treatment of Rose, though, shows that something more insidious might lurk beneath Fast Forward's persona. When Rose rushes to get Fast Forward cigarettes, Demon interprets it as a sign of Fast Forward's persistent charm. Demon thinks he would run to get Fast Forward's cigarettes, too. Rose's facial scar, though, hints that Fast Forward might be physically abusive toward her, or at least that there might be more to their relationship (and to Fast Forward) than Demon knows.



CHAPTER 39

Demon thinks Fast Forward might be able to help Maggot, so he invites Fast Forward to June and Emmy's Fourth of July Party. Fast Forward picks Demon up. Rose and a woman named Mouse are already in the truck. They then pick up Maggot. Maggot has dyed black bangs, neon mesh sleeves, and wide-legged black pants with chains on the legs. Maggot seems twitchy. Demon knows that he's been stealing Sudafed from drugstores to sell to "cookers," and Demon imagines that they pay Maggot with their product.

At the party, Demon learns that Emmy is going out with Hammer, Maggot's cousin. Demon sees Mouse and Fast Forward leading a group of people away from the party to a small, broken-down cabin and then sees them passing out "small black disks" from a Pringles can. Demon has a bad feeling about it. When he goes up to the cabin later, he finds people passed out with needles and kits. Fast Forward and Mouse are nowhere to be seen.

Demon puts his faith in Fast Forward, introducing him to one of his closest friends, Maggot, and to his surrogate family, the Peggots. That decision reveals Demon's difficulty in judging character. He trusts people he probably shouldn't, like Fast Forward, but remains skeptical of people who seem to have his best interests at heart, like Coach. The novel also continues to show here how addiction impacts almost every member of Demon's community in one way or another.



The novel reveals that Fast Forward is a heroin dealer and contrasts his business with the pharmaceutical industry. By describing the people as they appear after injecting heroin, the novel presents a comparison between the pharmaceutical industry, with its legal opioid painkillers, and drug dealers with the illegal opioid, heroin, suggesting that the two are more similar than they may at first appear.



CHAPTER 40

The Farm Supply store has an end-of-summer sale each year. The store's former manager, Vester Spencer, comes with his daughter, Dori, and Demon falls for her as soon as he sees her. After Demon and Dori chat for a minute, her dad has a coughing fit, and they leave. A few weeks later, Demon goes with Fast Forward to a drive-in movie and sees her again. Demon asks how her dad is, and she says he'll never really be okay again after having a recent heart attack. When she asks about Demon's parents, he wants to lie, but he doesn't. He tells her they've both died. It turns out that Dori has had experiences with DSS, too, because the state wasn't sure if her dad should raise a girl alone.

After Dori goes back to the group she came with, Demon runs into Tommy. He never got adopted, but he's living in an apartment with roommates and has a girlfriend. When Demon goes back to Fast Forward's truck, he's with a woman who people call Car Wash. Rose then comes up and slams a paper bag on the truck's tailgate. She says she had to drive all the way to Kentucky to get whatever's in the bag. Fast Forward gets angry and calls her hideous to her face. She yells back that Sterling Ford (Fast Forward's real name) is the worst mistake his mom ever made. She walks away, and Demon follows her to try to get change for Fast Forward.

When Demon finds Rose, she tells him that Fast Forward doesn't own the farm. Instead, he lives in what the owners call a guest house, which is really a barn, and feeds the horses. She explains that her family adopted Fast Forward when he was little after his mom died. They had to "unadopt" him when he was nine, though, because he kept trying to kill the other kids in the family. She says he gave her the scar on her face when he threw a hammer at her. Demon returns to Fast Forward and his friends. They drink the tequila Rose brought. Demon doesn't remember the rest of the night, but he wakes up the next morning halfway up the stairs to his room. Angus helps him get to his room and tells him that he's messing up.

CHAPTER 41

In late October, the football team is six points ahead of Powell Valley at home when Demon gets hit and injures his leg. The injury is so bad that Coach takes him out of the game. The next morning, Dr. Watts comes to see him. Demon overhears the doctor and Coach talking about what the issue might be. The doctor says Demon will have to go to the hospital for an X-ray and MRI. In the meantime, Dr. Watts writes Demon a prescription for a painkiller called Lortab.

Demon and Dori become closer by sharing memories of similar traumatic experiences, which parallels how Demon and Emmy first bonded. That similarity suggests that, in some ways, Demon is looking to heal his trauma through his romantic interests. The novel draws the comparison, then, between the painkillers that are supposed to alleviate suffering and other means people turn to in order to alleviate suffering, like romantic relationships. Ultimately, the novel argues that the best way to heal trauma, though, is to address it directly rather than looking for temporary ways to treat symptoms like pain.



Demon runs into Tommy while he is out with Fast Forward, a coincidence that points again toward Fast Forward letting Crickson beat Tommy for something he (Fast Forward) did. Immediately after, Fast Forward hurls insults at Rose when she returns from running an errand for Fast Forward. The evidence against Fast Forward seems to be mounting, but Demon still can't change his opinion of him, and this reinforces Demon's struggles to accurately judge a person's character.

Rose's story portrays Fast Forward as charming, manipulative, and seemingly incapable of feeling empathy. Still, Demon returns to Fast Forward and his friends, drinking with them late into the night. In the morning, Angus points out to Demon that he has everything he wants—and is throwing it away. The novel suggests, then, that while Demon may have everything he's looking for, he might not be ready for those things because he hasn't addressed his own trauma yet.



Demon doesn't seek out painkillers. Instead, a doctor, who presumably has medical knowledge and authority, prescribes them to Demon. At this point, Coach and Demon are just trusting the word of an established medical professional. That trust points again to the novel's arguments about how pharmaceutical companies preyed upon unsuspecting people to secure their own profits.



Demon spends the next week in and out of consciousness while he takes Lortab. One day, Angus goes to his room while he's recovering. She can tell he's agitated and asks what he's afraid of. Demon tells her that if he can't play football, he'll lose his value to Coach, so he won't really be welcome in the house after that. Angus says her father wouldn't do something like that. Demon doesn't spell out what he's thinking to her: that without football, he'll be back where he started. He would be "the loser Demon" again: the person who is still there, just beneath the surface. And he would never get to be with Dori.

June hears from Emmy about Demon's injury. When he wakes up one afternoon, she is at the foot of his bed, staring at the bottle of **pills**. She asks him how long he's been taking Lortab and who prescribed it. She then examines Demon's leg and tells Demon and Coach that she's not happy with his radiology report because the X-ray wasn't taken from the best angle. After she leaves, Demon can hear her and Coach talking in the hall. She says she used to see a couple of narcotics patients a year, but now she sees a couple every day. Soon after, Demon goes to see the bone doctor, who tells him that he'll probably need surgery. He also refills Demon's painkiller prescription. When Demon picks it up from Walgreens, the paper stapled to the bag reads OxyContin.

This chapter shows again just how profoundly Demon's past trauma has impacted him. Because of his past experiences with exploitative and uncaring foster parents, Demon can't fathom that his relationship with Coach isn't transactional. Demon assumes that playing football is his ticket to stay at Coach's and that Coach will kick him out if he can't play. The novel hints, then, that as long as Demon has that kind of overwhelming fear hanging over him, he won't be able to find true, lasting stability and happiness.



When Demon is at risk, June, a member of his surrogate family and community, comes to try and help him, showing how much Demon's community is willing to show up for him. June also warns about the possibility of addiction, and the novel underlines that warning when Demon receives a prescription for OxyContin, the same drug that killed his mother. By referencing that same drug, the novel suggests that a person's family history can affect their chances of struggling with addiction later in life: it's not just a matter of personal choice.



CHAPTER 42

Four weeks into his recovery, Coach starts letting Demon play. But he's still taking a regimen of painkillers, and he plays like someone on drugs, a second or two behind each play. He tries to cut down on oxy, but then he starts going through withdrawal, so he goes back to a higher dose. Homecoming is coming up, and Demon thinks he'll still be crowned homecoming king. To try and get him to take them as his date, girls start leaving food, underwear, and nude photos in his locker. But Demon only wants to go with Dori.

Dori comes to Demon's house on a Monday with a gift. It's a baby chicken, which Demon said he liked the first time they met in the feed store. Demon strokes the baby chicken's head to try and calm it down. After that, Demon buys Dori flowers and buys himself a new suit jacket. Dori comes to the house every day that week. She tells Demon that after her dad had his heart attack, the doctors found cancer. One day, she lies in bed with him and cries.

The novel traces Demon's slow descent into addiction, implicitly linking that descent with certain traits commonly associated with toxic masculinity. Instead of listening to and acknowledging his pain, Demon tries to push through it to play football again. Notably, Coach is in control of the situation and allows Demon to play while he's still on painkillers. The novel shows, then, the profound mistakes that well-intentioned people like Coach might make. The ramifications for Demon eventually become severe, and it's telling that again, the people who are supposed to care for Demon end up letting him down.



Demon and Dori become closer and seem to emotionally support each other in a healthy way. Dori also reveals more of her own struggles, like her father's illness.



Demon and Dori go to homecoming together. After the game, there's a party behind the gym. When they leave the party, they stop at Dori's house to check on her dad before going to park somewhere. Demon is surprised when Dori pulls out a fentanyl painkiller patch. He's even more surprised when she takes a kit from her purse with a spoon, lighter, cotton ball, and syringe. She says she's been saving it because when you do it for the first time with someone, it's supposed to be "the best you'll ever feel in your life." Demon is afraid of needles, so Dori puts a drop of the liquid on his tongue before shooting herself up. They then have sex in the backseat of the car. The next morning, Demon is sorry he can't remember everything. But he reassures himself that since Dori is "[his] girl" now, everything will be OK.

The novel continues to chart Demon's path to full-fledged addiction. First, he is prescribed opioids by a doctor who has ulterior motives (namely, his own greed). Next, he begins abusing those drugs in an attempt to treat the symptoms of his injury (like pain) without treating the injury itself. Notably, medical professional also facilitate that step in the process. Finally, someone close to Demon (Dori) introduces him to fentanyl, another highly addictive opioid. Demon's thought that "everything will be OK" now that he is with Dori is darkly ironic, as that night also seems to mark a pivotal step in Demon's struggle with addiction.



CHAPTER 43

Dori and Demon plan to see each other again next Saturday. When Saturday comes, though, Maggot calls Demon and tells him Mr. Peggot isn't okay. June picks Demon up to take him to the Peggots. Maggot is in the car with her, but Emmy isn't. June says Emmy thinks the rules don't apply to her and that Maggot has been staying at their house for the past few weeks. No one elaborates further. When they arrive, the Peggots' house is filled with family.

While Demon is going through his own struggles, the Peggots are facing their own challenges. Notably, both Maggot and Emmy are no longer living with their own guardians, showing that while Demon's struggles with housing insecurity are significant, they aren't necessarily unique.



Maggot disappears, and Demon finds him at the creek where they used to play together. Before Demon knows what's happening, Maggot is crying. Demon is afraid to touch him. He thinks of when he and Maggot used to go fishing with Mr. Peggot. Now, he's watching Maggot cry "with no idea what powers existed to save him." That night, Mr. Peggot passes away. Maggot never goes to see him to say goodbye. Instead, he and Demon stay at the creek until the moon disappears. Maggot says he has been living at June's because he and Mr. Peggot had a fight. Demon thinks he would have tried harder to get Maggot to go see Mr. Peggot that night if he had known it would be his last chance.

Demon and Maggot return, both figuratively and literally, to the site of their childhood adventures together. This emphasizes how much their lives have changed over the years. The carefree existence of their childhoods has been replaced by housing insecurity and drug addiction. And even the relationships that once seemed foundational, like Maggot's relationship with Mr. Peggot, have been shaken to the point that Maggot doesn't even visit Mr. Peggot when he is on his deathbed.



Dori and Demon go to Mr. Peggot's funeral together. The church is filled with people from the community. Even Stoner is there. Demon doesn't talk to him. Maggot is wearing a suit and tie. Demon feels proud to sit with the family during the funeral: it makes him feel like somebody of worth. Afterward, Demon and Maggot go outside to smoke weed. They hear a fight break out and walk around the corner of the funeral home to see Rose Dartell grabbing Emmy's hair. Demon separates them, and they both leave before Demon can talk to either of them. Demon asks Maggot what's going on. Maggot tells him that Emmy broke up with Hammer and has started dating Fast Forward. Rose must have seen them and gotten angry.

Demon feels proud and like a person of worth when the Peggot family invites him to sit with them at the funeral. That feeling clarifies why family, community, and belonging are so important for Demon: without those things, he feels worthless. Demon faces obstacles in finding that belonging, though, because he doesn't always choose the right people to trust. That seems to be the case with Fast Forward, whose actions lead Rose and Emmy to get into a physical fight.



CHAPTER 44

Now that football season is over, Coach tells Demon that he should decrease his dosage of Percocet and stop taking oxy altogether. He'll heal then, and Coach will get him in shape for football next fall. Demon tries to follow Coach's plan, but he realizes pain is no longer the issue. The problem now is: "how soon will the bottle run out." Demon feels like Dori is his salvation. The two of them spend most of their time together taking care of Dori's dad, Vester. To have some time away from Dori's house and her dad, Demon takes her to Crickson's farm, which is now vacant. Dori gives Demon the "smallest hit of something," so he doesn't feel sick.

Demon avoids Angus and Coach to spend more time with Dori. One day, when Demon is in Walgreens to pick up Vester's prescriptions, he runs into Tommy. Tommy tells him he's doing layout in the newspaper and got his own place. It's in a garage without a kitchen or bathroom, but the family in the main house lets him use theirs. He also looks after the kids sometimes. One of the kid's names is Haillie. It turns out that Tommy lives at the McCobbs'. Mr. McCobb has started a new business selling a weight-loss product called Wate-O-Way. For a \$300 fee, he signs other people up to be part of the Wate-O-Way sales team. Demon warns Tommy not to put any of his money into the venture. Tommy says he already has.

Demon initially took opioids for the pain that resulted from his football injury, but the pain that comes from withdrawal is worse than the pain of the injury. Demon might not acknowledge it to himself, but he is already addicted to opioids. The novel shows, then, the slippery slope of Demon's addiction. At first, he's only treating knee pain, but before too long, he can't make it for more than a day without taking pills.



Demon's coincidental meeting with Tommy reveals that the McCobbs are the same as they always have been, always concocting schemes to address their financial difficulties. Notably, as Demon descends further into his struggles with addiction, he avoids Angus and Coach. While Demon says he's avoiding them to spend more time with Dori, the novel hints that Demon might also avoid them because he knows he is struggling with painkillers and doesn't want Angus or Coach to find out.



CHAPTER 45

Demon starts keeping his clothes and drugs at Dori's house. He also starts sleeping there more often. He doesn't keep up his connections with most of his other friends, including Angus and Maggot, and he starts skipping school more. After Angus confronts Demon about not following through on what he says he's going to do, Demon plans a trip for **the ocean**. He needs a ride, so he calls Fast Forward. He invites Maggot next. When Emmy hears that Maggot is going, she decides to accompany them. On the first day of their trip, Demon, Maggot, Emmy, and Fast Forward make it to a park called Hungry Mother. Demon isn't sure if Fast Forward and Emmy are still together, but they act like they might be.

Demon continues to avoid Coach and Angus, afraid of what they might do or say if they find out how far he is down the path of addiction. At the same time, Demon seems to be slipping more and more as he skips school and lets his connections with friends fade, showing the toll that addiction is taking on his life. To Demon, the ocean symbolizes beauty and liberation, and he plans an ill-fated journey to see it. Again, the novel suggests that while Demon's life may contain the ingredients to happiness, he is not yet ready to put those ingredients together.



That night, Emmy finds Demon and tells him that someone recently threatened June. She says that every day, people come and try and force her to prescribe them painkillers. Emmy says that June believes half of these people don't even know they're addicted—they just do what the doctors tell them to do, and once the drugs run out, they feel like they're dying. Emmy says Hammer is probably at June's house, protecting her right now. She starts crying. She says she drove Maggot's friend, Martha, to Knoxville for an abortion but lied about it. She says taking Martha was a nice thing to do, but she's a horrible person for always lying to June. She also tells Demon that June is worried about Maggot, who is now doing more meth than oxy.

As Demon descends into addiction, the novel likens his struggles to the issues that countless other people in his wider community face, including Maggot. June's story of people accidentally becoming addicted to painkillers follows Demon's own path to addiction. He had been following the doctor's orders, and before he knew it, when he tried to stop or cut back, he felt like he was dying.



CHAPTER 46

The next day, Demon, Maggot, Emmy, and Fast Forward pass through Christiansburg and Richmond. In Richmond, they stop to see Mouse and stay at her house. They all do lines of cocaine off of a glass table after one of the guys Mouse lives with offers it to them. Demon doesn't get much sleep that night. He thinks the house is the kind of place where people routinely get knifed. The next day, Fast Forward tells Demon that they "screwed around too much" on the way here, and now they have to head home. They're not going to make it to the beach.

On this trip, Demon fails to reach the ocean, which to him symbolizes beauty and liberation. The fact that Demon doesn't make it underlines where he is in his life. While he may want the liberation and beauty offered by the ocean, he may not be ready for it in his day-to-day life, as he continues to lose the stability he had when he lived with the Winfields.



Demon thinks the drive home is miserable. Fast Forward is excited about the drugs he scored at Mouse's house, but Demon starts going through withdrawal. When he gets back to Dori's house, she gives him a hit of something to tide him over. The next morning, Angus calls and tells him he needs to get back to Coach's house. She tells him he found out he hasn't been going to school and is talking about implementing a curfew and lockdown. When Demon gets to Coach's house, U-Haul confronts him. He says Coach has put him in charge of making sure Demon gets off drugs. When Demon asks why he should care about anything U-Haul says, U-Haul tells him he should care because he (U-Haul) knows things about Coach that no one else does. Namely, that Coach has been embezzling money. Demon says, "You are so full of it."

After failing to reach the ocean (and the liberation and escape it symbolizes), Demon's struggles catch up with him back home at the Winfield house. Notably, U-Haul says that Coach has appointed him to be in charge of getting Demon off drugs. Since Coach is living with his own addiction to alcohol, it may have been difficult for him to take on the role. The novel suggests, too, that Coach's own struggles with addiction may have made him vulnerable to U-Haul's schemes and accusations.



CHAPTER 47

Vester dies that winter. Dori doesn't seem like she'll ever get over this death. She worries she might have given him too much fentanyl and that he died of an overdose. Demon tells her she's not to blame for the ice storm that cut off the power and, as a result, Vester's oxygen. Vester's death also means that Dori and Demon no longer have a supply of drugs. Demon figured out a while ago that Dori had been selling Vester's drugs to make money. After Vester's death, Dori and Demon drive to a clinic in Pennington Gap to sell what's left of Vester's stash. The clinic is a pill mill—the doctor inside will write prescriptions for whomever asks—but it can take so long to see the doctor that people will buy from Dori as well. Dori tells Demon that the doctor inside is Dr. Watts.

After Vester dies, Demon can't bring himself to leave Dori at the end of each day, even though he knows U-Haul is keeping close tabs on him, and he's supposed to sleep at Coach's. Then Betsy comes. She says she's going to stop her monthly payments to Coach because Demon has flunked out of school. When Betsy cuts off the money, Demon decides to move in with Dori. After all, she has her own house now and is living there alone. Coach says the money doesn't matter and that Demon is more than welcome to keep living in his home, but Demon still decides to leave. Before he goes, Angus tells him that he should stop using drugs before it's too late, and he should take it step by step and not expect miracles. She also says that she likes Dori because she knows Dori makes him happy.

This chapter shows the inner workings of the opioid market in Demon's community. Essentially, Dori says, Dr. Watts operates as a drug dealer, similar to Fast Forward. The difference is that the drugs that Dr. Watts gets don't come from an illegal source: they come from pharmaceutical companies that are knowingly pushing doctors to prescribe highly addictive drugs. In that sense, the pharmaceutical companies operate on at least two fronts. First, doctors overprescribe pills to people who need pain relief (as happened with Demon). Once those people become addicted, they turn to people like Dr. Watts, who will prescribe them more of the same pills. While Dr. Watts's business model is presumably illegal, either way, the drug companies continue to profit whenever doctors prescribe their pills.



The novel portrays Demon and Dori's love for each other as genuine, but it seems likely that neither is in the best place mentally and emotionally to move in together. Dori's father has just died, and she's living by herself in the house where he died. Demon is addicted to pills and doesn't have a plan to stop. This chapter presents Demon at a pivotal crossroads; whatever decision he makes will dramatically alter his life. To Demon, though, it doesn't seem like he has much of a decision. He feels like he's overstayed his welcome at Coach's house, even though Coach says the opposite. Demon's perception of the situation points to how his past trauma and potential fear of abandonment have altered his ability to trust others, pushing him to make a decision that will most likely put him in harm's way.



CHAPTER 48

Emmy graduates from high school and gets a scholarship to University of Tennessee at Knoxville, but she decides to run off with Fast Forward instead. Maggot tells Demon about it after he starts staying on his and Dori's couch. When Maggot, Demon, and Dori get high together by smoking heroin, which they call "chasing the dragon," Demon can only think about how much it costs. He has some money saved, but without a job, it's disappearing quickly. Dori and Demon decide to get a prescription from Dr. Watts. But when Dori visits Dr. Watts, he tells her that she'll have to pay \$400 up front, and they don't have the money. Dori says Dr. Watts told her he would waive the fee if he could "[give] her an exam." Demon is furious and promises to find work.

The novel continues to show Demon and Dori's struggles with addiction. At this point, it's not just that they need heroin or pills to avoid withdrawals: they also spend most of their time trying to figure out how they can find and then pay for heroin or pills. When Dr. Watts tries to coerce Dori into having sex with him for pills, Demon is furious and feels compelled to find a job to avoid the emotional cost of keeping up with his and Dori's addictions.



Maggot moves back in with Mrs. Peggot. Tommy is the only person who is able to cheer up Demon. Demon will visit him at the garage where he lives and at the newspaper office, where Tommy started as a janitor before being promoted to do layout and ad design. One night, Tommy can't find a clip art picture of a Chevy, so Demon offers to draw the truck for him. Before long, Demon is drawing most of the ads for the paper.

The novel consistently portrays characters not necessarily in terms of whether they are morally good or bad but whether they are good for Demon and can make him feel a sense of belonging. While trouble seems to follow someone like Fast Forward wherever he goes, the opposite is true with Tommy. Whenever Demon is with him, things seem to take a turn for the better, and he makes Demon feel like he belongs.



CHAPTER 49

Demon gets a job at Sonic, and Dori starts cutting hair in a bootleg basement salon. They both get prescriptions for painkillers. Emmy has been missing for two months, and June is not doing well when Demon goes to see her. They both know that Emmy is living in Roanoke with Fast Forward, but they don't know much beyond that. June says she's worried about Maggot, too, and that more than anything, he needs a good boyfriend. "You'd be okay with that?" Demon asks. June says yes.

The people closest to Demon in the Peggot family—including Maggot, Emmy, and June—are all struggling. Emmy and Maggot, in particular, are struggling with addiction. The novel shows, then, how thoroughly addiction has impacted Demon's community, with nowhere for him to turn where addiction hasn't left a mark.



Tommy lets Demon draw a comic strip for the paper. Tommy is upset by the stereotypes of the region that other articles and comics portray, so he asks Demon to come up with something better. Demon makes the superhero of his comic a miner with a red bandanna. In the first comic, a woman's power has gone out. The superhero grabs a lightning bolt from the sky and puts it into the electrical wires. In the comic's last panel, Demon draws music notes coming from the woman's radio as she and her husband dance outside on the porch. Demon names the strip *Red Neck* and signs it "Anonymous."

While Demon doesn't necessarily express it in these terms, his comic strip takes on a political angle. The superhero of his comic is inspired by the 1921 coal strikes in Appalachia and uses his powers to impact everyday people's lives for the better. By naming the comic Red Neck, Demon directly takes on the harmful stereotypes that outsiders use against people from Appalachia and tries to reclaim a derogatory term to show the complexity of people in Appalachia.



CHAPTER 50

Demon meets up with Angus at a small park in Jonesville. Angus tells him that U-Haul is spreading rumors that the art teacher, Ms. Annie, has been having sex with someone behind Mr. Armstrong's back—and that if people want proof, they should ask Demon, who saw it happen. Demon is furious and wants to strike U-Haul. He also tells Angus about the difficulties of his relationship with Dori. Angus tells him, "Whatever you love about her, you get to live with. And the other stuff, you live with that too."

The novel continues to show that U-Haul is a malicious person who wants to take others down, highlighting his willingness to make up stories and spread rumors. Meanwhile, Angus shows again that she is a good friend to Demon. She cares about and is willing to listen to him, even though she thinks he has made mistakes by leaving Coach's house and not going to school.



After talking with Angus, Demon goes to the high school to see Ms. Annie. Ms. Annie tells him she hopes he'll come back to school. Demon tells her he wants her to know he has nothing to do with the rumors about her and Mr. Maldo, the janitor. Ms. Annie tells him that there's a contingent of parents who say they want Mr. Armstrong fired for "being a Communist," but the real reason is racism. She also tells him that she likes his comic strip and asks him why he doesn't sign it with his name. Demon says if it's terrible, he doesn't want people to know it's his, and if it's good, signing it would feel like bragging. Ms. Annie tells him that art is work.

While Demon is always searching for a sense of belonging, in this chapter, the novel shows that community in and of itself is not good or bad but can be used as a force for good or evil. A group of people can band together for horrible reasons, and that a community conspiring to commit evil—like the group of racist people who want to take down Ms. Annie and Mr. Armstrong—can still provide a sense of belonging to its members. With that in mind, the novel suggests that Demon's goal isn't just to find belonging: it's to find belonging in an inclusive community that supports all of its members.



Demon follows Angus's advice and goes home to live with Dori. Trash bags are piling up and dishes grow mold in the sink. When Dori starts stealing from the person who runs the basement salon where she works, Demon gets angry. They talk about getting married. Dori plans what dress she'll wear and thinks about how beautiful she'll look. Because she's high, though, Dori doesn't remember the conversation later.

Demon's life seems to be falling apart. His house is full of trash, and he and Dori are unable to make plans to change how they're living. Demon's anger at Dori begins to mount, too, hinting at ways that Demon may have internalized the toxic masculinity Stoner displayed earlier in the novel: for instance, he struggles to resolve conflicts without resorting to anger.



CHAPTER 51

The next week, Maggot asks Demon to pick him up from Mrs. Peggot's. After he does, Maggot gives him directions to another house, where they pick up Swap-Out. Demon hadn't been aware that Maggot and Swap-Out knew each other. Next, they drive to a Walgreens, where Swap-Out climbs into a tiny hole in the building and steals Sudafed before coming out three minutes later. On Tuesday, Fast Forward calls and asks Demon if he wants to go for a ride to Richmond. Demon says no, and when he asks about Emmy, Fast Forward says they're not together anymore.

Addiction has driven Maggot to escalate his thefts from Walgreens (the pseudoephedrine in Sudafed is used to make meth). Maggot drags Demon along, and before he knows it, Demon has become an accessory to the crime by driving the getaway car, showing the widespread destruction of addiction.



Tommy's boss, Pinkie, offers "Anonymous" \$10 per week for a new comic each week. Demon has no shortage of ideas. As the comic gets more popular, Pinkie says they need to sign a contract, so Tommy tells her that Demon draws the comic. Around the same time, Demon gets fired from Sonic. He goes to dinner at Ms. Annie and Mr. Armstrong's house because he wants to talk to Ms. Annie about the contract at the newspaper. When he brings up the \$10 Pinkie has offered, Ms. Annie says the amount is far too low. She says she'll call Pinkie herself to negotiate the contract and will say she's Demon's agent. Both Ms. Annie and Mr. Armstrong tell Demon he should think about going back to school, and they gently push him to stop using drugs.

The novel shows the potentially unglamorous side of making art. As Ms. Annie says, art is work, and part of that work involves making informed decisions about the business side of things. Through that description, then novel makes a broader point to show that for Demon (and, by extension, people in the Appalachian community), there are no miraculous fixes waiting to be discovered: there is no superhero who will come and save him. Instead, any change in Demon's life will come from careful, concentrated action sustained over time.



Demon agrees to do weekly comics for the newspaper. Ms. Annie pushes Pinkie to get \$50 per strip. Tommy will help him with story ideas and going over the art in pen with a steady hand, so they'll split the fee 50-50. The night Demon signs the contract, Rose Dartell calls him at three in the morning. She says she has something from Emmy to give to him. He meets her at a park, and she tells him that Fast Forward cut Mouse out of his business and started dealing directly with Mexican traffickers in Atlanta. He had been using Emmy as "bait," forcing her to have sex with men so they'll do business with Fast Forward. Demon tells Rose he doesn't believe her, and then she hands him something. When he looks down, Demon sees that it's the "snake bracelet" that he gave Emmy when they were children.

This chapter reveals the true nature of Fast Forward's character, which highlights Demon's difficulties in choosing the right people to turn to for support and connection. While Demon thought of Fast Forward as a charming, larger-than-life figure, he seems to be closer to the coal or pharmaceutical companies that exploit people without caring about how their actions impact others, which is what Fast Forward has done to Emmy. On some level, whether he is right or wrong, Demon feels personally implicated in Fast Forward's actions because he introduced Fast Forward to Emmy.



CHAPTER 52

Demon calls June to tell her that Emmy might be in Atlanta. June says they should find Martha because Martha might help lead them to Emmy. When he goes back home, Demon expects Dori to be at work, but he finds her in bed. She's been asked not to come back to the salon job. Demon thinks it's because she either missed too many appointments or got caught stealing. After that, Dori spends most of her time watching TV. One day, Demon reaches a "breaking point" and throws an empty vodka bottle at the TV.

When Demon throws a vodka bottle at the TV, he once more demonstrates his inability to control his temper or to resolve conflicts in his relationship with Dori without resorting to that anger. Demon's reliance on anger—and his unwillingness to feel other emotions or experience vulnerability—point to the ways that Demon, even though he despised Stoner, internalized some of Stoner's toxic masculinity.



Demon gets a job now at a farm co-op in Norton. The part of the day he enjoys most is when he goes to the paper after work to draw the comic with Tommy. One night, Tommy tells him that he's not really supposed to have visitors at the paper, so they should work on the comic at Tommy's house. Tommy says that he's worried about Demon's ability to function and is afraid he might hurt himself with all the machinery around. Demon can tell it almost kills Tommy to tell him that, but Demon still gets angry and lashes out at Tommy. Demon then apologizes and says he wants to "clean up his act." Tommy says he should go to AA. He also says that it's hard to get clean if you're living with an addict. Demon thinks he won't leave Dori, though.

Even Tommy, who seems to abhor confrontation, has reached a point where he feels like he has to say something to Demon about issues that have arisen due to Demon's addiction. Tommy gives Demon sensible advice about attending AA and the difficulties that might come from living with Dori, but Demon doesn't want to hear it. While Dori is a much different person from Fast Forward, Demon's relationship with her shows his tendency to fill his life with people who might not be willing or able to act with his best interests in mind. In this case, the pain might be mutual, as neither Demon nor Dori seems to have much chance of getting clean as long as they live together.



Demon starts working out of the garage where Tommy lives. Haillie often comes over from the main house to visit him. She tells him about the family and how everything's going. She also tells him she's afraid that Mr. McCobb is in over his head on something with someone named U-Haul. Demon tells Haillie to stay as far away from U-Haul as possible. June hears where Martha is living not soon after and sends Demon to find her and bring her back to June's.

U-Haul reappears in this chapter in a way that makes it clear that he is an unsavory character with bad intentions. Demon also keeps working to find Emmy and bring her home, showing again his willingness to take action on behalf of his friends and the Peggots, who serve as a surrogate family to him.



Demon drives with Maggot to the “crack house” in Woodway where Martha is staying. Martha gets in the car with them when they ask if she wants to go for a ride. She doesn’t ask where they’re going, but when they get about a half mile from June’s house, Martha tries to throw herself out of the moving car. When he gets back home, Demon tells Dori they have to talk. He’s not sure where he’ll go if he leaves. Before Demon says what’s on his mind, Dori tells him that she’s pregnant.

Martha seems to try and jump out of the moving car because she knows where Emmy is or how she is doing and is afraid of facing June. Demon also seems like he’s ready to make a change and leave Dori, but when she tells him she’s pregnant, leaving her seems impossible. This shows how getting sober isn’t just a single decision that Demon can make on his own: it’s a decision he’ll have to make over and over again as his life moves in different directions.



CHAPTER 53

Demon thinks that the prospective baby will help Dori and him get clean. But now, Dori just waits for Demon to leave before she shoots up. Demon goes to see June to try and get prenatal care for Dori and to see if June might be able to help Dori quit using. June is more excited about her own news, though. Through Martha, June thinks she might know where Emmy is in Atlanta, and she wants Demon to come with her to go down there.

Demon’s hopes for a potential new chapter of his life with Dori fade quickly, as she doesn’t seem ready to stop using drugs even though she is pregnant. The grip that addiction holds on Dori highlights again how destructive addiction is.



Demon and June head to Atlanta with June’s brother Everett. Everett has an open carry permit, so he’s there as protection. When they get to the address June has for Emmy, they stop the car and wait outside. The house is in rough condition. June knocks, and a guy inside tells her that he thinks the women who used to live there moved to a house nearby. That house is new, with factory stickers on the windows. June, Demon, and Everett go inside. In one of the rooms, they find two kids lying on flattened pizza boxes. In the next room, they find Emmy passed out, “half naked.” She has bruises on her face. Demon picks her up and carries her back to the car. By the time they get back home, Emmy has woken up but isn’t saying much.

Emmy’s story also highlights the destructiveness of both addiction and exploitative people. Before taking off with Fast Forward, Emmy had been offered a scholarship to the University of Tennessee. Now, she has been thrust into squalor, and June, Demon, and Everett have to find her to bring her out of it. The novel suggests that Fast Forward’s exploitative and manipulative behavior is similar to the behavior of the pharmaceutical companies, and the repercussions that Emmy feels from Fast Forward are similar to how the pharmaceutical industries have impacted regions of Appalachia.



CHAPTER 54

When Demon gets home that night, he finds Dori crying on the couch in bloody pajamas. He doesn’t think she understands what’s happening. After Demon says he thinks she must have lost the baby, Dori cries even harder. Dori wants to “shoot a morphine patch,” but Demon won’t let her. She yells at him and says he doesn’t love her. Demon doesn’t know how much she’s already had and is afraid that more might kill her. At least five different times, he’s come home after a night at Tommy’s to find her on the couch with her eyes rolled back in her head after overdosing. Demon thinks that his only purpose now is to make sure Dori doesn’t die, and he doesn’t know how to do that.

Dori has a miscarriage and wants to shoot morphine to alleviate her pain. Demon won’t let her, and Dori’s response that he doesn’t love her is telling. In their relationship, drug use is framed as an act of love. Dori offers Demon drugs to help ease the pain of withdrawal, and Demon makes sacrifices to ensure that Dori has the drugs she needs. The novel complicates stereotypes around addiction that might frame it as a deliberately selfish or self-serving pursuit. Instead, the novel argues that addiction can be a misguided and ultimately destructive attempt to care for the people one is closest to.



CHAPTER 55

June plans to send Emmy to residential rehab in Asheville. The day before Emmy leaves, Demon goes to June's house to say goodbye. When Demon and Emmy talk, Emmy tells Demon that she's afraid of going to rehab. Demon thinks she's afraid that when she goes away, no one there will know that she's "queen bee, Emmy Peggot." After seeing Emmy, Demon goes to Tommy's. His phone keeps ringing, but he doesn't answer. When he picks up, it's Angus. She says he needs to come over immediately. She says it's about U-Haul. If possible, she wants Demon to kill him.

When Demon gets to the house, Angus and U-Haul are circling the kitchen table. Demon can't tell who is trying to catch whom. Demon tackles U-Haul, and Angus yells at Demon not to let U-Haul escape. She grabs papers from the table and runs out the door. Demon pins U-Haul to the ground, but he eventually escapes and runs out to the driveway, where he bangs on the windows of his Mustang. Angus has locked herself inside. Demon punches U-Haul and then gets into the car beside Angus. Angus tells him that U-Haul has been watching her since she was a child. Now, he's trying to blackmail her into having sex with him. If she doesn't, U-Haul says he'll go to the school board and get Coach fired for being a drunk or for embezzling school and booster funds.

Demon says Coach would never steal money. Angus agrees, but U-Haul is in charge of bookkeeping, and he's been funneling money into his mom's bank account for years. Angus says U-Haul had been altering Betsy's checks to steal money, too. Angus says that U-Haul tried to blame her because she knew about Coach's drinking. Demon says, "This was *done* to you. To you and Coach both."

Emmy's fear about going to rehab highlights one of the novel's primary themes: that community gives one's life meaning and person. Emmy is afraid that when she leaves Lee County, her life will no longer have the same meaning and purpose because she will lose the sense of belonging that she feels at home. Demon tries to reassure her, but he also seems to share the same kinds of fears, and that fear is part of what keeps him in Lee County, even though leaving might be the only way he too could try to get clean.



This chapter reveals the full scope of U-Haul's scheme. Not only has he been embezzling funds, but he also wants to frame Coach for the crime and use Coach's addiction as a way to explain why Coach did it. Beyond that, he wants to force Angus, a teenager, into having sex with him. U-Haul's behavior shows what exploitative and manipulative behavior looks like on a personal, individual level. The novel makes an implicit comparison between the exploitative behavior of people like U-Haul and the exploitative practices of institutions like the pharmaceutical industry.



Demon points out that Angus is not responsible for U-Haul's actions or for the events that happen because of his actions. The novel suggests that the same statement could also apply to people living with opioid addiction in the Appalachian region. It is something that was done to them by pharmaceutical companies, the novel argues, not something they chose for themselves.



CHAPTER 56

In April, not quite a year after Vester died, Demon comes home and finds Dori's body. She has died from an overdose. Angus comes to the funeral and helps Demon get through the day. Angus updates Demon about Coach, too. She explains that he went to the school board to explain everything that happened. They said they might suspend him but would wait until after football season. At Dori's burial, most people don't pay any attention to Demon. Some ask if he knew the deceased.

Demon again finds the person he is closest to has died of an overdose. The novel makes clear, then, the true destructive nature not just of addiction, but of the companies that thrust so many people in Appalachia into addiction, arguing that those companies are responsible for those deaths. In contrast to Mr. Peggot's funeral, Demon is not treated like a member of Dori's family at her funeral, and this deepens the pain of his grief.



CHAPTER 57

Demon starts living in Dori's old car, an Impala, until Maggot finds him. Mrs. Peggot says she wants Demon to move in with them. Demon moves, and he and Maggot go on a bender that lasts for about a month. He can only barely keep helping Tommy with the comic strip. In June, Demon runs into Rose Dartell. She says Fast Forward is back in Lee County and asks if Demon wants to see him. At first, Demon can't imagine going. But then he gets Maggot, and the two of them follow Rose's pickup truck to where Fast Forward is living.

On the way, they see Hammer with a flat tire. Demon thinks Hammer looks downright pitiful. He said he would never get over Emmy, and Demon thinks it seems like he's keeping his promise. Demon gets out to help and ends up changing the tire. It's raining hard, though, and he loses the lug nuts, and they have to leave Hammer's truck. Before they drive away, Hammer retrieves his rifle from the truck. When they get to Fast Forward's house, they're greeted by the woman he's living with, Temple. She gets them towels and coffee. She says Fast Forward is out at Devil's Bathtub. When Hammer realizes they're at Fast Forward's house, he says they have to leave.

After Dori dies, Demon seems to have lost all hope. He abandons any plans to get sober and isn't really helping Tommy with the comic. Moreover, when he hears that Fast Forward is in town, he decides to visit him, even knowing what Fast Forward has done to Emmy. This shows how little Demon seems to care about the decisions he makes now. As the novel has previously established, wherever Fast Forward is, trouble follows.



The writer Anton Chekhov famously wrote—as a way to describe the logic of narrative storytelling—that if a gun appears in the first act of a play, in the third act, that gun must go off. Hammer's rifle serves as the proverbial Chekhov's gun in this situation, and the fact that he runs back to get it from his truck foreshadows the pain the gun will later cause.



CHAPTER 58

Hammer wants to go to Devil's Bathtub to confront Fast Forward. From Demon's perspective, Hammer's reason for wanting to confront Fast Forward is straightforward: Fast Forward stole Emmy from him and then treated her badly. Maggot and Hammer are both on meth. Hammer takes his rifle with him when they leave the car. Hammer and Maggot get ahead of Demon on the trail because his knee slows him down. He passes two people on the trail who say Fast Forward is still up at the waterfall with Big Bear Howe. When Demon gets to the waterfall, he finds Hammer screaming at Fast Forward that he wasn't fit to touch a hair on Emmy's head. Fast Forward is standing on a cliff above them, naked.

Several of the novel's primary themes come to a head during this scene. Hammer is on meth, which Maggot, who is addicted to drugs, gave to him. Demon has lost hope in the world because he has lost the people closest to him to drug addiction. He is also trying to support his surrogate family and community, the Peggots, but is doing so in a way that seems like it will only lead to destruction. And the conflict between Hammer and Fast Forward seems rooted in toxic masculinity, in Fast Forward's misogynistic treatment of women, including Emmy, and in Hammer's jealous and protective response, which leads him to violence.



Demon tries to get Hammer to calm down, but Hammer swings his rifle around to his shoulder. Big Bear yells at Fast Forward to get down because Hammer is going to shoot. Fast Forward tries to dive off the cliff but seems to slip. The contact sounds like “a watermelon on pavement.” Hammer yells at Demon that he wasn’t going to shoot Fast Forward; he was going to lay down his rifle. He says he won’t let anyone die and jumps into the water to swim to Fast Forward’s body. The water is rising, though, and sweeps Hammer away. Big Bear and Maggot run to get help. Demon can barely walk, so he stays behind. After they’re gone, he kicks Hammer’s rifle into the water. He then finds Hammer’s body and drags it onto a rock close to Fast Forward’s.

Hammer’s decision to jump in the water to try and save Fast Forward seems to prove that he’s telling the truth when he says he didn’t plan to shoot Fast Forward. Fast Forward’s death, then, seems like a horrible accident, and Hammer dies trying to fix that accident. The novel shows, then, how addiction, toxic masculinity, exploitation, and a desire to belong combine to lead to this ultimate moment of destruction. Demon is left, then, to literally and figuratively pick up the pieces that this moment of destruction has left in its wake.



CHAPTER 59

Demon gets taken down from the waterfall on a stretcher alongside Hammer and Fast Forward. The two bodies go in one ambulance, and Demon goes in another to be taken to the hospital and treated for exposure. Maggot rides with him in the ambulance. The next morning, Rose gets in to visit him by pretending she’s his sister. When she gets to Demon’s room, she calls him a “murderer.” She wants him to tell her exactly what happened, and he does. Rose says he and Demon are accessories to murder—not for Fast Forward’s death but Hammer’s—because they gave him drugs.

Even though Demon and Maggot have both lost Hammer in the same accident that claimed Fast Forward’s life, Rose wants to see both of them punished. The fact that Hammer was on drugs, then, becomes not just something that might have driven him to act more recklessly than usual: it becomes the central fact that Rose will use to try and make sure Demon and Maggot receive some kind of punishment, showing again the unpredictable and sprawling impact of addiction.



When he’s released from the hospital, Demon returns to Mrs. Peggot’s house. It falls on him to tell the Peggots how Hammer died. Maggot is too high to do it. When Demon talks about Hammer’s death, he leaves out the detail of the rifle and doesn’t say that Hammer went to Devil’s Bathtub to confront Fast Forward. Later, Mrs. Peggot gets a letter from the court, which says they are investigating the deaths. The authorities have information that Maggot supplied drugs to one of the people who died. They don’t mention murder, but Maggot could be charged with accessory to death. His court date is scheduled for the same week Mariah, his mother, will be released from prison.

The novel underlines the fact that so much of the addiction in the novel is the result of generational. Just as Demon became addicted to drugs like his mom was before him, Maggot follows in his mother’s footsteps when he goes to court and may be sent to prison. The novel argues that the similarities between Maggot, Demon, and their mothers are not coincidences. Instead, they are the result of the trauma one generation experienced being passed on to the next generation.



June tells Demon that she can get him enrolled in a Suboxone clinic. She says that after that, he’ll go into a halfway house. “It’ll be all work and no play, for a while,” June tells him. Demon realizes this is all he ever wanted: “a mother, simple as that.” She says that rehab will be in Knoxville and that she doesn’t want him to return to Lee County for a year. Demon says he’ll consider it, but he thinks that June knows he’s lying.

Demon has reached the lowest point of his life. Hammer and Fast Forward have both died, as have Dori and Demon’s mom. Again, community and a sense of belonging remain of paramount importance to Demon, as June, a member of his surrogate family, steps in with an offer to help him get clean and begin a new chapter in his life.



CHAPTER 60

Demon packs his things that same afternoon. He wakes Maggot up to tell him he's leaving. When Maggot asks where he's going, Demon says he's not sure yet. He gets into his car and starts driving without knowing where he's going. He pulls off the highway. When he sees a sign for Sand Cave, he decides to hike up to the cave, thinking walking might help. While he's walking, Demon thinks about the recent offer Angus received to go to "real college" in Nashville. He tries to find it in himself to be happy for her. He then settles down to sleep on the trail. If he makes it until morning, he decides he'll take June up on her offer to go to rehab.

Demon has reached an inflection point in his life. He doesn't know what he should do, only that he can't keep living the same way he has been. Fortunately, he still has a community willing to help, including June. The novel suggests that Demon has strong bonds with other people and has helped form a community because, despite his faults and struggles, he is always willing to be there for the people he cares about.



CHAPTER 61

Demon goes to rehab in Knoxville and then moves into a halfway house there. Demon thinks he had a "head start" on rehab because he was "well used to the no-toucher lifestyle before [he] started the program." Maggot goes to juvenile detention and stays there for two years. Now he's living with Mariah in Bristol, Tennessee. Demon has a job at a Walmart Supercenter. His friends, Viking, Gizmo, and Chartrain, are also in recovery. He keeps in contact with Tommy through e-mail. They plan to finish their 12-month contract to do comics at the newspaper once Demon feels up to it.

For the first time in his life, Demon starts to address his struggles with addiction and his past trauma directly. As a result, he can start a new chapter in his life. It's not an easy chapter, though, and Demon notes that he is discriminated against, too, as someone who has been through rehab and lives in a halfway house. He likens that discrimination to the ostracization he has previously faced, which he compares once more to Mr. Ghali's description of growing up as a Dalit in India. Notably, both Demon and Maggot had to move away from Lee County, their community, and their homes to get sober, highlighting the novel's commentary on how community can both positively and negatively impact people's lives.



CHAPTER 62

Lyra, a librarian, helps Demon study for the GED. He and Tommy work on the comic over email. Pinkie wants them to renew their contract for another year, but they decide not to. Instead, Tommy moves to Allentown, Pennsylvania, to be with his girlfriend. Demon starts his own online comic. It doesn't make any money for the first year, but then people start to buy subscriptions. Tommy tells Demon that he should write a graphic novel. Demon does. He calls it *High Ground* and puts chapters on his website once he finishes them. Before long, a publisher in New York contacts him about making those comics into a book. He wants to talk to Ms. Annie about the offer. He's been a "sober living resident" for three and a half years, but he's not sure if he's ready to go back to Lee County.

Demon's commitment to his sobriety leads to new career opportunities, including the possibility of publishing a graphic novel. Notably, those career opportunities don't come because Demon seeks them out: they come because, at this point in his life, he can devote himself more regularly to the work he loves. When he does that work, others start to notice. The novel continues its argument, then, that neither success nor sobriety is the result of miracles. Instead, one must steadfastly devote oneself to each (work and sobriety) to achieve one's goals.



CHAPTER 63

Demon decides to go back to Lee County to visit Ms. Annie, who is pregnant. He also tells June he's coming, but he doesn't tell anyone else. When he gets to Annie's house, he finds a note on the door saying they have gone to the hospital. He calls June, but she's busy with patients. He drives around aimlessly before ending up at the trail to Devil's Bathtub. He's not sure why he goes there, exactly, but he hikes up to the waterfall.

After more than three years of sobriety away from Lee County, Demon returns. When the two people he isn't worried about seeing—Ms. Annie and June—aren't around, he finds himself drawn to the site of one of the worst traumas he has experienced (the place where Fast Forward, Hammer, and his father all died), signaling that while Demon has made significant strides in his life, there are still aspects of his past that remain painful and unresolved. The difference now is that Demon is able to cope with those difficult emotions and stay sober.



When Demon eats breakfast with June the next morning, she tells him about lawsuits against drug companies she helped get off the ground. She also talks about Maggot and Mariah. They are both working at PetSmart, and Maggot has a boyfriend. June tells Demon about Emmy, too. She is living in an apartment in Asheville with people who are also in recovery. After breakfast, Demon decides to drive to Murder Valley. In Murder Valley, Betsy and Mr. Dick are excited and surprised to see him. Demon talks to them about Angus and asks if she has a boyfriend. Betsy says she has her “hunches about that,” but doesn't elaborate further.

June discusses lawsuits against pharmaceutical companies, mirroring the lawsuits that occurred in the real world (not the world of the novel) against companies like Purdue Pharma, the manufacturer of OxyContin and the Sackler family, the owners of Purdue Pharma at the time. Maggot, Emmy, and Demon all seem to have made their way to sobriety by leaving Lee County devoting themselves to maintaining that sobriety.



CHAPTER 64

The next morning, Demon goes to visit Coach. He resigned from the football team after the scandal and now lives in an apartment building in Norton. Next, Demon drives to Coach's old house, which Angus is trying to get in shape so they can sell it. Angus, who has recently graduated college, tells Demon that she's enrolled in an online program for social work and that she wants to work with kids. She says she's planning to stay in Lee County. It's almost Christmas, and Angus says she has a present for him. “I'm giving you **the ocean**,” she says. They decide to take Demon's car. On the drive, Demon realizes what Betsy was talking about. It seems that Angus is interested in *him*. The trip to the ocean, Demon thinks, is “possibly the best part of [his] life so far.”

When it's revealed that Angus loves Demon and Demon feels the same way, the novel suggests again that Demon has always had what he's always wanted. Before he left Lee County, he had a family, a community, and people who cared about him: he just didn't have the coping mechanisms to accept the help they were always willing to give him. The book ends on a happy note, though. Demon and Angus are on a trip to the ocean, a symbol of liberation and beauty for Demon, and the novel hints that they will reach the beach this time and that they will begin a happy relationship together.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

DeHaven, Ben. "*Demon Copperhead*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 12 Dec 2023. Web. 12 Dec 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

DeHaven, Ben. "*Demon Copperhead*." LitCharts LLC, December 12, 2023. Retrieved December 12, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/demon-copperhead>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Demon Copperhead* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Kingsolver, Barbara. *Demon Copperhead*. Harper. 2022.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Kingsolver, Barbara. *Demon Copperhead*. New York: Harper. 2022.